



good
nikki

arnica butler

GOOD NIKKI

A HOTWIFE NOVEL

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

He knew the look.

Nikki wasn't any good at hiding her excitement about anything.

She was even less skilled at hiding this very particular kind of excitement. It practically vibrated beneath her skin when she was on the receiving end of a lot of attention from men.

Sure, Nikki would deny that, if he asked her about it, or suggested it, however casually, in conversation.

"Don't be an idiot," she would say, smiling and rolling her eyes playfully.

There was a delicious mystery there: did *Nikki* believe her own lies? Was Nikki actually this clueless about men, and herself? Or was Nikki just flat-out lying when she pretended that *he* was seeing things?

A Pandora's box of possibilities unfurled from *there*: if Nikki was lying, why was she doing it? To cover up her sins? Or her guilt? Or to lay the groundwork for some possible future transgression?

The possibilities were endless.

One possibility that was *not* part of this endless set, though, was the possibility that Nikki just *didn't know* that she was as hot as she was.

That was just inconceivable.

When he met Nikki the very first time, she was decked out in her work gear and had blood splatters all over her plastic gown. Twenty-two, still pretty green, her sinewy curves all buttoned up in the shapeless navy paramedic uniform, her hair twisted up (ratcheted) into an all-business bun thing.

He could see (and so could anyone) that Nikki was one of those gals who would make PIC in no time, never show up late for work, never fuck up anything, and never tire of her job. She was determinedly un-makeupped, not like a lot of the girly-girl paramedics who had their hair in a blowout and lowered aviation glasses down their noses when they stepped out of the ambo, sizing the scene up less for hazards and more for potential mates.

Those girls were just there to find a cop or firefighter to hook up with, and they always cycled through in about three years – married off to the Officer Mulroneys of the world or packed up and sent to dispatch because they just couldn't hack it on the mean streets.

Not Nikki.

Nikki had all her PPE on like she was about to take a final test on it, *including* a traffic safety vest, which not even rookies actually wore, unless a supervisor was expected *and* it was close to a review. If someone had written her a script for patient handoffs and she had worked all night memorizing it, it couldn't have been any more textbook. She delivered her patient like she'd had a quiet room and forty minutes to get it all right. Her tourniquet was *clearly* labeled in her square, tidy handwriting. She had her chin jutted out like she didn't have time for anyone's shit.

All business, Nikki.

He would admit that he sought her out after that call, which wasn't something he was in the habit of doing. He'd been on the job for years by then, and he'd been down that road before and given up on it: dating a first responder - especially a paramedic - was a mug's game, especially if you, the man, were a paramedic, as opposed to a firefighter or a cop.

There was literally always a buffet of more masculine men around you - and therefore, around your lady friend - in that business. Even if you were a hot-shit version of a paramedic, which he was, it was a downer of a feeling you couldn't shake. Also, all paramedic conversations tended to gravitate to the gnarliest calls, the incessant shit-talking, the fattest people they'd ever had to load up with the help of the fire department. He didn't really need any more of *that* in his life. Paramedic wasn't a calling, it's just what he ended up doing after he ended up being sent down the medic stream in the military.

He was looking for a nice girl with literally *any other job* than first responder.

But he asked around about *her* after that call. Went to the bar where she was likely to be.

He didn't immediately see her when he strolled into the bar. Because with a hairdo like the one she'd had at work, and your lips pursed up and no time for jokes on the job, one expects a girl who is almost exactly the same off-duty as she was on-duty.

Maybe she would put her hair in a ponytail, and slap a little lip gloss and mascara on, and she'd be wearing a t-shirt and jeans instead of her fire-retardant, androgynous uniform. But Jack hadn't expected much change.

He walked right past her, in fact.

When she was *out*, Nikki evidently ditched the bun and let her wavy, glorious, all-natural cornfield-golden hair fall down around her shoulders. That night, she had taken a lot of smoke-colored shadowing to her eyes, and piled black mascara onto her long and slutty-thick eyelashes. Her green-gray eyes smoldered from inside this haze of smutty shadow, hovering over

a straight, somewhat oversized nose, that no one would ever notice anyway because of the shape of her mouth. Her lower lip was full, naturally pouty, and her upper lip was shaped like an archery bow, with an appealing, drastic slope that hinted at Slavic ancestry. She had painted these stunning lips an unexpected sultry pink. It was anybody's guess - and still was, if you asked Jack -if she had *consciously* chosen a shade that looked so much like raw, wet pussy.

Gone were the blues, replaced by a gray-green dress the color of her eyes, not especially short or slutty, but wrapped tightly to the long, trim length of her body. No tights, in November. A thick sliver of her thigh parted down the middle by the indentation of well-trained muscle, rolling beneath porcelain skin. Her jacket was caramel-colored suede, like her knee-high boots, and it set off the lowlights in her hair.

Jack had been at that bar mostly on recon, curious about the uptight paramedic from the MVA his team had been called to.

His head was pretty easily turned by the attractive creature she had converted into. He caught a glimpse of her eyes, fell into a deep well of disturbing, dirty thoughts thinking about her lips, and momentarily abandoned all efforts and thoughts related to the paramedic that had brought him *to* the bar.

He was, if he recalled correctly, already writing the gorgeous girl at the bar off as out of his league, though, when her arm shot out and her fingers closed around his bicep.

“Hey,” she said.

The voice was *hers*. The paramedic's. It was deep, had an interesting and sexy nasal quality to it, and poured out of her lips with delightful textures

and nodules attached to it. And yet, as unique as her voice was and as sure as he was that he was hearing the same soft-gritty whiskey he'd heard back at the scene, his brain couldn't connect the dots.

She looked back at him like he was an idiot.

"You're the air ambulance guy, right? From today?"

She was really excited. She dropped her straw into her drink and gave him a wide, love-inducing smile. "What are the fucking chances?"

And this was *so* Nikki:

That was it.

She really didn't think about it any more than that.

She didn't think about things like the fact that she was now jaw-on-the-floor, mouth-watering hot, and that she had looked like a tightly wrapped and parboiled schoolmarm at that scene. It didn't occur to her that he might not recognize her, and it also didn't occur to her -at all- that he might have come here *looking* for *her*. She didn't answer her own question ("what are the chances?"), because, if she had, she would have known they were pretty slim. Air ambulance was based on the other side of town: this wasn't their bar. At all. Everyone knew that.

It had taken a long time for him to get up the guts to ask her out. And the whole time, he had wondered if she was for real.

She *was* out of his league, but she never seemed to figure that out.

Jack had been waiting, since the day he met her, for her *to* figure it out.

He had expected it before their marriage, but she showed up smiling and covered in lace and said her vows. She had two kids with him, and while

their sex life had gone from steamy to mundane over the years, it had followed the same course as everyone else's. Nikki never figured out, somehow, that she was a near perfect-ten with a near-average husband.

And all the while, Nikki had only gotten sexier, and yet she never really seemed to key in on her sexual prowess.

"Uh-oh," he said, when she barged through the door far later than she should have come home. He always said this if it seemed like Nikki'd had too much to drink, or had gone out with her friends. Nikki probably never noticed the faint hint of excitement beneath this declaration. The thrilling flame of possibilities that he couldn't extinguish.

She was flushed with an extra glass of wine, which seemed to go straight to her cheeks, where it spread as a pink stain slightly under her cheekbones, in patches. Jack found this flush wildly alluring, but he never mentioned it to her anymore because *she* found it annoying. ("It looks like I'm a four-year-old and I got into my mom's makeup bag," she would whine, and then spend the next few minutes assessing herself in the mirror and rubbing her face, saying "*God*.")

All-business Nikki didn't have time to play Jack's games. Nikki didn't even really know about Jack's games, because he kept them all inside his head and locked away. He liked to ask her probing questions whenever she had obviously been out with her crew and run into a lot of guys: he liked skirting around the deep lake of perverted thoughts he fantasized about. Thoughts of Nikki one day realizing how hot she was, pondering her mundane husband and sex life in suburbia, and then just going full-out nuts with every guy she met.

They would all be game. Jack knew that much.

It was therefore only Nikki keeping Nikki in line, and Jack wondered endlessly and incessantly if that was because Nikki was clueless, or because she was actually faithful.

He liked to sink his teeth right into the bittersweet horror of those thoughts.

He was cleaning up dinner when she came home, wearing a fucking apron of all things.

Nikki had texted him that she was going out that night after shift, and she really wasn't that late - nine-thirty, and so there was no way anything *untoward* had taken place. But it gave Jack a little thrill anyway, because Nikki had the flush, and she was bright-eyed and excited in a way that perhaps she didn't even know she only got when she hung out with a bunch of guys at the bar.

She was a little tipsy, too.

"Guess *what?*" she asked, plopping onto a bar stool and folding her arms over each other. She hadn't taken off her leather jacket yet. Jack assessed her appearance: she had her hair up in a ponytail, and her makeup looked about like he'd have expected if she had touched it up after shift and then had a few drinks. She was wearing tight, dark jeans and a simple green shirt that clung to her small but shapely breasts.

"You ran into a whole house of cadets and showed them a great time," Jack suggested, indulging in his own fantasy. It was the kind of safe fantasy that would likely never come to pass in real life, if only because the fire guys were probably the most sexually conservative straight-shooters in emergency services, and a gangbang was just not in the cards with a crowd like that.

"No," Nikki said, completely ignoring, as always, his joke. "We ran into a bunch of *cops*."

And then Nikki did the thing she did, which Jack could never tell if it was purposeful or not, and left a big chunk of airtime out there. Airtime for Jack to take that declaration and run wild with it in his mind.

So this was another question he liked to nibble at, juicy and full of crispy fat:

Did Nikki do stuff like this on purpose?

He'd asked her before about this very same kind of pause. She'd looked at him like he had three heads. Like she didn't even know what he was talking about. "What pause is this?" she would ask him, and she was either the world's greatest actress or genuinely befuddled. "After *what*? What are you *talking about*?"

But *cops*. That was a different story.

Jack waited, because Nikki obviously had more to say. His cock twitched a little, coming to life as his mind went down the well-worn path of imagining Nikki with her lips around some huge guy's dick.

"They were in some tactical team," Nikki continued, after the dramatic pause, "and guess what?" She balled her fists up with excitement.

Probably not the same excitement that Jack was feeling, but a man could dream.

"They're looking for recruits. They told me all about it. Well, not them, specifically, but the PD. It's for this special on-call tactical team that goes in with them to like, raids and stuff like that."

Jack stopped what he was doing and looked up at Nikki over the marble counter-top and the kitchen sponge.

Genuine alarm was now pouring into his fantasy. "Say what?"

Nikki balanced herself on the stool, her feet up and her torso leaning back, which was something she did when she was *quite* tipsy. "It's *so cool*. And these guys, like, you know how most cops are such meat-heads? That's because we only run into the beat cops, who *are* all total idiots. These guys were really cool. They had a good vibe going, you know? It was still a cop vibe, but it was more like... I don't know. More like firefighters. And guess what? I totally qualify and it's not even all that much training, and the training's paid anyway, and I also would get a stipend, and probably a new partner, which, honestly - *you* know I wouldn't be sad about -*God already* with Trevor - and then I'd also get bumped to get placed downtown, and it's *even cooler* because the physical test you have to pass is pretty hard, and I wanted to get back into working out..."

Nikki rattled on like this, in her usual way, leaping from thought to random thought, giddy with excitement.

Nikki *loved* excitement.

Jack was still thinking about the cops, studiously staring at the sponge in his hand, wiping the clean surface of the counter over and over again, a superheated thrill washing out to his limbs from the center of his being.

And terror.

Also terror.

"That sounds... very unsafe," he said, when Nikki finally came up for air.

"Uggggghhhhhh!" Nikki said, her fists balled up again. She was feigning frustration, looking at the ceiling, her mouth contorted into a comical and charming grin-frown. "I *knew* you would say that. I *knew* that would be the first thing you said."

She pulled her phone out of her pocket and started typing a text message with two thumbs. She curled over herself on the stool, giving her a very adolescent appearance that Jack was slightly ashamed to say he also found very hot.

"What's that?" he asked, looking at her phone.

"Just telling Rashawn about you saying that, because I owe her a drink now."

"Why do you owe *her* a drink?"

Nikki tucked her phone in her pocket and grinned at Jack. "Because *she* said you'd say that before I got the chance to. And *I* defended your honor." She pointed a thumb back at herself.

"Listen," she said, sliding her arms on the counter and interlacing her fingers before spreading her hands out, palms down. "It's statistically much safer than just regular calls. Okay?"

Jack sniffed in order not to laugh. "Oh yeah. How's that?"

Nikki tossed her hair. "Because they already *know* that shots are being fired and you already *have* your vest and helmet on, and the cops are already *there*, and you go in the middle of the like, SWAT team and they stand around shooting at people *for* you." She smiled. "Silly."

"I fail to see how that's safer than hauling some old lady out of bed for dialysis."

"That's because *you* are a -" Nikki cut herself off before she said something that she seemed to sense bothered Jack: *desk-medic*. "You haven't been out on the streets in a while, Jack. It's mayhem and murder from here to High Park."

"Mostly in High Park, though," Jack countered.

"...I'd appreciate having a tactical team with me, actually, every day. At least a beat cop. Somebody with a gun."

A pit was developing in Jack's stomach: Nikki was really hitting all his fantasies and tender nightmares out of the park.

"God." Nikki adopted the look she got when she was about to change tactics. "You know this is the kind of thing that would *never* happen. I'd *never* get called. Or I'd get called and all set up to go and they wouldn't even go."

This was, in fact, *probably* true. All special teams were pretty much like that, except for air ambulance.

Jack looked at her, pausing his now-unnecessary and violent cleaning of the counter. "Then it seems like sort of a silly thing to spend time training to do."

"Ugh! So what? It's just the cops spending their money, and now we get some of it." She ended this thought with a cheery smile and a shake of her head, like she was certain she had scored a game-winning goal.

"Mmm. Did the factory run out of military-grade weapons and Humvees?"

Nikki shrugged, taking the comment less as a joke and more as a legitimate question. "Beats me. All I know is this - are you ready for it? It's a 10k stipend, *super* pay - like super-duper double-time-danger-pay if you

actually go on a call - paid training, and it pays better than my stat pay - *and* I get combat medic training, which is *awesome*." She stood up and held her hands out before letting them drop to her sides. "What's not to love?"

"Getting shot?"

Nikki smiled and reached across the counter to squeeze his chin. "That's already a 'con' in my current job category, honey. Mayhem. And murder. Here to High Park." She gestured theatrically in the opposite direction of High Park, which seemed like a joke because Nikki detested when people pointed in the wrong direction, even from the lowest level of a subterranean garage where no-one had any idea which way was north.

"I think I wanna do it," she told him, heading over to the bag she'd dumped unceremoniously on the floor. "Let me at least apply."

Jack placed both hands on the edge of the counter and hoped he looked authoritative. "And does your husband get any say in this?"

Nikki was sifting through her bag, smiling. She pretty much ignored the question, which was also typically Nikki. Jack was sure this was because she knew the score: in the end, there was almost nothing she "couldn't" do because Jack said so.

All she had to do was pout, and he would become helpless and agree to whatever she wanted.

So they usually skipped that step.

"Look," she said, her business voice coming into play. "It's really competitive, and so I probably won't even get selected," her voice took a sudden turn, from consoling to argumentative. "But I have an 'in' with these guys now - I wouldn't have even known about it otherwise, they don't even

have to advertise it - and so it would be a total *waste* if I didn't at least *apply*." She looked at him, watching how her plea was sinking in.

"And you want to do this *why*?"

Nikki stood still, her mouth slightly open, and offered him a slow blink. The question was incomprehensible to her. "*Seriously?*"

"I mean, I get it," Jack began, feeling a little more daring than usual. "You get to hang out with a bunch of big tough guys with huge biceps -"

"Oh my *God*," Nikki said, rolling her eyes. She dropped her shoulders and slumped energetically, staring skyward.

It was not the first time he had twisted a conversation of this type into this sort of comment. And it wasn't the first time Nikki had rolled her eyes at him.

But it was the first time she had ever done *this*:

"They're *cops*, Jack. They're... you know," she pantomimed a huge belly, puffed her cheeks out, and waddled in place.

None of which was particularly helpful to her cause, because to Jack it came across as a pregnant woman, a blow job, and the way his wife would be walking after she had sex with all of them in a testosterone-and-adrenaline fueled orgy of blood and lust after a "raid."

"Pregnant?" he offered.

Nikki laughed at this, which was probably good. She rolled her eyes again and tossed the bag on the floor, having apparently located what she wanted in it. "Overweight frat boys with guns," she corrected. And then she yawned. "Look. This is a lot. I don't have all the details, either. So I'm going

to take a shower, and you can just... you know, think about it." She stalked toward the hallway. "But I am at least going to *apply* in the meantime."

"Nikki..." he said, without putting much effort into it, because he knew he had already lost. His mind was already drifting to the potential positives of this latest development in Nikki's career, and he was still chewing on this final statement of hers, which really didn't square with the *type* of cops she'd described meeting.

Tactical team cops were usually built less like donut-stuffing beat cops and more like soldiers.

And Nikki never, *ever* took any pains to describe any of the men she came into contact with - even the very obviously overweight frat boys - in a negative light like that. It was one of the reasons Jack wondered about her so much: she truly never seemed to even consider any of these people as potential lovers. She therefore never bothered describing them at all.

But *this*.

This was new.

And it was probably a fib.

Which was also new from Nikki.

Interesting.

"The deadline is tomorrow!" she shouted back at him as she headed upstairs. He heard her lobbing greetings and questions about the day in the direction of the kids' rooms, from which no reply emanated.

*

"So seriously," he began, walking into the room about half an hour later. He had come up with all sorts of reasonable arguments for Nikki about her plan: it would take time away from the family, it was dangerous, etc., but none of them were especially case-closing.

Especially since the money *would* be better (hurting nothing, truth be told), Nikki *had* been looking for something more exciting to do, it was probably an excellent career move, and she was right - it was unlikely that she would ever end up on more than one call of this type.

And if she did, she would probably, technically, be safer than plenty of calls she went on in her regular work, because the police would already be there.

Nikki was lying on the bed, wrapped in only a towel, though, and so his plans dissolved in the fleshy tones of her long legs and the shadowy secrets beneath the edge of the towel between her thighs.

He changed course.

"... you aren't signing up for this just to sweat and shoot guns with a bunch of sexy man-children, by any chance?"

Nikki was typing on her laptop, lying on her stomach. Her hair was wet and piled on her head haphazardly, something she did to make her waves "coalesce" as she said, which was a peculiar choice on a work night. "*Well*," she said.

Her voice had a teasing tone.

Which really wasn't very Nikki at all.

Jack could feel his cock getting turgid, lengthening and kicking against his boxers and sweats.

"Ooooh," he said, feigning benign interest, but experiencing a rush of blood to his head and a quickening of his pulse. "So it *is* about that. I see. Hmm."

He climbed onto the bed at the foot, putting one knee down and then the other, waiting for Nikki to snap her head around and look at him like he was a crazy person, right before clarifying that she didn't want any funny business because she had to be at the station at 6am.

But she didn't.

She just grinned and kept at whatever she was doing. Jack glanced at the screen. It looked like the application.

He let his hand drop to Nikki's smooth, toned calf, and when she just kicked her foot playfully, he moved his hand up to her knee, and then her upper thigh.

Still no shut-down from Nikki.

He moved his hand along her inner thigh, poised in a stance that he could spring back from when Nikki swatted him away.

His fingertips made it all the way to the shadow cast by the towel on her legs, and when he got there, he hesitated. It was actually hair-raising, not because Nikki *never* gave in to his advances, but because she almost never did on a weeknight.

The timing was, on the whole... *suspicious*.

Deliciously suspicious.

Nikki looked over her shoulder and lifted the leg he was not groping to slide her pretty toe - she didn't paint her fingernails, for obvious reasons, but she did take time to get pedicures and keep her toes perfect, even in the dead of winter when her feet were almost never bare - against his shoulder.

It was a *fetching, come-hither* look.

Jack might have sensed danger, but he was a man sensing danger with his fingers just inches from her glorious pussy, so he did what any man would do, and carried on, sliding his fingers into the warm and humid shadows between Nikki's legs.

They had been married for almost sixteen years by then, so sex on weeknights (and plenty of weekends) was a vanishingly rare occurrence. It wasn't something Jack normally attempted, and Nikki wasn't usually an instigator. As his fingers continued, unimpeded by Nikki in any way - she didn't wriggle away or snap her strong thighs together on his hand, or say something about being tired - he hesitated, unsure of what, exactly, was happening. When his fingertips brushed over the tidy thatch of feathery hair that trimmed her pussy, and he felt her slippery wetness, he froze.

He looked at her face. Her head was turned slightly to the side, her eyes unfocused and heavy-lidded, her lips damp and parted slightly. With renewed confidence, he slid his pointer finger into her folds and over her clit, which was swollen with arousal.

Not being able to "help himself" was one of those things that Nikki was always complaining about, and it rankled him a little because it was a true indictment (in the sense that it was basically true). He was a man who had managed to keep a woman far out of his league married to him for sixteen years, and he was, at that very moment, on the verge of having sex with her.

On a weeknight.

A man with some sense might have surveyed all that he had before him, literally at his fingertips, and count himself lucky, and shut up.

But Jack could sense that he was not such a sensible man. He reveled a moment in the way that the touch of his finger against her clit sent a shudder - almost imperceptible, light and airy - through her body.

And he just couldn't help himself.

"Hmm," he said, moving his finger from her clit to the opening of her pussy, imagining it in his mind, a place of flesh and sweet-smelling nectar that was, and had been for almost two decades, the thing he thought most about in the entire universe. She was sodden, and his pointer finger slipped in easily, so he worked his middle finger in as well. Her hot, velvety flesh encased his fingers to the first knuckle, and Nikki squirmed, exhaling.

"Hanging out with all those cops seems to have turned you on."

The better angels of his nature frowned upon him, shaking their heads. *You just blew it*, one of them whispered to him.

This wasn't the first time Jack had tried to work a little snippet of his fantasies into reality. It had failed horribly on almost every occasion. Nikki's reactions had varied from brushing it off (best possible outcome) to kicking at him furiously and asking what the *hell* something like that was supposed to mean (worst-case... so far).

So as soon as he said it, his heart dropped, and he was already willing his hand to stop, to pull out before Nikki squeezed him between her legs and wrenched his arm as she rolled over to read him the riot act.

Since he had never been expecting this to go all the way, he didn't feel consumed by disappointment. He was actually looking forward to it. It pressed on perverse, deeply hidden buttons in his psyche.

Nikki, however, opened her eyes and looked at the wall in her direct line of vision, a wistful, incomprehensible look on her face for what seemed like an eternity. A very slight, but real, smile turned the corners of her mouth upward.

"Hmm," she purred, her voice sexy and low. "Maybe it *did*."

Her words impacted him like a giant block of ice right to the chest. For a full second, his body felt flash-frozen, and he was paralyzed, his fingers inert in the hot liquid of her pussy.

Nikki couldn't have had any way to read his mind. He could be sure of that. And it wasn't like he went around voicing these fantasies to her, or anyone, for that matter.

His thoughts raced around, trying to think of something that might have given away his darkest thoughts: a web history? a porn site? What?

But this was fantasy so dark, so deeply buried, that he didn't even really get into it in the real world outside his own head. Porn couldn't imitate what he specifically wanted: no matter how much a girl might look like Nikki, there was no way to replicate her exactly, and so the punch that was at the center of his desires (to see her open her mouth for another man's cock) was never delivered.

His only "sin" was occasionally venturing to a Reddit community about cuckolding, which had led him to a Reddit community about hotwifing, which had spun such tales of wives who indulged in their husband's fantasies as to come across as completely unbelievable. He hadn't been back in years, and even when he had gone there, he only lurked.

There was no record of this that Nikki could ever - or would ever - go searching for. She didn't even care about porn, and she was no internet

junkie. Nikki was the kind of person who confused Instagram with Tinder, didn't know what Reddit was exactly, and had no idea that search histories existed, let alone how to look one up.

All of this thinking took place within seconds. Instinct took over; a primal, primordial part of his brain connected the fact that his fingers were in his wife's pussy and relayed the information directly to his body, bypassing his brain.

He moved in, lying down next to her, pleased as she rolled to the side and turned her interest to him instead of the computer. His hand was still beneath the towel, playing with the folds of her pussy. As she rolled on her hip, his fingers slipped away from her slit, but the towel loosened and parted along her side, revealing a lengthy slice of pale, damp skin, and the lean curves of her right breast, the taut flesh along her ribcage, the intersecting, rounded angles of her hip bone and her thigh.

He moved his right hand to her computer, slowly closing it - so that when she objected, annoyed, there would be time for her to open it back up or snatch it away from him. But Nikki didn't return her eyes to the computer: she let him fold it in half until it clicked shut, a faint smile on her lips. A sequence of barely noticeable movements played out on her face: the slight cocking of her eyebrow, a tremble in her lips, a gleam in her eyes, which moved to his jaw along with her fingers. She stroked the unshaven scruff that had come in because he'd skipped shaving for two days, and grinned, watching her fingers on his jawline. "Speaking of *manly*," she said softly, leaning in to brush her cheek against his. "I like *this*."

"You do, huh?" Jack asked, happily playing along. He pushed the towel open, and wet heat rose up from her body, scented with soap. Riding along behind this moist cloud was the sweet scent of her pussy.

Nikki moved her mouth over his lips, teasing him, and then rolled easily as he nudged her over onto her back, making sure to grasp the edge of the towel so that it fell away from her body.

"I do," Nikki said, applying the tiniest bit of pressure on his head. An invitation, subtle and tenuous, which he embraced with wild abandon. He dragged his chin and jaw along her skin as he moved down from her mouth, over her neck, caressing her silky skin with his lips. His hands moved over her body, seeking out places he couldn't attend to with his mouth as he moved down, lifting his leg to get on top of her. The pressure of Nikki's fingers in his hair was electrifying - faint but insistent, always pushing him further down.

She watched him, her eyes bright and attentive, as he moved between her legs, which she had already opened for him - lengthening out first in a long, feline stretch with her legs together and moving them apart gracefully, like tendrils.

She watched him as he brushed his jaw deliberately over her thighs, pleasure simmering in her eyes, turning the surface slowly glassy and distant when his tongue wriggled into the sodden petals of her pussy, flicking at her clit, which was swollen and hard, easy to lap at. She seized his head with both hands as he worked steadily on her, watching conscious thought ebb slowly away from her expression, her stomach muscles rolling in tense waves as he brought her closer to climax.

The moments that he would commit to memory, and to the film that he would play for himself when he jerked off, came when Nikki arched her back, pushing her hot pussy into his mouth, and closed her eyes. Her body was stiff and violent in his hands, which he had moved to cup her ass, and

he was rewarded with a burst of hot, tangy juices when she came, her fingers digging into his hair.

What did Nikki think about in those final moments, when she closed her eyes and also his window into her mind, just before she came? The same thing that had made her pussy wet before he had even come into the room?

It couldn't be him - not *just* him - because she had been simmering just below a boil when he walked in there. And so, as she squirmed in his hands, mashing the unreal silk of her pussy against his face, dripping onto his chin and even one fat, slow-moving bead of cum that rolled down to his throat - she *had* to be thinking of something else. Someone else. Men with guns, and danger all around.

When Nikki came, she usually opened her mouth and eyes wide, her whole body seizing up for a moment before dissolving into dozens of separate ripples of trembling pleasure that spread out from her core to her limbs, until it rattled away in a flutter of her fingertips and toes. She exhaled then, a sharp "hhhhah," from deep in her lungs, and then collapsed, totally limp.

And it was then that Jack stood up, tugging at his shirt, freeing himself from his clothes, scurrying backward to kick the door closed, all at once. Nikki was sprawled on the bed, her arms flung to the side, her head tipped into a pillow that she seemed to have bitten. He admired this view as he moved in, his cock in his hand (force of habit, age requiring him to check on the status of his erection most of the time), pleased to find his cock as thick and rigid as if he was eighteen again.

Nikki's breasts, small and resiliently perky after two children, spread a little, like slightly flattened teardrops, her pink nipples that reminded him of fat erasers at the end of a big pencil, were hard and enticing. Nikki's always

carefully trimmed landing strip of unusually silky, fine blond hair glistened with her juices, and her gash earned the slang term - her pink flesh was swollen and wet, beckoning him to enter her.

They hardly ever did this - this choreography - but it was what Jack liked best. To feel Nikki erupt, to watch her eyes become glassy with pleasure, to see her shudder and mewl, and then to enter her body, almost like an act of worship.

She mewled as he slid inside her, the heat of her body swallowing him, and she wriggled and shuddered, her pussy still raw. That was what he liked best, and it took almost all his willpower to fuck her slowly until he felt the change inside her - felt her cross over from enduring his attentions, to wanting to come again.

Best of all, though, was that tonight Nikki's consciousness never reactivated: her eyes never came back to meet his, her thoughts never drifted back into the room with him. She looked at him as he fucked her to her second orgasm, as he came inside her hot pussy, but behind her dilated pupils, her thoughts swam darkly beneath the surface, unreadable and unknowable. He had only to think for an instant about what they could be - the superimposition of another man's face over his, a whole fantasy she played out inside her own head, desires for a bigger cock to stretch her out and bump against the deepest parts of her body... who could know?

But once he came, and rolled over to stare at the ceiling with her, he emerged from his own fantasy and decided to leave well enough alone. He may have wanted to keep probing, to see if he could peel away to the soft, dirty center of Nikki's mind.

But he also wasn't an idiot, and he also just got laid.

Nikki lifted her hands and looked at them as she floated them above her face, outstretched. It was a typical Nikki gesture, something she always did and probably didn't know about. She twisted her hands together and folded them to her chest in a girlish gesture, like she always did before she rolled toward him and kissed his shoulder.

"Okay," she said, after kissing him. She pushed against his shoulder with both hands, shoving him to the side. Nikki might have been a small-ish woman, and in her thirties, but she was strong as hell. "Get outta here, I gotta finish the application."

He groaned and refused to be moved, so Nikki walked her feet up his right leg, until both of them were on his hip, and she was folded nearly in half, and started shoving with her legs.

There was no fighting against that. His hips went sideways and Nikki laughed, scooting forward with him, shoving him again, until his feet went off the side of the bed and he had no choice but to roll toward her and climb on top of her, or he was going to end up on his ass.

Nikki laughed, and played along, squealing delightfully. Jack was pleasantly surprised to feel his cock pulsing back to life - it wasn't unheard of (something about wrestling with a naked woman, for whatever reason, always got his dick hard) - but it gave him a little flare of pride. He was, after all, in his forties, and he had just had sex.

"No, no, noooooo!" Nikki squealed, when he made a move that she deemed more amorous than playful. She slapped weakly at his back and kicked her legs, scissoring them to get out from under him and keep him from launching a fresh assault. "I have to finish this, horn-dog!"

She rolled onto her stomach and reached for the computer that had ended up tipped half onto her night table, precariously perched and ready to fall, settled in on her elbows, and tossed her hair over her shoulder. It landed with a wet splat and she lifted a hand to her head, feeling around for the damage that had been done to her wave technique.

"Shit," she said. "You messed my hair up."

She swung one of her feet toward him as he made one more half-hearted attempt to lure her back into sex - even he knew this was unrealistic at this point, probably for him more than her - and grinned. "Seriously, Jack."

He rolled away, still pleased with himself, and off the bed, heading to the bathroom. "Right, gotcha," he said. "Gotta fill out your application to go roll around on the floor with the tactical guys."

He looked over his shoulder as he rose. Nikki had pulled up the application and was focused on it intently. She grinned, but her attention was clearly divided as she murmured, sexily: "Exactly."

CHAPTER 2

But like so many fortuitous sexual encounters, especially the ones where Jack got a whiff of his own fantasies passing by, like a hint of perfume in the air, this one came and went and never turned into anything more.

Almost a month went by, and he didn't hear any more about the tactical team program.

He wanted to ask - he was dying to know, and half-wished she would get the position, just to fuel his fantasies. But Nikki was the type to very aggressively *not* talk about things she hadn't succeeded at, so he didn't bring it up. He didn't dare.

It wasn't like there were no distractions, either. He may have changed to what his colleagues, and Nikki, and pretty much anybody in emergency services derisively sneered at as a "desk job," but in reality, he had a ton more work and spent plenty of time "in the field" for it. At least it had typical working hours, which was his main reason for taking it when it was offered to him.

Nikki worked the insane shifts, and they had gotten longer and less predictable because of the pandemic. Everyone in the house was used to it by then, but it still made having time to have a decent conversation almost impossible. Their occasional, mutually free weekends were usually a flurry of errands and shuttling their kids around, perhaps a stressful barbecue with friends, almost all of whom were first responders and ended up talking shop no matter what they did - and talking shop in that line of work usually involved dredging up the most disgusting - gnarly or otherwise - calls they

had been on since they'd last seen each other. Not exactly the superhighway to hot sex.

So it hit him over the head when Nikki's alarm blared at 6am on a Saturday morning. He had gotten into the beers himself with some buddies from work because the kids were staying with friends and Nikki had the Saturday off. It was a really fortuitous aligning of schedules and events that he had been fantasizing about since he had figured it all out on the calendar.

Specifically, he had envisioned a lazy morning in bed. Waking up around eight, which would be some deep sleeping for either of them, and then rolling over and burrowing into his wife for some unimaginative sex.

Instead, he was getting pounded by an alarm.

"What. The. Hell," he grumbled, pulling a pillow over his head.

Nikki sprang into action, though, instead of her usual routine of slapping her phone silly and tossing it into the laundry basket when she forgot to change her alarms, which was often. She sat up, and the mattress bounced a little as she pretty much bounced out of bed.

Jack lifted his torso and pulled away the pillow. Nikki was hopping around in the semi-darkness, like a bunny, picking things up as she found them (they weren't the tidiest people in the world on Friday nights). She didn't notice him.

"What are you *doing*?" he groaned. "It's *Saturday*." He threw his arms out and fell onto his back with another, exaggerated groan.

"Sorry!" Nikki whisper-yelled. "I'm... oh, sorry, I didn't mean to wake you up. I gotta go."

Jack groaned again. "Ugh. Did you pick up somebody's *shift*?" he complained. His blood pressure started rising a little.

Nikki had a hard time saying "no," at least to work, and this exact same scenario caused more than the occasional marital dispute.

He was *not* going to let it get to him.

Nikki almost stopped his heart by bouncing on the bed, straddling him. He snapped his eyes open when her soft body sank onto his hips. "I'm sorry," she said, leaning down to kiss him on the cheek.

Which was not, at all, what he was interested in at this point. He reached for her hips, but she was too speedy. She was already bouncing away, off the bed and into the bathroom.

"I was going to sneak out and be back before you even woke up," she whisper-yelled, leaning back into the doorway after hopping into the bathroom.

"Where are you *going*?" Jack moaned. He pulled the pillow over his face again.

Jesus, his wife could really be nuts sometimes.

A colleague - a battle-axe of a sixty-year-old paramedic who had been reassigned to dispatch (because she had developed what could only be called a blatant apathy for doing her job), had a nickname for Nikki. Francis Rogers (who, in a cruel twist of fate, could not say her "r's" and therefore mauled her own name, and who also had a terrible memory for phrases and usually substituted a word with *more* r's in it than the correct original) had anointed Nikki the "Enewgizuh Wabbit."

"Gym," Nikki said. She had already found a toothbrush and was applying toothpaste to it with the kind of weird, carefully calibrated precision that all paramedics with more than a decade on the job seemed to apply to measurement of everything. She shoveled it in her mouth and began brushing furiously. "Gah-ah geh in shay or ya draining."

Jack pushed the pillow off his face. "Huh?"

But Nikki had already disappeared into the en-suite bathroom, and he heard the shower starting.

Why was the woman taking a shower before going to the gym?

Why was she going to the gym at 6am on a Saturday morning when she didn't have to work?

He sat up and put his feet on the floor. Condensation began to gather at the top edges of the large mirror that ran along the sinks.

"Babe," he said, plodding into the bathroom. Nikki was in the shower, doing her usual thing of contorting her body to shave off a rogue bit of leg hair. Jack lost his train of thought completely because of the nice view, which afforded him an opportunity to look at both her ass and one long, outstretched leg.

"I really am sorry," she repeated, when she saw him.

And then she plastered herself to the glass, pressing her perfect breasts against it and mashing them into very appealing pancakes. Her thighs stuck to the condensation to make slippery, soapy cylinders of flesh, and she pressed her lips to the glass in a smooch.

Jack's eyes were mostly trained on her slit, which hovered in a dense foggy haze just out of sight.

His mouth fell open and his mind was swept clear of thoughts.

Nikki never did anything like that.

Nikki was playful and fun, and sexy as hell, but she treated these components of her persona like an epoxy glue that should always be kept separate. Nikki did not simply press her body to the shower door and smooch it.

"I'll make it up to you."

Jack's erection, which had been stumbling to life in its usual morning way, was immediately full and at the ready.

"Hmm," he said, walking toward the shower door. "I like the sound of that."

Nikki's hand snapped to the door handle. "*Not* now," she said.

Jack tried anyway.

Strange things were afoot in his household, and they had a sexual vibe, so what was he supposed to do?

Nikki telling him "not now" was nothing new under the sun. Nikki told him that at least three times a week. And at least three times a week, he soldiered on anyway, because he had discovered that his chances of "convincing" Nikki that now was as good of a time as any, were approximately fifty-fifty.

What Nikki did *not* do, in response to his dogged attempts, was *giggle* and go about her business. "*Seriously*," she said.

But she smiled.

Jack arched his eyebrows.

"I texted you about this," she said, punching the water off violently. She pulled a towel she'd draped over the door down and started toweling off, which Jack watched with interest. "You even said, 'okay.' Remember?"

"I do not," he admitted.

But it sounded like something he'd write while drunk at the bar and forget about.

He scratched his head and stepped back so Nikki could get out. "Why, again, are you going to the gym this early? On a Saturday?"

Nikki stopped right in front of him and looked up at him, blinking slowly, annoyed. Jack tried hard to keep his attention on her face, and not on the appealing drop of water that was swelling on her chest, just above the shallow valley between her breasts, and would, any second, grow fat and spill sexily into a rivulet that would travel down to her navel. He was already thinking of the small pool of water that would form there, if he could just get her to lie down and let him suck it out of her belly-button.

Nikki became exasperated. "It's my team for training... for *training*. I *told you* about this."

"Oh," he said. "Right."

She patted him on the cheek. "Nice try," she said, and tried to bank right. He caught her hand in his and tried to move it down.

He didn't really have a plan with that, except to get her hand in the general area of his body that he cared the most about at the moment.

Nikki, whose wrists were abnormally slender, easily wrested herself from his loose grip and hopped into the bedroom. "I gotta go," she hissed.

Her tone, however, was still friendly.

Sensing some small degree of opportunity that might still be floating in the air, Jack followed her and sat on the bed to watch her toss things out of her dresser.

Nikki was a circumspect, meticulous paramedic. Her bag was always packed like it had just come off the production line, and she had such a reputation at Beth Sinai for being a tidy paramedic that the ER staff once identified her ambulance from a mud-covered pile-up of them at the ER after a mass casualty event - by its level of conspicuous tidiness on the interior, despite having brought in a bloody as hell trauma victim.

Her job seemed to consume every last ounce of this tendency, though, because at home she was a total maniac.

Clothing of all different types came out of the same drawer in a blizzard of silk and colors, socks and blouses, and, for some reason, an arm brace. Several band-aids were tossed into the air and fluttered to the floor like confetti.

She let the towel drop to the floor and stepped into a pair of very practical sport underwear (still sexy), and Jack reached for her appealing bottom. She slapped at his hand. "*Jackson*," she complained. "I'm serious. I gotta be there by seven."

"Hmm," he said, not really listening.

Nikki twisted away from him and pulled a sports bra on, then leaned over to snatch an article of clothing from the dresser while remaining just out of his reach. Her eyes were hawk-like, picking over his expression.

He knew that look.

He was in trouble for not having listened to something.

"And what *gym* are you going to, anyway?" he asked, feeling suddenly sour and defensive.

"*The gym.*"

Nikki was based at a brand-new emergency services base, which included the fire department and had fueled, as such, numerous fantasies for Jack. It also had a top-notch gym. Because firefighters.

"Oh," he said, falling back on an old joke. "You want to go sweat with the guys from C-shift. Gotcha."

Nikki was squirming, very seductively, if you asked Jack, into her most sexy leggings. She paused mid-squirm to glare at him. Then she continued pulling on the tight fabric, spreading it over her skin and forming a Lycra work of art. "You serious right now?" she asked.

It was not a particularly hostile question, and she seemed amused more than anything. But it was a warning shot to Jack's ears.

He was definitely missing a key piece of information.

Nikki sighed at him, exasperated again, and swatted him with a pair of her sexiest underwear, which he attempted, and failed, to grab. "Anyway," she said, "I'll be back by lunchtime. Go back to bed."

He made his move, shooting his hands out to grab her by the knees. "I would *love* to go back to bed," he began.

"Nope," Nikki said, wriggling away. She somehow found a shirt as she hopped out of the room like a *wabbit*. "I'm late." She stopped at the door and blew him a kiss. "Toodles."

*

There was no going back to sleep for a man like Jack, who drank a little too much and was in his forties. He tried anyway, gave up after fifteen minutes, and then he got in the shower to jerk off.

It smelled like a damp, flowery Nikki in there, which was added assistance to what was not a particularly difficult task. He mostly used the image of her naked body pressed up against the glass, her lips smashed and obscene.

He peppered this visual with a few dark thoughts about his wife at the ES base, sweating in her Lycra get-up, while some bulky firefighters looked on with their huge cocks clearly pressed up against... their station wear.

This was, of course, an utterly absurd visual, because the fire department in question had at least one woman on every shift now. He had it on good authority from one of those female firefighters that word had come down from way up that there were to be absolutely no scandals, sexual harassment claims, or funny business in the AFD.

"*Seriously*," she had added. "It's *impossible* to get myself laid around there."

If there was one thing you could count on firefighters for, it was respecting the chain of command. *Even* if command told you not to chase or look at or interact with *any* of the tail that was - if you were a male firefighter on the AFD, or a lesbian - literally *raining down on you* from every direction.

After a moment of silence and respect for the poor firefighters whose main *raison d'etre* had been cockblocked, he fished his phone out of his jacket while he was making coffee. Indeed, the text exchange Nikki had told him about had taken place, and he had not only okayed her gym visit, but had done so enthusiastically, with an exclamation point.

"Huh."

Only one thing remained unclear, and that was *why* Nikki suddenly had a "team" with designs on working out at 7am on a Saturday.

Excitement, cool and fluttering, began to seep into his chest. He lay back on the bed, staring at his phone, and trying to figure out a sensible interpretation of what Nikki had said with her mouth full of toothpaste.

He scanned their text messages - mostly abbreviated grocery lists sent to him, by Nikki, and his thumbs-ups in response to requests for dish soap, shampoo, and Drano - for some kind of clue.

When the giant sweep of his thoughts got closer to what he thought might be the real truth - that Nikki had somehow been accepted to the crazy tactical paramedic job, whatever it was actually called - he got wildly uncomfortable.

The thought was as delicious as it was terrifying. Hot, and horrifying. Horrifying that it was even slightly hot, horrifying because it was really dangerous, and horrifying because he couldn't remember her having told him about it.

And that was not the sort of thing Jack would have forgotten about.

Horrifyingly tantalizing.

It was probably just some kind of new fitness test they had to take, or some friendly first responder competition (they were always doing stuff like that out on "the street").

This was, he concluded, a little wistfully, the most likely explanation: some weight loss challenge or early start on making an all-girl team for some awful fitness competition the firefighters were always getting up to.

Nothing more.

CHAPTER 3

Nikki texted at about 12pm to say she wanted to grab lunch. By then, the kids were headed home, and the bug that had piqued Jack in the morning had disappeared in a puff of nagging chores - one of which was cleaning out the invariably clogged shower drains - and so Jack sent her a thumbs-up and went about his business, slightly rankled but mostly just annoyed by the drains.

She didn't come home until four.

She was still in the Lycra leggings she'd worn to work out, but had donned an oversized navy AFD sweatshirt that covered her bum. Also notable: her hair was down, and she had dark-brown mascara and a little bit of makeup on.

"Hey," she said, hopping into the home office, where he had settled in to whittle away what remained of the day and his hangover by touring the internet of non-porn. She kissed him on the cheek and he caught a whiff of booze, spearmint gum, and a vague aroma of stale smoke in her hair.

Beneath all of this, a foreign, sickly-sweet laundry soap (not theirs, which Nikki selected specifically to be scent-free - the unused bottles of scented soap he had mistakenly purchased were downstairs gathering dust in the laundry room), and the astringent soap from the ESB. "I'm sorry, I lost track of time."

"Mmm," he murmured agreeably, disgruntled and unsettled. "What kind of training group goes out boozing right after working out?"

Nikki's first reaction was to laugh, as if this was a joke and he already knew the punchline and so did she. But when she caught his expression, her lips

pressed together. She tipped her head to the side and blinked at him.

"Really?" she said.

"It just seems kind of counter-productive," he said, sensing suddenly how far out on the ledge he was.

Nikki opened her mouth wide, a smile on her lips, but snapped it shut quickly. Another tilt of her head. She put her hand out to his shoulder and moved it from there, across his back, and then cut back to his neck, tickling him with her fingers. "Some-body didn't listen-to-his-wife," she sang.

The phantom pleasure of her fingers on his neck lingered, distracting him. She had her hands on her hips and was biting on her lower lip, triumphantly, by the time he turned to her.

Well.

Two possibilities: one, that Nikki had, indeed, started training for her cop job, which meant she had either been accepted or was likely to be.

Or two, this was, in fact, some monthly fitness challenge that she had droned on and on to him about and he hadn't listened.

He really didn't see how he could have missed her telling him about the cop job.

After doing some complicated algebra in his head and not really figuring anything out, he resorted to his best alternative tactic: being a "typical man."

Adorably, and with some claims to senility.

He turned in his chair and put his hands on the back of her thighs. "Of course I listened to you," he said, using what Nikki called his "sly shyster voice." He moved his hands up her thighs to her very taut bottom and

massaged gently, pulling himself closer to her on the rolling chair. "I listen to everything you say," he murmured, pressing his face to her belly.

Nikki was already smiling congenially, which was a good sign. She put her hands on his head and ran her fingers through his hair. "Oh, really?" she said, a lilt in her voice. "And so... just to make sure we're talking about the same thing here... what was it you thought I was training *for*?"

He rested his chin on the very faint swell of her belly and looked up at her imploringly. He still had his hands on her round ass, and he was starting to forget what the conversation was about entirely.

But Jack was no noob when it came to covering *his* ass.

It was all about making a good joke.

"You are training to be on the paramedic cheer leading squad," he said, biting into her sweatshirt, which was way too big for her. It hung over his hands on her bottom, and she disappeared in the thick fabric. He started to move his hands up, beneath the sweatshirt, and found only smooth, bare skin.

Nikki rolled her eyes and tipped her head back. "You *jerk*," she said, her voice (thankfully) full of mirth. She gripped his hair forcefully, which made his cock get harder, and tipped her head back down to look at him. "You do not *know* because you didn't *pay attention* to your wife."

He had a bit of a baby face, which had sucked for the first half of his manhood, but these days was an advantage in all aspects of his life. It was an advantage when trying to worm his way out of trouble with women. He grinned and clawed at the waist of her pants.

For a moment he was in a perverse kind of heaven, and it seemed like Nikki was going to let him tug the leggings down, followed by her underwear, and then, if he could have his way, followed by a foray into the folds of her pussy with his tongue. He could smell her - the scent of her pussy mingled with sweat from a workout - and he could almost taste the salty-sweet mixture of those two flavors.

But her hands came out of nowhere, in from behind his hands, sliding under the sweatshirt and over her own skin to clutch his wrists and gently - but forcefully, because Nikki had been a paramedic for almost eighteen years and that's the sort of thing that makes you very good at loosening people's grips on you - and pushed them down and away.

"I am so sweaty and gross," she laughed.

He gave it a second shot, because that wasn't *exactly* a full blow-off. The more he felt of her body, and loosened the reins on his fantasies, the more he wanted her. "I don't mind," he murmured truthfully, trying to get his mouth to her mound and breathe his next words into her Lycra pants, knowing that the heat of his breath would tickle her there. And hopefully, turn her on.

Nikki wriggled away somehow and swatted at him playfully. "I'm taking a shower first," she said.

He was leaning on the edge of his rolling chair, hands open in the shape of his wife's body, staring at her open-mouthed.

The only part of her sentence he heard was "first."

"First" implied there was a "second," and all signs pointed that "second" was the thing he had been trying to get started first.

"I really, really," he said, using his feet to drag the chair toward her, "don't mind a little sweat..."

"Ah!" Nikki screamed playfully, pulling the door closed behind her as she backed out of the room.

Jack smiled. What else could you do?

After so many years, you took what you could get. Making a girl scream and slam the door on you - while still, potentially, not being so mad at you that you were blacklisted completely for the evening - was a pretty commendable achievement for a man his age.

He pushed back with his feet, headed to the computer, which he planned to shut down.

He heard the soft rap of knuckles on the door, thump-thump-thump, in rapid, sexy succession. "By the way?" Nikki's voice: sultry, playful, the kind of voice he had fallen in hopeless lust for and hadn't heard in decades. "It *was* for the tactical team."

A pause. His mind ran wild during this pause, imagining her face and her body, a glint in her eyes. His heart stopped beating, he ceased to breathe, and his ears could have heard the rise and fall of her breath at night through the door. She was still there, doing something, thinking something.

"And I *did* tell you about it," she added, her voice teasing.

It was a silent, stuffy world with no breath and no heartbeat. Jack waited, unable to think of anything to say.

Her footsteps retreated, soft and muffled by the carpet. "So you better think about how you're going to spin that one, champ, while I'm in the shower."

This, she called over her shoulder, as she headed across the hall to the master suite.

*

He had given himself a mandatory time-out, to cool off and talk to himself about saying stupid things and ruining a potentially good time.

The thing that was eating him, rattling around in his brain, was that he was *sure* Nikki had not mentioned any of this.

This wasn't something he'd have tuned out. He didn't have the greatest episodic memory in the world: like any guy he knew, he forgot entire events all the time. Like any guy, he got scolded by his wife for it, and like any guy, he couldn't see why she found it so upsetting. He didn't *care* about Jennifer Ruben's living room renovations or Steve and Kelly getting together and then breaking up and then getting back together again in secret. This is why he dumped the information two seconds after its arrival in his head. His brain was full up as it was, so any time he put something in the vault, something else had to get the boot.

His wife training for a tactical team with muscled cops at the fire house was just such a story that he would happily jettison another memory for. He was certain of that.

He was also certain that it was interesting to him.

Which meant: Nikki was having an episodic memory lapse herself (highly improbable), or she was deliberately telling a lie.

Either one of *those* possibilities came with its own subset of dark, exciting thoughts.

The time-out lasted only about five minutes, which hadn't been enough time for him to talk himself into being reasonable about anything. He plodded into the bedroom.

Nikki's workout clothes were rumpled, on the floor, taken off as she walked. They made a sexy trail of discarded garments, each one more intimately worn and soaked in more of her scent, and Jack followed them like a character from a fairy tale, picking them up, checking to see that Nikki didn't have a view of him via the mirror in the en-suite, and inhaling her scent.

The shower was running, steam moving lower and lower in the room. "So tactical team training, huh?" he asked, pausing by the hamper on his side of the room to deposit Nikki's clothes. He paused after dumping everything in - except her underwear, which he was aware he hadn't found yet. The navy sweatshirt was rumpled and folded over, hiding the insignia he had assumed was the AFD crest.

He unfolded it and stared at it.

APD.

He held it in his hands and stared at it for a minute. The implications were many, and he let his mind wander all at once to all of them.

"To be fair," Nikki called out. "I didn't put it on the calendar."

He was still holding the PD sweatshirt. The enormous PD sweatshirt.

Who had given this to Nikki, and why? There was a delicious and dark chewy center to that story: Nikki, having sweat through her own shirt while lunging, squatting, or crawling around on the floor (or whatever cops did when they trained; if they were anything like the fire department there was

a lot of heavy lifting and sweating and rolling around in positions that looked robust for men, and inevitably sexual when women did them).

Poor Nikki. All soaked in sweat, looking oiled-up and flushed, full of the peculiar energy she acquired from that kind of shit. She hadn't brought *anything* to change into, so she couldn't possibly go for lunch with you guys...

Unless...

Jack pictured his wife with her hands clasped, looking up at some muscle-headed cop figure, damp eyes brimming with disappointment. Was there anything to be done?

It was just a sweatshirt, he reminded himself. He sniffed it, and it smelled like dry cleaning, of all things, and Nikki.

"So... how did this happen, exactly?" he asked, holding the sweatshirt up. It was plain, other than the PD crest. A men's XL.

No immediate answer from Nikki.

He walked into the en-suite, leaving the sweatshirt.

"How did 'what' happen, exactly?" Nikki said. She was leaning her head back into the water, running her fingers through her hair. The glass door was fogged up, but Jack still had a nice view of her silhouette, and his memory of Nikki's body was photographic and knew no bounds for detail. He filled in the rest: her hardened nipples in the center of her pink aureole, beads of water gathering atop them before swelling and rolling down her upturned breasts. Rivulets merging at her hips and pouring into the sparse, golden grasslands of her mound, enveloping the slick wet flesh between her lips. The contours of her ribs that became prominent when she lifted her

arms and stretched her skin over them, the rounded fullness of her thighs that went on forever.

She was mocking him a little. But he could see that her mouth was open, smiling. She was toying with him.

Was she toying with him? He really didn't know. Nikki was never a deliberate teaser, and yet if he had written a script for her and asked her to follow it, it would have been something like what she was doing.

She had, after all, had some makeup to put on. Which he wanted to know about. Did she take it with her, expecting to be invited to lunch? Hoping to be? Just in case she was? Or was it a thing she just had on hand, everywhere she went, in case men asked her to lunch?

How did a man ask about that, exactly?

But it seemed suspicious - exquisitely suspicious - that Nikki had not taken any spare clothes with her, and yet still had gone out, wearing a police department sweatshirt, and had also somehow managed to get her hands on touch-up makeup.

And - and this was important - *put it on*.

Jack was torn at this point. It seemed like Nikki was potentially horny enough for him to get lucky. That was if he kept his mouth shut and didn't alter the ambiance.

On the other hand...

"Oh, I'm just wondering, you know, how it happened that you had this handy-dandy men's XL APD sweatshirt ready to go to lunch after your workout at the ESB, is all."

Nikki snorted and made a turn in the shower, pulling water out of her tresses as she did. "Hmm," she said, mysteriously.

He opened the shower door. Nikki looked at him and smiled, putting a hand on her hip and reaching for the door with the other. "You're letting all the steam out."

He positioned himself next to the door so she couldn't close it and pulled his shirt off. Nikki's eyes went up and down his body, and he prepared for her to slap his shoulder and push him out of the shower by force, but she didn't. She let go of the shower door and shrugged, smiling at him. She folded her arms over her chest and dipped her hair back into the stream of water.

Jack enjoyed the view for a while, waiting for Nikki to say something. But her eyes were closed and her lips appeared to be sealed.

He shimmied out of his sweats and boxers, giving, for the first time in a very long time, some thought to his appearance. He was decently fit, but long past his days as a lean youthful man. Maybe Nikki was tired of his sweats and his soft man-belly, and was looking for a man in a pressed, clean uniform with defined muscles on every part of his body.

The kind of man who would loan her a sweatshirt so she could go to "lunch," right after he showed her how to roll around the floor while he defended her from the bad guys with his military-grade weapons.

His cock was hard and ready, requiring some extra effort to free himself of his clothing. *That* certainly didn't happen every day.

Nikki opened her eyes as he stepped into the shower, and then moved them down his body to his cock.

She raised her eyebrows, but sucked her lower lip behind her front teeth. Her eyes continued to his feet, and she burst into laughter. "You have your *socks on*," she chortled. She shook her head slowly, grinning at him.

This was a mistake, born of enthusiasm, he thought, but did not say. Nikki's eyes had returned to his cock, and then slowly made their way back to his face. She tilted her head a little. Her expression was partly quizzically - like it always was when he ventured to play a game like this - but a glimmer of enlightenment twinkled in her eyes. "You don't seem too upset about it," she murmured, extending her hand to deliver a feathery caress to his cock. She squeezed it and giggled, turning around in the shower.

Jack was temporarily paralyzed by incomprehension. He pulled the shower door closed and stood just outside of the splashing water - which was insanely hot - watching Nikki make a sensual, slow turn under the water.

Sex in the shower was a young man's game, and even then, it typically ended in disaster - for men like Jack, at least, who were not able to bench press 300 pounds or carry a full-grown woman much of anywhere, let alone support her weight against a wet slab of marble while his own feet slid around on the floor. But as he stepped toward her, he discovered that socks in the shower had actually been a very good idea all along.

Traction.

"What are you...?" Nikki squealed, as he slid his arms around her waist and gently bit into her shoulder. He walked her over to the far wall, pressing her against it. Nikki put out her hands on either side of her and went willingly, turning her face to the side. Her mouth was open, her eyes closed, a smile surfacing and disappearing in her features like the fin of a shark in deep water.

His mind was feebly trying to reason with him, to tell him not to take chances when he had an apparently sure thing in his grasp, right there: a wet, slippery wife who was going to let him have sex with her. Maybe even in the shower.

Make a joke about the socks and then shut up, his brain wisely told him.

But his brain wasn't the head doing the thinking anymore, and so while his hands moved over Nikki's wet body, his mouth went right ahead and started saying things he knew he shouldn't. In Nikki's ear, the bitterness of leftover shampoo in tiny quantities on his lips:

"So who is this mystery man who gave you the sweatshirt?"

Nikki smiled, and opened her mouth to say something, but cut herself off with a sharp inhale just as his fingers found her pussy and slipped between her outer lips. When he encountered not the squeaky-clean rubberiness of her flesh after showering, but instead a reservoir of viscous juices, his cock swelled against her thigh.

He was ready to be shoved out of the shower, or for Nikki to wriggle away asking him what the hell was wrong with him, but she took him by surprise yet again and wriggled - putting her ass more comfortably into his crotch, pushing his dick to the side almost to the point of pain - before smiling.

"Just some guy," she said.

"A police guy," he breathed, sliding over her swollen clit. And it really was swollen, just like his aching cock.

"A big, hairy, pot-bellied, ugly, bald, pig of a cop guy," she said, laughing. She turned in his embrace, and her silky wet skin ran beneath his fingers like a silken rope he'd let slip through his grip.

He kissed her once she was facing him, and his hands moved to her hips as her hands went to his shoulders.

She had unfamiliar tastes in her mouth. The mint from her gum lingered there, and the hoppy carbonation of beer had left an aftertaste on her tongue. As he explored her mouth and the tip of his tongue ran over the impossible softness of her inner cheek, his thoughts went immediately to the equivalent softness down below, and he wanted to taste it. Deep inside, a desire to find something unfamiliar there burned a hole through him.

His fingers worked their way into her pussy, and it was easy going sliding inside of her. Nikki's mouth fell open, and it was hard to know if this was shock at his brazenness or delight at what he was doing to her.

It didn't matter, as long as she was into it, which she seemed to be.

He stared into her eyes as he finger-fucked her, gripped by a profound desire and a preposterous belief, that he could stare into her eyes and find out the truth, if only he looked hard enough and made her weak enough with his touch. Her pussy quivered around his fingers, distracting him.

"He wasn't really, though, was he?" he asked her. "Fat. Or bald. Or ugly." He curled his fingers toward the root of her clit, where a patch of slightly rough skin - he desperately believed - marked her g-spot. He stroked it, and juices seemed to well up from nowhere to slide down his fingers.

Her eyes stared back at him, limpid and unchanged. She bit her lower lip. "No," she whispered softly.

His cock pulsed violently.

He gave himself a brief moment to size up the situation: he was a middle-aged man in average-to-good shape, in a shower with a horny wife who

seemed to be into having sex. He was ahead of the game, he had even left socks on for traction. Now was the time to take what he could get and be satisfied with it.

Not the time to go out any further on a limb than he already was.

All of this flashed through his head while Nikki nudged her ass toward him, tilting it up slightly - provocatively, message received. She twisted a little and looked back at him, her features enlarged and dripping with lust in a way that was terrifyingly unfamiliar and also completely destroying of rational thought.

What happened next seemed to happen in such slow-motion that it wasn't real. Jack even doubted it was real while it took place. It had the quality of a dream. Every second seared into his memory, sizzling as it burnt, a red-hot poker in the shape of Nikki's lips, curved like her bouncing bottom that slipped against his thighs. Her hands were on the marble, glassy beads of water growing fat and dripping in zigzags to her back.

Her lips, pink and glistening, moved, and he stared at them as they formed the words she said next.

"He was black, actually. Very tall. *Very* fit." She grinned, her mouth open a little like she needed to swallow more air - or something - and her eyes fluttered alluringly. "Really good with his gun."

Jack answered in actions first, pinning Nikki against the wall and guiding his dick to the slippery folds between her legs, dragging it through her flesh. His own skin clung to rubbery patches of her pussy, where the shower had diluted the silky lubricant that streamed from her, but near the center, where her body sucked at his crown like two slathered lips, she was as wet as he had ever felt her.

A wave of aggression traveled through him. It was a familiar feeling, a surge of recklessness and disregard that made him feel like he was twenty again. Back when he took chances on things, fucked in whatever place was convenient, had rational thoughts ground down into a useless dust by the desires of his dick.

He pushed into Nikki roughly, bracing himself, making her contort her body to accommodate him. She went right along with him, pushing back into him, spreading her legs, raising herself up on her tiptoes to rut against him like they were teenagers. The slap of their thighs against each other was wet and filthy, erotic in and of itself. And even with all of that, even with his brain already doused in the wild reward drugs that came from fucking, he still had the senseless, reckless courage of a younger version of himself. "You'd like that, wouldn't you? A big black cock stretching you out?"

It was the center of the knotted ball of his desire, the root from which all streams of his fantasies - in all of their forms - unfurled. From the seed of the image of black cock sawing stickily between his wife's legs. *Saying* it made his cock throb to the edge of climax; Nikki's reaction - a surly, pretty murmur of neither assent nor dissent - drove him to fucking her hard, with deep and powerful thrusts, his eyes closed to try and keep himself from coming before Nikki's pussy's clenched around his cock in an explosion of hot liquid.

Perhaps that was what drove him to press against her body, clutching her by the hips and the waist, their skin slippery in each other's hands - a potential accident lurking at the edges of every movement, none of which they were thinking through - and whisper into her ear:

"I want you to think about him fucking you. Right now."

The reaction in Nikki's body was immediate. Her legs trembled and her muscles tightened throughout her body. Around his cock, her hot pussy squeezed and quivered, and in pulses, she shuddered in pleasure. Her mouth opened, and her eyes squeezed shut - but instead of the silent scream that Nikki had long ago adopted (out of the necessity brought about by having kids in the house), she howled in a feral and almost terrifying way as her cum welled up, a flood of sweet excitement that made her so wet that he had to grab her by both hips and pound her like an animal to get enough friction.

Nikki's face was against the marble when he came, her eyes staring emptily in front of her.

Thinking about a black man fucking her? As his cum poured into her pussy, the thought was as delicious as it was painful, and what shook his body was the best orgasm he'd had in a long time.

He leaned against her while he let his heart recover - it was pounding so hard his ears seemed to have been closed off to the outside world and a dull rush and his own pulse were all that he could sense over the distant-sounding roar of the water.

Nikki rolled around, lifting her arms, smiling, wet in every possible permutation of the word. His cock flopped from inside her and she curled her arms up between his, which were pressed against the wall.

And there, on Nikki's face, was a smile of pure pleasure, behind which something else he had never seen swam, darting, difficult to capture in his mind for more than a moment. Like something moving beneath dark water, it appeared at times promising, at others terrifying. But like anything that

came up from the depths, it flashed and then disappeared, before he could see it in its full form.

He stepped back, panting, his mouth open. Had he summoned a monster?

Nikki smiled at him benignly, sleepily. "Whoa," she said.

A flutter of girlish modesty surfaced in her features. Her hand moved to his jaw, and she squeezed. Maybe she had the intention of saying something in her weird New Jersey accent, but she changed her mind, leaned forward, and kissed him. "That was..."

He stepped closer to her again. "Hot?"

Nikki giggled and wriggled away from him, back into the scalding shower water. Her hands were on her shoulders, and she gave him no further answer than to smile, look him up and down, and then turn, mysteriously silent, to dip her hair into the running stream.

Lifted her hands to her hair, to push the water backwards from her face, her eyes closed. Another smile. "*Something*," she said, and then her lips closed in a smile that could have been read any number of ways.

Cum snaked down her thighs, mixing with the water, and Nikki's eyes were closed so Jack was free to fixate on it, thinking whatever he wanted, while she rinsed her hair, her body stretched out for him in all of its used glory, imaginary and real.

*

"So," Jack said. "Seriously. Does this mean you're all-in on this thing?"

They were in bed, where they had ended up again after Nikki had gotten out of the shower, dried off, and started to put clothes on. Jack had pulled her into bed by her underwear, making Nikki squeal and slap playfully at his

hands, but she had gone willingly. For a few minutes, it had been a silly, playful game that Jack hadn't actually expected to end in sex - more because it had been so long since he had fucked Nikki twice in one day that he couldn't even hazard a guess as to the year.

But the playfulness had, like the switch of a light, turned serious. It was a hazy, dreamlike memory, but Jack felt certain that Nikki had been the one to suddenly change, whose goofy smile and fake slapping had turned, in that indescribable way, to a sudden, serious lust.

This time, she had climbed onto his lap, looking into his eyes, and ridden him. They hadn't exchanged any dirty talk that time, just an intense and wild eye contact as Nikki took over the entire scenario, sliding herself onto his cock after stroking it to full life with a few lazy swipes of her fingers over the crown, her thumb rolling beads of precum into a slippery sheen before seizing him and stuffing him inside her.

Nikki opened her eyes lazily and smiled. "You *are* talking about the tactical team again, right?"

He tilted his chin and arched his back to move her head into a more comfortable position on his chest. His fingers were making lazy circles on the smooth expanse of her back, which was inexplicably gorgeous. Nikki wasn't the type to wear dresses very often anymore, and definitely nothing backless, but on the rare occasions that she did, it was a show-stopper. He found it particularly sexy because it was such an atypical feature of a woman to find as sexy as he did.

"I am, actually," he said, making a quick decision to quit with his other pet project while he was ahead. "I, uh, don't know how I missed that you were, you know, actually all in...?" He left it ending like a question, because in

real, practical terms, it was. And it burned away in the back of his mind, giving a different kind of light than before, after what had just happened.

He really didn't understand how he could have spaced it out, as Nikki was claiming. He knew better to harp on it, but he wanted to clarify it with Nikki.

This, after all, was not the kind of thing, like it being his turn to take the garbage out, or a dentist appointment, that he would just "forget" her talking about. Not when it was attached, via invisible, psychological strings, to the darkest parts of his mind.

"It seems like the kind of thing I'd have paid attention to," he added, almost defensively, even though Nikki hadn't said anything.

Nikki sat up, leaning her arm on his chest to toss her back from her face and run her fingers through it. "You okay'd this, you know, when I applied? Remember?"

"Vaguely." That wasn't exactly the conversation he remembered having, but then, they never seemed to be.

"This" was also the main point of contention here. What did Nikki mean by "this?"

What did *he* mean by "this?"

What he wanted to talk about was precisely "this" - and how close their definitions could be brought together.

Nikki dropped her head, sending her still-damp hair cascading onto his chest, so he didn't get to watch her lips as they closed around his left nipple and sucked on it. "Well, you did."

Her voice was a little cold, a little irritated. It was definitely time for him to do some damage control on this subject, and yet it wasn't what he really wanted to talk about. At all.

She set her chin on his chest and looked up at him, breaking his concentration again. "Anyway, I'm just training for the physical test. It's a whole process." She threw herself onto her back. "I probably won't even get in."

Jack sat up and turned on his side, then plopped down next to her with his arm supporting his head. His right hand was now liberated to travel over Nikki's body, and so he tested the waters, beginning at her belly-button and working his way slowly up to her sternum.

Nikki was staring at the ceiling, troublesome thoughts still shifting behind her eyes.

It was probably time to stop thinking about sex, if he ever wanted to have it again. He was pushing his luck as it was.

"Okay. Look," he said, sitting up and propping some pillows behind his back. "I am *all ears*. I'm sorry I didn't listen carefully when you told me. Now you have to repeat this all to me and explain it like I'm five."

Nikki twisted her head to look up at him. She mocked him with a face of complete shock, then hopped onto her knees, tossing her half-dry and wild hair from her face again. "*This!*" she whisper-yelled, excitedly. "This is what I always wanted!"

She was laughing. She shoved him playfully before extending a leg to get out of bed. "For you to tell me that you're sorry for being a... non-listening... inattentive... *man*." She laughed at herself, because this was also very Nikki - starting a big diatribe without the means to finish it.

"I can be very attentive," he began, reaching for her, but it was too late. Nikki was already hopping out of bed and into the en-suite.

"The final rounds of interviews are after the physical test and then some other kind of psychological test you have to do, and then, if you make it through all that, which I probably won't because there are all kinds of crazy applicants, like critical care paramedics everywhere and they're all dudes... but anyway... so it's not like, a huge chance of me getting in, you know? But I thought I'd try."

"Mhmm," Jack said, glaring at the sweatshirt, still hanging halfway out of the hamper.

Nikki was peeing, and she sighed audibly. "This is where you say, 'Oh, Nikki, why are you even worried? You're a hotshot and you totally got this.'"

The toilet flushed, Jack scrambled to find something to say, and Nikki bounced into the room. "Or are you still hung up on the cop thing?"

She bounced into the bed, which was so distracting visually - with her breasts bouncing and her legs in motion, swinging over his - that Jack just stared at her, motionless.

She reached out and gripped his jaw, squeezing and releasing so that his lips squished in and out. "You totally got this Nikki," she said, in a crazed New Jersey accent that she used to "imitate" him saying things he should have said. She butchered the accent, and New Jersey didn't have anything to do with Jack, but she put her fingers near his mouth so he let it slide. "And you're gonna get the job."

Jack reached for her hand, a fountainhead of mixed emotions surging in his chest. Nikki must have sensed this, because she became serious, and they

looked at each other for a while.

"I *do* think you'll get the job," he said, and his voice was in danger of wobbling because of the sudden emotion he felt. "I'm just not sure I like it."

She squeezed his hand back and leaned forward to kiss him. He supposed it wasn't especially helpful to his cause that his cock was rigid and Nikki, sitting atop his lap, almost certainly knew that. He was aroused; there wasn't any arguing about that. But beneath that wild emotion, many, many more shifted and mingled, and a lot of them were uncomfortable emotions he'd much rather put away.

Nikki slumped a little when she sat back down on his lap. "You should come meet them if I do," she said abruptly. She leaned forward onto her hands, to his right side, and plopped into bed next to him. "Seriously," she said. "They said you should."

Jack squinted and stared at the wall in front of him. "*They* said I *should*?"

Nikki rolled out of bed again, this time in the direction of her dresser, right after giving him the kind of slap she gave to other guys out in the field after a good job. "Believe it or not," she said, once she was up and digging through her dresser. "You're not the only husband out there who has some concerns about his wife being on a tactical team."

Something akin to shame burned through him, fast and painful.

Naturally most other husbands would not like that, he thought.

But were there husbands who both *did* and didn't like it?

For the reasons that he did?

He doubted it.

"I have to make these kids something to eat or they're just going to have Ramen again," Nikki told him, pulling a shirt over her bare breasts. She looked around at the floor. "Where'd you put that sweatshirt?"

"They're teenagers," Jack complained, reaching his hand out to lure Nikki back to bed. "They *want* Ramen."

"Can't allow it," Nikki said, skipping over to the side of the room where she'd abandoned her workout clothes. She scanned the floor. "Sweatshirt?" she asked. But she found it at the same time, and was already headed to the hamper to collect it.

She looked at Jack after holding it up. She dropped her hands, still holding the sweatshirt. "You aren't seriously wigged out by this, are you? It's like... new. Somebody had it in the back of their car. I just borrowed it."

"A big hairy, bald, monster-man," Jack said miserably. He felt like a child, and he wanted to stop himself, but couldn't.

"Bald, not hairy... I mean, God Jack, I obviously wouldn't know how... hairy he is. You're not *serious*?"

Serious.

It was a harder word to define than most people gave it credit for.

Was he *serious*?

Did Nikki really know what she was asking when she asked that?

He shook his head, and Nikki looked at him weirdly, but then she decided to let it go, and spun around to leave. She changed her mind again, hopped onto the bed, busily worked her way up to his face, and kissed him loudly and sloppily on the cheek. "That was really hot," she said.

And giggled, and hopped away.

Her laugh communicated volumes: Nikki had liked what they had done, but she had interpreted it as pure fantasy, like any other game they had played while having sex after a bit too much booze. Or once, after a really wild four-alarm fire that pretty much the entire city had been called to and had felt like a gory, Viking battle and their sex had become unusually violent.

It was something novel and fun and totally enclosed in the safety of the moment. Like the brief periods of time where she had liked talking about getting spanked for not cleaning the house.

Amusing. Hot. But not real.

In Nikki's mind, anyway.

Well, Jack thought. There was always something to be said for getting your foot in the door, even if Nikki came along to kick it back out with a steel-toed boot and her relentless, sunny cheer.

CHAPTER 4

Whatever had transpired that day between them wasn't brought up again. There were all kinds of reasons for this, all kinds of probable explanations: they never had any time, Nikki didn't know how to start the conversation, it wasn't really a conversation anyway because Nikki was going to do whatever she wanted to do.

And really, other than Jack feeling vaguely and gently cucked by the mere fact that his wife was doing something dangerous and exciting with dangerous and exciting - and assuredly stacked - men with big guns and biceps and very high levels of testosterone, there wasn't much for them to talk about. He didn't have a solid reason - other than "danger" - to "put his foot down" about it.

She didn't have any new information about it, anyway: it was one of those long-term application processes that was, in typical EMS style, opaque and bureaucratic as hell.

But Nikki *clammed up* about it entirely after that day. She no longer got excited about it, jabbering away in excited sentences that fell all over each other and failed to express coherent thoughts.

Opposed to having the effect that he assumed Nikki wanted - making him think about it less - this only fueled a bonfire of suspicions.

Jack enjoyed going back to them, like a tongue to sore gums, probing the tenderness of the thoughts, pressing until he felt the pain.

She still went to work out on days she didn't have a shift, but she told him about it ahead of time, came back within a reasonable amount of time, and

recited the sets and exercises she had done in a dry and disinterested voice when he asked about it.

She seemed to not hear the creepy, needy undercurrents in his voice when *he* asked *her* about her workouts.

Casually.

"Ugh," she would say. "Brutal today."

Or:

"I *finally* did a pull-up and I think I may have broken my whole back."

So Nikki was working out for a physical test that may have involved doing a pull-up, which was pretty unsurprising and banal - though he had to admit, a pretty high bar for *paramedics*, especially given that they wanted *seasoned* paramedics.

Jack was working out, too.

For a psychological test that didn't even exist except in his own mind.

He got back on Reddit and diverted his attentions to a few websites dedicated to the subject of hotwifing, but the whole thing rapidly descended into a hazy, blurry, fantastical realm that he enjoyed delving into but categorized as escapism, even to himself.

There was no way that Nikki - with her straight-shooting, somewhat conservative, clean and prim sexual mind - was ever going to say the things that these guys' wives said, or do any of the things they purportedly did. It was almost impossible to imagine.

It all got filed away somewhere that he only revisited when drunk or alone at night because Nikki was on shift, or trapped at the ER in a queue of

annoyed, bitching paramedics with hypoglycemic old ladies on gurneys in the hallway.

Things went on like this until a Wednesday, when, in the early hours before he had to get up himself, he got sexual ideas lying in the blue morning light, and turned on his side to see if he had any chance of rousing Nikki just a little so that they could have sex before he left for work.

It was a gamble that he rarely took on a weekday morning when Nikki had worked a shift the day before - naturally, coming home late, because that was how it worked these days.

She could get very grumpy and bite his head off, but sometimes it was worth the risk.

Sometimes a man did not calculate risk exceedingly well.

Nikki was sleeping in a white shirt so thin that even her pale skin appeared through the loosely woven fabric. It was a long, clingy t-shirt that had stretched out a little in strange places, came to just below her butt, and framed her breasts incredibly. It was her go-to sleeping shirt, which was something Jack didn't object to at all. She barely washed it twice a month, so it smelled like soap and her skin, a little bit of sweat, and just inhaling it could get his cock hard.

He was not proud of it, because it seemed feral in the light of day, but he had sniffed it while masturbating sometimes.

It bunched up while she slept, and today it was caught under her ribs, so her lower back was exposed. She wore a pair of red underwear - practical in cut, but silky and with a tiny bit of lace, because Nikki wore underwear that fit her personality exactly. Practical, boyish in some ways, but ultimately silken and a little lacy, and deliriously tempting.

He started at her spine, just above the crack of her ass, where her underwear had slipped down a little to reveal the first shallow centimeters of the dip between her rounded buttocks. He brushed his fingers as lightly as possible there - this was a litmus test, a foray into the semi-conscious layers of Nikki's psyche. If she reacted by grumbling or throwing her hand back to grab his wrist, he would back off.

But she didn't.

He started working his fingers up her spine, his hand poised to retract quickly to any assault from her left arm, which was slung over her torso. Nikki only ever slept on her right side; if she was on her left she was probably awake and probably ticked about a bad sleep.

She stirred when he started back down, his fingers drawn to the very soft skin between her buttocks.

But she didn't swat him away.

He dipped underneath the panties, encountering skin that was damp with the fine sweat of her sleep. A noise, like a purr, vibrated in her chest, low and alluring.

So he pushed his weight closer, using his right arm, and drove his fingers deeper into her underwear. He propped his head on his hand and pivoted his face toward her neck, where the scent of sleepy sweat had gathered with the smell of her shampoo, the layers of sleep worked into the shirt, the sweet scent that belonged only to her.

His cock was alive and kicking furiously, and he usually slept nude, so it bobbed into the velvet softness of her upper thighs.

Another mewl, so he put his lips on her neck and watched her mouth as she twisted and squirmed a little, a smile forming on her lips. He swept his wandering, probing hand over her hip, tracing his fingertips along the hem of her panties, working his fingers beneath the shirt, which was caught up across her stomach and taut -

Nikki's eyes flew open, stared in front of her for a second, and then all hell broke loose.

"Shit!" she hissed, and her body was ripped away from his embrace as she sat up, throwing her feet on the floor and looking wildly toward the alarm clock - an antiquated, necessary device that she insisted on keeping on her bedside table even though it was often - and currently was - an hour off because no one thought to change it with the time change.

"Shit, shit, shit," she said.

"That clock's an hour ahead," he said sleepily, reaching for her. He had one thing on his mind still.

She whipped her head around to look at him. "No," she said, grabbing her phone and looking at it with dismay. "Shit!"

And she hopped out of bed and hurried into the bathroom. Jack followed her, rotating to watch her, and he was glad that he had, because she peeled her shirt off mid-stride and the resulting explosion of skin and bouncing breasts was a pleasant sight.

He let his head fall onto the pillow and sighed when he heard the water start running in the shower.

Things weren't ending in any kind of unusual way. Nikki had probably snatched up some last-minute shift, though it was unlike her to forget to set

an alarm about it or even tell him.

He lazily sat up, let his blood pressure adjust - mostly this was a question of allowing some of the blood that had been re-routed to his cock to return to normal circulation - before heaving himself out of bed and plodding into the bathroom. "You pick up a shift again?" he asked, almost miserably, putting toothpaste on a toothbrush.

"I have that test today," Nikki answered immediately.

Breathlessly.

Excitedly.

With a huge smile on her face.

Jack turned around and leaned on the counter, toothbrush poised in front of his mouth. "You forgot to set an alarm for that?"

Nikki laughed mysteriously, and then said no more for several seconds.

Jack shoved the toothbrush in his mouth and watched his wife. It was a better view than the one that he would get from the mirror.

Nikki popped the door open and stuck her head out. "Don't be ridiculous," she said, smiling. "I just needed to get out of bed before you started anything."

Jack raised his eyebrows and craned around his own torso to spit in the sink. "That's... vaguely insulting," he joked.

"My slot is at one-twenty," she said, and he could hear a cheerful, excited tone to her voice. This meant that, whatever "that test" was - and he could only assume it was the physical test for the lurid tactical team - Nikki

thought she had it in the bag. Otherwise she'd be fretting, and it would come across in her voice. "But I have a whole plan."

"Let me guess. It does not involve me stealing your life force before breakfast," Jack offered amicably. Nikki occasionally went for this shtick, so it was a last-ditch effort to draw her back into the bed. He moved toward the shower as he talked.

He popped it open and peeked in on Nikki, which was one of the things that gave him a very particular, very enjoyable throb of some feeling that didn't have a name. Good old-fashioned, dirty-man pride, maybe. He could open the door to the shower on a hot girl like Nikki and peek in, even grab a feel, and she was 99.999% unlikely to file charges on him for doing it, so it was basically a right. Which, if your wife was as hot as Nikki was, was pretty ego-boosting.

"You know," he said, mostly goofing off now, "You're actually stealing *my* life force when we -"

Nikki whirled around and swatted in his direction. "Jesus, what are you even talking about, life force, you weirdo?" She laughed. "I need to eat breakfast at seven on the dot."

An entire chorus line of glittering, filthy jokes surfaced in Jack's mind, all of them involving "protein" and breakfast, but he had learned at least a few things over the course of his marriage, and when to stuff shit like that down a memory hole was one of them.

It took a beat, though.

"Okay," he said, huffing. It sounded, even to himself, like he was about to roll his sleeves up and deliver Narcan to an angry linebacker who had just

done a speedball. "And what do you need to eat for breakfast, my tactical team queen?"

Nikki laughed. "That's it?"

He stared blankly at the steamy door.

"No jokes about a protein shake?" She whipped out her New Jersey accent.

"I got a protein shake right here for you, baby."

Jack blinked, speechless. "Uh, well... if you want, I have some jokes -"

Nikki slammed the water off, oblivious to the water hammer she frequently caused, in spite of Jack having managed to get their firefighter friend Angie to tell her it was a real thing and really bad for the pipes.

"I got it all made already," she told him, suddenly whispering, which was a sign in Nikki of stratospheric excitement. She popped out of the shower, pulling a towel from somewhere and wrapping it around herself from the front so that she had to hold it at the back as she slipped past him and scurried into the bedroom.

Jack decided it was in his best interests to stay out of her way, so he stepped into the shower.

By the time he got to the kitchen, Nikki was gone.

*

The text arrived midday. Nikki had taken a selfie of herself lying on the floor, looking like she had just finished a marathon. Her face was bright pink, the splotches absorbed by overall exertion. She was grinning triumphantly, though.

FUCKING KILLED IT!

Mixed emotions.

Jack scoured the picture with a paranoid eye. He took in the toe of a large tactical boot near Nikki's head. So not a selfie after all.

A photo of his wife lying on the ground, taken by the owner of a very large black tactical boot.

Sweat had darkened the collar of Nikki's shirt, patches of it showing through where her soaked sports bra had come into contact with it, the shape of her breasts as clearly outlined as if she were naked.

He stared at the picture, emotions roiling.

What should he write back? "AWESOME?" It was obvious to him that there was no stopping Nikki as she pursued this position, so he had shelved any real concerns - about safety, time, stress, the legitimate things that he could gripe about - long ago.

All that remained now was the convoluted fascination he possessed with the Nikki who seemed to be seeking this job - mysterious Nikki, Nikki who didn't give him all the details she claimed to, Nikki who borrowed sweatshirts from black guys with big shoes and then slurred about them alluringly in the shower. Nikki who would have to go to training sessions, unsupervised, with macho guys who were notoriously divorced and/or unfaithful, pussy-chasing dicks.

For Nikki, it was a real job that she was into doing for the *job itself*.

He could see that clearly: she wanted the extra pay, the new training, the new exciting tasks, the possible career advancement. The combat medic training.

Nikki was *not* into it for the dick.

He knew this. Intellectually, it seemed to add up.

Their firefighter friend Angie had been pretty helpful setting him straight about it, as usual. After an unrelated, heated discussion about various first responder jobs and what kind of people did which jobs and why, Angie, who had been listening without joining in and getting pretty loaded like she usually did, stood up at the end of their table and spread her hands out wide.

This was when Angie dispensed her wisdom.

"Look, you stupid fucks," she had slurred. "McCrae!" She had turned to their latest candidate, a sweet-faced, aw-shucks farmboy who was twenty and already married to his high school sweetheart, who was probably the only girl he'd ever fucked. "Why did *you* want to be a firefighter?"

McCrae had looked like someone had kicked his dog, and was short-circuiting for a few moments while Angie blinked slowly at him and then got fed up. "Ah, Jesus, kid, never mind, you're just gonna tell me what you think I want to hear, which is *wrong*." She had whirled around to find a more reliable source of information. "Hey, Hands! Why did you become a firefighter?"

Hands - Brian Olson, who managed to burn his hands on almost every working fire call but remained employed because he also had two saves and an uncle up on high - waved his hand limply in the air. "Basically... pussy."

Angie had delighted in this, and in collecting the same answer from everyone present except the candidates. Then she had leaned over to Jack and explained: "Now, ask any *woman* why they're doing this shit. Go ahead. And I guarantee you not one fucking one of them is going to say 'dick.'"

"That's because you're all a bunch of fucking dykes," Hands had contributed.

Angie had arched an eyebrow and collected her enormous beer, cradling it in her hands like a baby, probably in case she needed a quick escape.

"Whaddya got against dykes, Olson? You got a dick like a huge clit. They oughta be all over you."

"Yeah. Taking lessons," Hands had agreed, to a round of applause.

Intellectually, it was all true, and Jack knew it. Men did all this stupid shit because of the promise of pussy, but women usually had a better *honest* answer than that, and it was never "dick."

But could you really *believe* that? Angie had her reasons for becoming a firefighter (helping people, and she actually seemed to care about that), and she wasn't a dyke.

On the other hand, she did complain about not being able to get laid, so whatever that all added up to was anyone's guess.

His phone rang while he was trying to type a message back to Nikki, trying to get the phrasing right, to be honest and supportive and enthusiastic, without being an ass. He had scrapped "AWESOME!" because it sounded insincere.

"Hey," he said. "Just got your message. Wow. Way to go!"

Nikki was already speeding ahead, talking over him. "I set the women's record. Only by half a second but I still feel awesome. We're going out -"

There was a lot of rowdy noise from Nikki's end of the phone. She was obviously already out. Someone diverted her attention with a question Jack didn't hear. "Huh? What? Yeah, just - wait a minute." Breathless. Muffled voices, her hand was over the mic.

Then, loud, right into the mic: "So?"

Her attention was back on Jack. In the background, a chorus of loud male voices.

"Uh..."

"Come *out*. Come out, come out, come out!" Nikki said, giddy with excitement and pretty clearly already in the bag a little. "We're going to Stripey's -"

"Sounds like you're already there -"

" - no, Harry's - and... yeah, please come."

"I... Nikki, I... I have to drive Cole to a meet... uh... maybe I can -"

"I know, I already thought of that. Get Jen Bruce to take him, her number's on the fridge. Okay -"

More yelling.

" -Okay, I gotta run, babe, call Jen, or, just come after... I'll text you where we are, okay?"

Jack was silent a beat too long.

"Okay, come, come, come out with us, pleeeaaaase? I'll call you back in a bit."

Before the phone cut off, a man with a low voice, and a lot of air moving through his lungs, bellowed her name. "Hiller get ove-"

Jack set the phone down and stared at it. His heart was beating so fast he wondered if he was going to pass out for a full second and considered getting Mike's attention.

"Your girl's goin' for it, huh?" Mike asked, at a laconic pace. He took another rattling, annoying sip from his empty Big Gulp and frowned at it as he shook it. Then he slammed it on the table, rattling the ice. "Huh."

Jack focused on his computer screen and pretended to be hard at work so Mike wouldn't dispense any more deep thoughts. He had a huge report to finish, and he was grateful for it, because it was applying the kind of career-threatening pressure that allowed him to focus on work and not his wife, out on the town in the early afternoon, hopped up on the high of physical achievement and celebratory drinks, with a bunch of giga-Chad cops.

*

Hey. Jen Bruce's number isn't on the fridge, do you have it?

This message went unanswered for ten minutes. She also didn't answer his call.

A reasonable man, Jack knew, would see this in its most benign light.

Nikki was out having celebratory drinks with her colleagues. It was five o'clock, she always turned her notifications and ringer off for shift or training, and she inevitably forgot to turn them back on until after she misplaced her phone and couldn't locate it by calling it.

It was a well-worn marital sniping match. Not unusual. Not nefarious.

He left a pointed message stating that he would wait for her call for ten minutes but then they had to get going or Cole would miss his match.

And then, alone in the kitchen, listening to his younger son thump around getting his gear together, a sinking feeling spreading out from his core to his limbs, he waited.

He wondered what he hoped for. If anyone else had asked him, he would have said that of course he was just peeved that Nikki was unreachable, peeved that the number hadn't been on the fridge like she said, peeved that Nikki wasn't thinking at all about her husband and any difficulties he might encounter getting Jen Bruce to drive their son to a match, because if she really loved him and really wanted him there, she would have checked her fucking phone by now.

The reality was more complicated, though, because there was more to the story than just this one episode. For almost a decade, it had been him on the other end of this type of situation: Nikki ferrying the kids around, Nikki giving up the good job opportunities, Jack getting the training and going out to celebrate. *That* part of the story was just the tables getting turned, and he knew he just had to suck it up. It was fair play, and they'd already hashed *that* out a long time ago.

There was something else.

What was the right adjective for describing how he really felt? He *was* peeved, and agitated. But there were layers and layers to his peevedness: cool layers of jealousy that had no basis or rationale, white-hot layers of excitement and anticipation, a layer of smug self-righteousness, a layer of fear that he couldn't decide how he felt about - the emotion felt like raw anger and it also felt like violent, obsessive arousal.

"Ready?" Cole panted, hefty duffel bag over his shoulder. He turned to open the fridge and the bag almost knocked a set of ceramic jars to the floor. He reacted with the lightning-quick reflexes of an adolescent athlete entering the physical prime of his life and snapped a hand back to stop them, then carried on as if he had merely swatted at a fly as opposed to almost

destroying two hundred dollars worth of decor that Nikki would have had a fit about. "We have any Gatorade?"

He scanned the fridge while Jack considered his options. Cole would have Jen Bruce's kid's (whoever this was) number, surely. All he had to do was ask him.

"We gotta stop by Mac's," Cole concluded, closing the fridge as roughly as humanly possible, which was how he did everything these days.

"We better get going then," Jack said, hesitantly.

Cole looked back at him. After a few moments of awkward silence, Cole raised his eyebrows. "Okay... so... should we... *do* that?"

Jack put it to himself this way: he would be a bad parent for skipping Cole's match.

He *had* tried to contact Nikki.

It wasn't like he was setting some kind of trap.

Even if it felt that way, even if it had the incidental effect of sort of doing just that. And even if the thought of that trap springing closed was perversely thrilling.

*

He turned his notifications off for the duration of the match. This wasn't his standard MO, and Nikki would surely know that, but Jack was on a mission to prove something... to somebody... and so he did it, and was treated to a weird little dose of pleasure as he did.

So he missed Nikki's texts, the first of which came through a little past seven.

Which burned, with a vaguely pleasing aftertaste, like too-strong booze.

Shit. I'm so sorry - forgot to turn my phone on. Cole should have Jamie's number did you try that?

And then a call. No message.

And then nothing for an hour.

Then a picture of her at a bar, her arms around a female who Jack didn't know but assumed was a paramedic. Nikki was smiling, the girl was smiling, their foreheads were tipped toward each other like they had started laughing about something mid-photo. Both women's hands were in the picture: not a selfie. Again. Behind the two drunk attractive women with their mouths open in wide, vaguely sexual smiles were several navy t-shirts plumped into the wide, brawny torso of what Jack could only assume were the chests of tactical team police officers. Very, very male police. A holstered gun could be seen through a triangle space between Nikki's arm and the shoulder of the other woman.

Your missing a good time.

Text absolutely, with zero doubt of any kind, not written by Nikki, who began showing signs of stroke when people misplaced apostrophes and could not be compelled to make the same mistake herself for any reason, including large sums of money.

Let alone for the kind of multi-layered, sexually torturous "joke" she would be making by suggesting that someone *else* took this photo and then sent it to her husband, using her phone.

And abusing written grammar, to boot.

He decided to let it simmer a little, pocketed his phone, and threw himself into conversation with the parents after the match. They were all going to Pizza Hut. Cole wanted to go along.

"Sure, yeah... uh, buddy do you mind if I head home? I have a bunch of work to wrap up."

Of course he didn't mind - he was fifteen and had his sights pretty obviously set on one of the cheerleaders going with them.

Nikki had, by then, texted again.

That last message was NOT from me.

WHERE ARE YOU?!!!

He drove home. He wasn't sure what he was doing or what game he was playing. Some version of tit-for-tat, Nikki's "tat" being not calling at five to make sure he got Jen Bruce's number, and then not answering his text.

When he got home, he saw that Nikki had *called*, but not left a message.

Nikki had sent another photo. Her arm extended from the left side of the screen to her shoulder, indicating an actual selfie. Angie, their firefighter friend, was in the picture, her face a little blurry because she had turned her head at the last minute to shout something at someone and the lighting was dim.

Look who I found

A text from Angie, whose number was not stored in his phone, followed.

*Dont come down her an cockatoo me you fucking asd.
But seriously where ru dipshit good times being had*

He called Nikki. No answer.

By then it was getting late - by his calculations, Nikki had been out drinking (and obviously tying one on) for almost seven hours. *Surely* she would be heading home soon. Surely she would ask him to give her a ride.

Do you need me to come pick you up?

He checked the calendar to confirm: Nikki was on shift starting tomorrow at two. Nikki was possibly the only paramedic with more than five years of experience who still hewed to the alcohol regulations, which told everyone in no uncertain terms that they should be able to get a 100% clean for alcohol blood test if they reported to duty.

Surely she was keeping this in mind, annoying calculating her BAC and overestimating the time it would take her to metabolize it to zero, then tacking ten hours onto that.

He looked at the pictures again. It didn't look especially *calibrated* from that POV.

He called again, not expecting her to answer, but for some reason not forming his message ahead of time.

"Hey," he said, and his voice annoyed even him. "Just looking at the calendar here and it looks like you're on tomorrow at fourteen hundred hours. I can come pick you up if you tell me where you are."

And nothing.

Jack set himself to work in the office, but got nothing done. Checking his phone every minute, he stared into a wall of regulatory text, seeing nothing, thinking only of all the possibilities, the nightmares and fantasies, of what Nikki could be doing.

When a text arrived it gave him a jolt, and he fumbled his phone. The breathless anticipation and rapid heart rate of his younger, single years gripped him.

Angie again.

Hey dumb ass i am taking your wifi home w me

And then the money shot in Jack's tame-porno fantasy:

A photo of Nikki, flush speckling her cheeks alluringly. A big smile, eyes not directed at the camera. Mouth open wide, eyes glittering, hand in the air to wave in the general direction of the phone, lips shimmering with freshly applied lipgloss. Obviously drunk. Tight sea green t-shirt that Jack didn't recognize and wasn't the same shirt she'd been wearing in previous photos, but which gave her eyes an appetizing green glint.

One hand holding a beer bottle and resting on a dark brown bicep. Body squeezed between two walls of male musculature - really squeezed, her breasts smashed a little against her chest. Her golden halo of hair back-lit, caught in the moment just before...

Before what? Which way was Nikki squeezing - out toward whatever was behind them, in toward one of those guys, or in between, moving toward Angie? His eyes fixated on his wife's left hand, the simple gold band of their wedding ring glittered on her fingers, which were splayed against the dark skin next to her, her palm against the bulging muscle.

Jack stared into it as if they would suddenly turn into a video, start moving, start touching each other even more. What *had happened* after this picture was taken? He let his mind wander, and things turned raunchy almost immediately: the black guy slid his arm around Nikki's waist, pulled her out to a dance floor, started dry-humping her, Nikki was drunk so she leaned in

a little more than she should, felt his huge cock against her, and lost all control of herself.

By now they were in the bathroom, smashing into a stall, making out.

Jack shook himself free of the fantasy and looked at the message again.

Angie was taking Nikki home. There was nothing weird about this, and nothing wild was going to happen. Angie was a responsible person and she worked shifts with Nikki out of the same base station; she, too, had a vested interest in getting Nikki home and sobering up so Nikki wouldn't call in to work the next day. *Everybody* hated floaters on their shift.

As he talked himself down from the mild hysteria and excitement he had worked himself up to, his phone rang and the picture disappeared. Nikki was calling.

A jolt. It had the ice-cold feel of getting caught, the allure of a chance sexual encounter, the feeling that came with realizing you had found the woman you were obsessed with but didn't know if you could lock down. It was exhilarating, even if it lurked in his bowels as a fang-toothed monster of fear.

He answered by answering and saying nothing. Loud music and the clatter of a busy bar blared in his ear.

"- just talking to you about it like five... hey, hold on, what...? Babe? Hello?"

"Yes," Jack said.

"Oh. Hey, didn't hear you pick up," Nikki said, clueless to his tone. Her words slurred a little, and she was obviously drunk, but more obviously on a high, as Nikki tended to get whenever she won something or got the best

score on something, even if it was a health and safety review or something similarly unimportant. "Hi. Hey. Yeah, so -"

"Great job on your test," Jack said abruptly.

"Thank *you*," Nikki said, primly, as she always did right before yelling something. "I fucking nailed it!!!" she shouted. A chorus of voices repeated this cry in the background, and Jack tamped down his irritation, because Nikki almost forgot she was on the phone for a moment.

"So you're calling..." Jack prompted.

"Oh, shit, yes, sorry. I'm glad I got a hold of you -"

"I already *told him*," Angie's voice broke in. "I sent him a message."

"Angie's not *driving* you home, is she?"

Nikki didn't respond to this, but it was likely because she found the question absurd. Firefighters didn't do things like drive drunk or start bar brawls or even road rage, because it was one of the few jobs in the world where you could both get easily fired for bad conduct outside of work and there was zero corruption about enforcement of that rule.

"She can just take me in tomorrow so I'm gonna stay with her."

"I can come get you if you want. Or take a cab. Where are -?"

"Ugh, it's just so much easier this way, honey. It saves me about two hours of driving..." The sound had steadily dampened as Niki was talking; she was moving away from the noise into another part of the bar, probably a corridor near the bathrooms. The music was muffled. "...so... anyway... "

"Are you sure you're going home with *Angie*?"

The question had sprouted up from the dark, fertile soil of his fantasy mind, and somehow escaped to his consciousness and leaped into his mouth. Even as his own tongue formed the consonants, he was as shocked to hear it as if someone else was speaking.

There was a horrible beat of time, seemingly endless, while he waited to see how she would take it, his insides roiling. He was already mounting a defense. It was just a *joke*, Nikki...

"Well. I mean, that's the *story*," Nikki said, deadpan. So rarely did Nikki deadpan anything successfully that Jack was, for a long moment, in free-fall.

Nikki snorted, shaking him from his stupor. It was her laugh when something was too silly even for her.

"I see," he said, playing along, rushing it a little. "But you're actually going home with one of your cop buddies."

"The black guy," Nikki said, faster than he thought she could think of a joke like that. "Tony."

These jokes, after all, weren't Nikki's *thing*.

They were *his* thing. And he had only very, very recently even alluded to them with Nikki.

"Oh, yeah?" Jack said.

"Yep," Nikki said, making her "p" pop, airy and wet, at the end. "Just gonna tell my husband that I'm going home with Angie, but in reality, I have Tony right in front of me, and I'm pulling my fingers down his chest, and winking at him, and I plan to go home with him, and have all kinds of really dirty sex."

Jack was too stunned to think, let alone say anything.

"You there?"

"Uh... yeah. Yes. Here. That is... a... very..."

"Naughty plan?"

"Yes," Jack breathed. His mind had placed the black bicep on a huge black man and he was envisioning Nikki's fingers walking up and down his chest, her eyes fluttering, her glossed lips smiling, while she talked to her husband on the phone.

"Well, I didn't really have... any other... choice..."

Nikki was now leaving pauses, sensual and mysterious, between words. Surely they were deliberate, and a joke, and Jack knew that... but they could also, very easily, have been accidental, caused by distractions...

Caused by a single, muscled, dark distraction...

"My husband, you see, didn't make it to the bar, and I'm just feeling so... so..." Nikki gasped theatrically, a sure sign that she was joking and wanted him to know it, "...so... horny and..." Nikki paused, obviously having a hard time coming up with a word. "And...sexual... after rolling around on the floor while Tony watched me and put his hands.... together... and clapped... oh!"

She had already started laughing after blurting "sexual," which was, admittedly, ham-fisted. But the rest had been hot as fuck, even if she wasn't taking it seriously.

In fact, it was almost hotter because she wasn't taking it seriously.

He had an impish, horrifying thought: what if she was making fun of him, and his fantasy, deliberately, *and* this Tony character was right there in front of her, her hands walking down his rock-hard abdomen to the bulge in his tactical pants.

Jack laughed as gamely as he could muster. "Okay, honey. Just have a good time and don't be late for shift."

"Mmm. Uh... okay. So you don't want like, pictures, or anything like that?"

Jack exhaled sharply. "Well, yeah, pictures, of course."

"Videos...?"

Nikki was silly drunk, he could tell.

But didn't the adage go: you can't make people do something when they're drunk that they would never do sober?

"Nikki..." he breathed. "That's so... hot."

"Or I could, you know, call you, right in the middle of things, and pretend like I'm trying to hide that I'm actually - OH! GOD! JESUS CHRIST!"

Nikki burst out screaming and laughing all at the same time, and the phone clattered to the floor.

"Whatcha doin' there, Hillier, talkin' dirty to your old man?" a passing male voice said.

Some shuffling. Nikki laughing.

An unbearable quiet, muffled few moments.

"Oh my *God*," Nikki said, whispering, laughter in the back of her throat.

"*That* was close. Okay, so... *the actual plan*... Angie lives like two blocks from here, we're leaving as soon as we have to stop drinking, which for me

is in... ten minutes. So... I'll call you tomorrow? Sound good? I'm in for two, maybe we can have lunch or something?"

Jack was clutching his chest. "Uh... okay, yeah... okay... so what did -?"

"I gotta run, babe," Nikki said quickly. "Love you, bye."

CHAPTER 5

Nikki was dressed in a crisp blue t-shirt with unicorns on it, which was obviously a loan from Angie, and tactical pants that seemed to be her own. She was already seated in their favorite booth at The Diner, another EMS hangout strategically located between their respective bases, and, importantly, along major transportation arteries so the ambulances could pick things up while on duty.

Her hair was neatly swept up in her usual ponytail - all business. She had some mascara on and maybe a limited dusting of foundation, and her eyes were bright and alive for someone who had woken up at eight am after a night of drinking, to text him a string of hearts, an apology for being so drunk, and a request to let her pay for lunch and "*pleasepleaseplease please please come. xoxoxoxoxo.*"

After last night's phone "tease," which had been sadly interrupted, he hadn't been positive about what to expect. He hadn't even been sure what he *wanted* to see: a part of him was darkly attracted to the idea of finding something amiss with Nikki, some detail that seemed out of place and betrayed an indiscretion. He had no idea what that would look like, or whether it was what he really wanted to find. The idea of it captured his full attention, his imagination, all night long and all the way to The Diner.

Nikki saw him right away and her face lit up just before she stuck a hand into the air and waved energetically at him.

He liked that Nikki did this every time she saw him when they were meeting up somewhere. It revealed a deeper truth, he felt, than he could ever uncover by asking her about it directly: Nikki really seemed to be

under the impression that a man could walk into a public place with the intention of meeting her, and not immediately be drawn to her, not immediately see her there. She actually thought he needed her to shove an excited hand into the air and flag him down, as if her glorious hair and the energy she radiated, and her bright, attractive features and general hotness wouldn't serve as a blinding beacon.

Not just to him: to everyone.

And this was the always-unnerving, bittersweet aspect of being married to Nikki: everywhere she went, she pulled attention - male attention - to her like a magnet.

No one was *staring* at her, or even looking in her direction: but that, in itself, was the tell. Not a single man in The Diner was looking up from his food *at all*. Which tended to be the scene everywhere, at least once Jack got there. Men inspecting their food like they thought there might be gold dust in it if they just bored into it with greater concentration. A lot of men looking out the window at the traffic like it was their job to direct it themselves.

As he passed by the booths, a few guys did the quick look-up: it was always fast, furtive, a size-up and a signal - in its brevity - that they had their hands off Nikki.

Or, at least, this is what Jack envisioned was happening. Maybe he was crazy, and Nikki was the sane one.

But he doubted it.

He slid into the booth across from her, his heart admittedly a little swollen with the very specific fluff of pride he got from being *the* man who got to sit down with Nikki.

She jumped up energetically and leaned across the table to kiss him.

"You look..." he began.

"Surprisingly not too shitty?" Nikki offered. She flipped a cup over and held a carafe of orange juice over it. "Don't tell Angie, but I started drinking soda waters with a lime after about ten."

"She didn't force you to do tequila shots?"

Nikki smiled, resting her head on her hand. "I used your trick," she said, doing an exaggerated wink.

Jack's "trick" was to agree to all of Angie's tequila shots, and then pour them into a glass with ice that he always ordered if Angie was even suspected of planning to show up. He walked around with it all night and called it an apple juice if anyone asked.

"Anyway... aren't you going to *congratulate* me?" she asked, fanning herself. "Top female time!" She blew on, and buffed her nails.

Jack smiled and clinked his orange juice against hers, bowing his head.

"Very well done," he said, meaning it. It *was* impressive.

Nikki leaned her elbows on the table, spreading them out to get closer to him. She chewed on her lower lip. "I'm sorry about all the confusion with Jen's number... sorry you couldn't make it. I really wanted you to come out, meet the team." She looked down, seeming a little hesitant. She put her hand out on his arm and squeezed it. "I got a little caught up in the moment, you know? And, I was maybe, just a tiny bit..." she squeezed her fingers together and squinted through them, "...drunk off my ass." She fluttered her eyelashes alluringly - it was anybody's guess if Nikki did this purposefully

or if it was just instinct, a natural flutter with nothing behind it. "I wouldn't be able to do any of this without your support."

Of *course* this stabbed him right through the heart, and he squeezed her arm back.

There was an unspoken chit on Nikki's side of the table in all of this: the only reason she was still slugging it out on the mean streets was because she had taken so much time off to have the kids, and had knocked back to part-time - an awful cesspool of shifting sands and drudge work, floating and getting called in for the worst shifts (Friday the 13ths, Halloween night, Christmas Day - a sad parade of fatal heart attacks and strokes with the whole extended family screaming and sobbing and tripping over IV lines and defib cables) - for years. That had all been done under a banner of Jack being the breadwinner and Nikki being the caregiver, and they had always implied, if not explicitly stated, that her time would come in the future.

And now it was here.

"I love you, Nikki," he said, overcome by a sudden wave of emotion.

Whenever he said this, something washed over Nikki, and watching it wash over her was more satisfying than watching her orgasm. She blinked slowly and a warm smile spread to her lips. "I love you, too," she said softly.

"But..." she sat back, her hand still on his. "I know you're not super thrilled about this."

Jack feigned confusion. "Oh, really?" he asked.

Nikki bounced her head side to side. "It's dangerous. Okay? I admit it is more dangerous than regular calls, if we ever go. And I know it's like... annoying, training is taking up a lot of time... I get that. So..." she sighed.

"Listen," she gripped his arm more tightly. "I haven't committed yet. I have

like a week to look over the offer, I have all the stuff..." she dove into a large purse next to her, to pull out a red folder (carefully labeled in neat handwriting). She set it on the table and looked at it seriously before looking back up at him. She squeezed his arm again. "I really, really want to do this," she said. "But it's an 'us' decision. And..." she leaned back, tipping her head to one side, shrugging up her shoulders. "I've been kind of... a little bit... one-sided about it." She met his eyes, melting his heart. "I'm sorry about that. So."

"So," he repeated, smiling.

Nikki had a really hard time apologizing, but what she lacked in deftness, she made up for in sincerity. "I really am," she whispered. "I was sort of a bull in a China shop about it."

Jack laughed quietly. It was a well-worn apology path.

Nikki shrugged again - adorably, and used her left hand to pour some cream into a coffee she was clearly no longer drinking, without letting go of his arm. "So... you know... look it over, think it over. I know that it..." she looked up at the ceiling, "I know it takes some time away from *us*, at the beginning anyway. And there isn't much of that to give up. I just, um... I don't know.... It kind of seems to have some... benefits, too." She said this last part quietly, and brought her gaze down to meet his, warily. "It gives us something *new* to talk about..."

Nikki moved her hand to draw a circle on the back of his hand. The motion traveled from his hand through his arm and straight to his cock, which twitched uneasily.

Jack stared back at her, his heart skipping a beat. The move was loaded with sexual implications - not something Nikki was particularly prone to doing,

especially not in the middle of the day, right before shift, and in a diner.

Nikki was looking at him expectantly.

"It definitely does," he said, still stunned.

Was Nikki talking about the same thing he was? Or was she thinking about the newfound knowledge of mag capacities she would get?

Nikki was watching him closely. She smiled a little sheepishly, opened her mouth as if to say something, and then pulled back suddenly, biting her lip and leaning back. "Okay. Well. The ball's in your court, then," she said, and shifted her gaze out the window, still smiling.

They enjoyed the moment for a few minutes, without saying anything else. Jack was searching for the right words, a way of bringing up the teasing conversation from last night, a way to feel out what, *exactly*, this "something new to talk about" might be. Nikki smiled at him and sipped a water, he looked at the menu, and he was just getting geared up to reintroduce the topic in a neutral, friendly way and feel it out ("So about that phone call last night...?") when all hell began to break loose, as it did frequently at The Diner.

There is a buzz that precedes an incoming call on radios and pagers. It doesn't exist, according to experts and the laws of science, but anyone in emergency services will tell you they feel it. "Like the shockwave," Mike would say. "The one that makes dogs go nuts before an earthquake."

Mike was nuts, but on this matter he was actually correct.

By the time you feel it and register it, it's already happening, but there a ghostly few seconds when radio waves make something tingle in the air. If there are enough people with radios about to get toned out in the room,

there is a shift in the mood, a flutter of disturbance that travels lightning-quick from face to face, coils up in the muscles, starts spiking adrenaline and setting the trained reaction to squash it before the sound even comes through.

The rumbling came first, from the pagers. Hitting each one at a slightly different time. Sighs. Forks dropping. Crackles on the radio.

Uniformed responders started looking alive, sitting up straight, arms going to their sides to adjust the volume. A lot of hands going to hips. Jack even felt the impulse to drop his hand to where his radio would be: old habits die hard.

One set of tones, and chairs started scraping on the floor. Waitresses, accustomed to the whole routine, started pivoting toward the customers who were starting to stand up, wiping their mouths, muttering curses. They lifted their chins as the responders called out that they'd settle up on the way back: there were systems in place for this at The Diner and no one ever stiffed the bill: that was the deal. Nikki's attention turned inward, even though she was looking right at Jack: she was listening for the call.

More tones, more chairs. More people filing by. Nikki looked up as some firefighters filed by, her eyes wide and eyebrows raised. Through the many dispatch streams erupting all over, Jack heard "structural collapse."

Nikki picked up her coffee mug and brought it to her lips with both hands, watching the action. "Jesus," she said. Half the diner was leaving. She looked at Jack over the coffee mug.

Disaster. Nikki liked to play it cool, but she lived for the big calls. Jack felt a pang of disappointment himself. Everything about his current job was a better choice for everyone, including himself. But there was nothing that

could replace the feeling of getting called to a total shitshow. It was a helluva drug.

"Where's it at?" she whispered. "Did you hear?"

"Don't drink that," he cautioned her, smiling, eyes on her mug of creamer.

Nikki looked into the mug and snorted. "Thanks," she said, raising it for a toast. She was desperately trying to act like she didn't care about what was happening, even though, if it was in her area or her hall got called to respond, and it really was a shitshow, she'd end up on scene. Nikki was the kind to report early in this kind of situation, the kind who wanted to get there first and into the fray, as opposed to being relegated to clean-up or telling firefighters to stay in rehab, which was a lot like trying to keep third-graders in time out.

It was actually incredibly romantic of her, Jack thought, to continue sitting there. Her rabbit-like energy was boiling inside her.

She looked over the mug at him, squirming a little. Over all the fracas, her phone was starting to ping. Sirens were erupting in every direction, all three kinds, and the flash of blue, red, and strobe lights glinted in the windows of the skyscrapers around them. But Nikki held onto her cup, and smiled at Jack. She was, after all, not due at the station for an hour.

Jack let the display of loyalty wash over him, warm and satisfying, for a few minutes. Nikki clutched her mug, obviously dying to check her phone, but with her eyes on him. A fire truck went by and Nikki's eyes darted to it, probably to see which company it was and try to guess where it was headed.

Jack shook his head. "Check your phone," he said.

"I have no interest in that," Nikki said, closing her eyes and smiling.

"I'll get the bill," he said. Nikki opened her eyes and looked at him, then reached for her phone but held it, still waiting. *Really?* her expression said.

"You look like a golden retriever waiting for someone to throw the ball again," he told her, laughing. "It seems pretty big. Go get it."

Nikki seized her phone, swept through a few apps and messages, opened her mouth in amazement, and then closed her eyes, clutching her phone.

This was the moment of Zen. You had to pull your shit together so you didn't go off half-cocked. Everyone had different levels of adrenaline to combat, and everyone had different ways of doing it.

She stood up. Her movements, adorably messy and careless when she was off the clock, became meticulous and careful. She was running checklists, patting her pockets, ticking off boxes, thinking ahead to her best route to the station to avoid emergency vehicles. "It's in High Park," she said, monotone, as if she was a dispatcher. "Building collapse, explosion. I'm taking Reid Street to Bancroft and cutting over on River -"

"How many alarms?"

Nikki looked out the window and gestured. "A lot..."

"Sixty-seven will respond down River. Take Bancroft all the way to Ursula." This much, he could definitely help with.

Nikki recalculated her route in her head, looking up at the ceiling, smiled, and leaned over to kiss Jack. "You really are my hero," she said, her hand lingering on his chin. She was about to depart when she rubbed his face again and grinned. "Scruffy," she said. "I like it." She kissed him again, grabbing his hair with her fingers and pulling it taut for a moment. "Thank you."

And then she hopped away, trotting down the steps and onto the sidewalk, passing him as she walked purposefully to the car, one hand holding her phone. Jack watched her, figuring she was in the zone. But as she passed, talking into her phone, her face set in EMS mode, her jaw moving the way it did when she calmly spat out orders and information, she turned her head and looked up at him. She bent her pinky finger a couple of times and smiled.

CHAPTER 6

God.

After Nikki's nearly incessant requests, he had agreed to meet "the team" at Stripey's, which was open to the public and frequented by first responders of all denominations, but also the sort of place that you didn't pop into if you weren't on friendly terms with at least one cop who went there as well.

It was a cop bar, and everyone knew it - even civilians, who took one look around and walked right out when the hordes of thick-set, off-duty cops with clean-shaven heads and an air of permanent aggravation glared at them from their perches.

Jack was a critical care paramedic who had worked in High Park, and he had a lot of "buddies" on the force because of that - those guys didn't forget you when you saved them from bleeding out. But he'd been in his administrative position for years now, and consequently lost a lot of the associated status that only working in the shit up to your elbows could get you with the cops. Cops and firefighters, and fire paramedics like Nikki, worked in a different universe, one of strict hierarchies and primitive social structures where the only thing that got you any respect was doing a really good job doing something nobody else wanted to do.

On the street, that is.

Administrative duty, unless it was imposed upon you after a life-threatening injury, didn't make the cut.

Another thing that Nikki seemed incapable of understanding was the mentality of people like that, or maybe it was better stated, of *men* like that.

Policing and firefighting, and also military service, all of which usually traveled together, tapped into some fierce primordial instincts for men. The women who - very competently - served with them just ran around completely clueless about it, though.

And there was no explaining it to them without getting your ass chewed.

Just because you were doing a *good job* as a woman did not free you from the instincts of men to want to protect women. Especially from the instincts of men who went into a career that was specifically about doing that very thing, if you drilled right down to the very center of it.

Not very many cops or firefighters envisioned themselves saving *men* when they fantasized about being heroes.

This truth, in turn, caused all sorts of fucking problems - most of them logistical and mental - and Jack had yet to meet a woman who understood that. Or a man, for that matter, who was tapped into his emotions enough to understand that *that* was the real reason he didn't "want any goddamn broads on his shift."

"Sexist," Angie had declared, right after slamming 45 ounces of beer and winning an arm wrestling competition with a beefy cop while listening to Jack try to explain these thoughts one night.

Angie's crew loved her, and she was a super-competent firefighter. Jack had been drunk and talking out of his ass, expressing this exact viewpoint - about the protecting and saving and how it made it hard for men to do their jobs with women because of it - to Angie and part of her crew while he waited for Nikki and her partner to dump their patient at the hospital, two hours after their shift had been slated to end.

"You," Angie had said, pointing a finger at his eye, "Are going to retract that bullshit or I am going to pick you up and throw you out of this bar myself."

"I retract," Jack had wisely and immediately said, because Angie was fully capable of throwing almost anyone but Big Mike (350 pounds) over her shoulder, and she had red hair, and she was drunk and would therefore probably do it. "I am an idiot and I am sorry I ever suggested such a thing."

This had satisfied Angie, who strolled over to the bar to start another arm wrestling championship.

Her crew -all men - had taken turns patting him on the shoulder after she left. "Good call, buddy."

Harrison, though, who had a mortally wounding crush on Angie that all men could see from ten miles away ("Nah," had been Nikki's clueless verdict), pressed his lips together and drank his beer before leaning over the table and saying, in a low voice, "You ain't wrong though, man."

It was the kind of impossible problem that women were always causing. On the one hand, Jack himself and most guys he knew were happy to have them around. They smelled nice, they kept guys from getting way out of line and descending into a testosterone-fueled fever dream, and admittedly, they consistently did a better job at almost everything to do with people, communication, paperwork, safety, and peacemaking, which were all things very much required out there.

But no man worth his salt could shake the feeling that it was *unnerving*, and even a little bit *unnatural*, to be deliberately putting women into clear and present danger. Even the ones you didn't particularly like, but especially the ones that you obviously did. No matter what you did, no matter how much

you held the intellectual belief that women were equals, it gnawed at you that you had just sent a woman into the very situation that you felt much more hardwired to protect them *from*.

Nikki was still clueless to all of this, even if Jack had made numerous attempts to explain it (since every woman in fire services, at least, seemed clueless about it as well).

But perhaps even more disconcerting than any of *this* was being a man - like him - who allowed *other men* to put his wife in danger - knowing, as they all did, all of *that*.

And then showing up at a bar where they were all hanging out together.

Fairly emasculating.

But he obviously couldn't say any of that to Nikki, who, like Angie, dismissed discussions of this type as "sexist."

So here he was, standing at the doorstep of Stripey's, to go "hang out" and "meet" the "team" that Nikki was training with.

He had expected a clichéd scene, straight out of a Hollywood police movie: he'd open the door and all the stern-faced, bulky cops would turn simultaneously to stare at him. The music would stop. Nikki would save him, but the damage would be done. He'd probably trip over the threshold for good measure, like an ass.

The air was stale and glittered with dust in the sunlight pouring through a window near the back, where a smashed set of blinds hanging from a single thread indicated a brawl had broken out recently. But it was sparsely crowded, and nobody turned to look at him at all. He breathed a sigh of relief when he saw that Nikki and her "team" were practically the only

people in the bar, which made sense because it was in the dead middle of shifts and a Sunday.

Nikki's glorious nasalized laugh broke through the stale air right away, and that was when Jack's relief faded and was replaced by a wish that more people *had* been in the bar, to better serve as fake distractions. Nikki was sitting on top of a tall barstool, swinging one leg seductively with the other folded up to her ass so that she could rest her chin on her knee. Her hair was loose and she had her mouth open in the generous smile that was easily her sexiest feature.

And standing right in front of her was the largest black man Jack had ever seen.

Okay, not the largest he'd ever seen, but the largest he's ever seen standing upright and walking around. The man had to be 6'5" tall at least, with a massive chest that meant real business, and biceps that meant he wanted everyone to know he meant real business - even the people who didn't know what part of the body that real business actually came from. Something in his stance marked him as a boxer: a permanently coiled energy, ready to be set loose.

Nikki was talking to him, her hands out in front of her, her eyes on his face, hanging on his every word, her big smile for whatever he was saying.

A sexual sensation - but not entirely thrilling - vibrated through the center of Jack's body before settling into a dull and uncomfortable coolness in his lower abdomen.

It would have been ideal if the bar had been more crowded, he thought for the second time. He could have spun around and left.

Not that Nikki was paying any attention to the door, and not that the team - all men, of course - were paying attention to the door either. They were scattered around Nikki, who was for some reason sitting on this tall barstool next to the ordinary seating tables, and so was perched like a princess on a throne. They may have been looking at other things, or moving their mouths like they were having a conversation, but Jack knew as well as any guy that Nikki - the lone woman in the bar, her coltish leg folded up like that, the glimmer in her blue eyes - was at the forefront of everyone's mind, and peripheral vision, and twitching cock.

Nikki laughed mirthfully and tipped her head back as Jack approached the group. "Oh no way," she bubbled.

Flirtatiously.

"Do it again?" she asked her tall dark companion, and they held their fists out toward each other.

Three of Nikki's balled-up tiny hands would have fit inside his grip.

She noticed Jack then, and hopped immediately off the stool. "Hey!" she squealed, like she was greeting some old girlfriend from school. "You made it."

Nikki's tone carved through him like a paring knife in her expert hands. He couldn't say why. It was too excited, too fluttery, too much like she was trying to cover something up or keep everyone off a certain topic. There was a frantic, hurried air to the way she did everything: the way she hopped off the stool, the way she hugged him and patted him on the back, the zealousness with which she took him by the arm.

And anyway, there had never been any question of him "making it" to the bar.

"Yeah," Jack said, imitating her weird tone. "I have Sunday's o-o-off."

It might have gotten weird from there, because Nikki looked a little aggravated by the way he said that - indeed, that he even had - and Jack was already picturing a scene.

But the huge black guy thrust a hand the size of a shovel at him.

"Tony," he said simply.

He was that kind of guy.

Jack went in about as hard as he could and clasped as firmly as he could muster for a brief and violent shake. "Jack."

Tony's eyes went from Jack to Nikki and back again, calculating.

It wasn't the first time other men had done this very same thing to Jack: usually it made him feel good, because he got the sense that it raised him in the esteem of most men. Like he had to have *something* that had attracted the beautiful and likable Nikki to him.

It *was* the first time one of these men was meeting him as the desk-jockey husband who let his wife go play tactical paramedic with the cops, and so it went over quite a bit differently. Jack could see from Tony's size-up that Tony wasn't looking for a way to esteem Jack more, but rather, less.

And he was possibly succeeding.

It didn't help that he was looking down at Jack, who came in just under six feet tall. In Jack's experience, cops tended to size the world up almost entirely by size.

Tony's eyes looked Jack up and down - not hiding what he was doing - and things felt close to getting awkward, when he abruptly turned his head and

yelled at the bartender. "Hey man, get Jack here one of them, too."

"We're having Car Bombs," Nikki said giddily, clutching Jack's arm.

"Yeah..." Jack said, uneasily. This was the kind of situation he didn't know how to get out of: he didn't *want* the drink, or to drink in front of six cops and then drive off, but he also didn't see a way to politely refuse Tony. Who seemed like he was daring him to do just that.

On top of everything else, this was no sipping beer.

Nikki squeezed his arm and said - literally incomprehensibly - "I'm glad you're here, I have to pee. Save my seat."

Jack glanced at Nikki's throne, and then sideways at the empty bar. "I can do that," he told her. She kissed him on the cheek and bounced away.

"Got a real live wire, there," Tony commented, as they both watched Nikki hop away.

Jack inhaled through clenched teeth. "Yeah," he agreed. He looked back at Tony, who was laughing to himself and still had his eyes on Nikki's retreating form. "Don't I know it." Jack moved closer to the bar, where the bartender was taking his sweet time making seven Car Bombs, with one empty glass out for him.

Tony moved with him and leaned on the bar. "Guess you don't have much say over what she gets in her head," he said smoothly. Jack bristled, but he didn't have Tony quite sized-up yet. He had adopted a folksy, fatherly tone, so it seemed more like he was working *on* Jack than anything else.

Jack put his elbows on the bar and squinted at the bottles of alcohol behind it. "Not with Nikki," he agreed.

"Yeah, she seems like the type does whatever the hell she wants," Tony chuckled. Jack looked over at him: it was a reflex, he did it without thinking.

"Within *reason*," Tony clarified.

"Not always."

They laughed uneasily together. Jack's insides felt like someone had applied a layer of cold pack gel to the inside of his skin, but overall, things were going relatively well. He sized up the rest of the crew, who had not said anything to him yet.

It wasn't that strange. Cops were suspiciously like gangs, and Tony was obviously the Big Man here. They'd introduce themselves if and when Tony told them to.

"You that guy saved Jimmy Brighton."

This wasn't a question. It was a statement awaiting confirmation. "Uh..." Jack said.

"This would be about six years ago, gunshot wound?"

The wolves were listening, Jack noted.

The only problem he had was, he didn't know if Jimmy Brighton was a cop, or a thug. A lot was riding on that important piece of information, because if Jimmy was a cop, he was in good with the gang of men who would apparently be protecting his wife from gunshot wounds.

And if Jimmy had been a thug who was back out on the streets after Jack saved his life?

That might not go over so well.

Jack looked at Tony again. Tony was revealing *nothing*.

"This a cop?" Jack asked. "You gotta narrow it down a little, you guys get shot up all the time."

"Nah," Tony said, pointing a finger at him. A stab of fear went through Jack's chest along the same trajectory, almost like Tony had flung a projectile through him at the same time. "I remember you."

He began the next sentence almost immediately afterward, but to Jack it felt like three hundred years later. "Guys, this here the medic saved Jimmy Brighton." He leaned toward Jack. "Nicked his femoral. Shattered femur. That warehouse deal."

Tony's gang of brothers were stirring now, but the energy was decidedly more positive than before. He ventured a glance in their direction and lifted his fingers up from the bar. He got a few nods back.

He remembered Jimmy Brighton now, and was pretty relieved: if anything, that had been one of his better days, and he really did deserve some credit for saving his life.

"How come *you* ain't up for this job?" Tony asked, pouring water all over Jack's temporary fire of pride. He had a glass partway to his lips and his eyes had narrowed. "We could really use a guy like you."

Jack has a line all ready for this line of questioning, and he deployed it frequently. It rolled off the tongue. "Nikki's the adrenaline junkie," he said, chuckling the way he always did when he was forced to explain why Nikki was the one still doing dangerous things while he worked away in Admin.

He could see that Tony, like most cops who still got out on the streets, did not think much of this explanation. Jack leaned in a little to say the second

part of the explanation - and it really was the true one - in a low voice so he didn't sound like too big of a dick. "I sold out for the better pay, if I gotta be honest."

Men could understand *that*. Especially if they meant Nikki, because the explanation that Nikki was expensive jived with their preconceived notions of relationships: *something* had to attract a good-looking woman like that to an average man like him. Nikki's explanation ("I just *love* him!") never satisfied the male mind.

It was a real primordial soup at this level of first response. "Big dick," "more money," "knows how to ventilate a roof like a boss," "has lots of guns," were all understandable reasons. "Love" was not.

The Car Bombs were ready - except for Jack's, which was still sitting empty in the line-up. The bartender gave him a look of irritation as he set the filled glasses on the bar. Tony used his enormous hand to shovel three of the drinks away from the line on the bar, while he looked thoughtfully above Jack's head. He took a sip of the drink he already had and nodded. "Yeah, well. We gotta do what we gotta do to keep the missus happy."

Jack breathed easy for a moment.

Guys could understand this: you did what you had to do.

"Still," Tony reflected, and then looked at Jack conspiratorially for a moment, then around the bar, almost like a guy about to make a racist joke. "You can't tell me you ain't got no problem with it."

"With my wife? Being on a tactical team? Nah," Jack joked. "I love it."

Tony was looking at him. Sizing him up. It was a terrifying few seconds.

But Tony laughed in the end. It was a scary, bad-guy kind of laugh, the kind of thing that gave you the impression that you were still in a boatload of trouble. "Yeah, well, I guess you don't get much say about it."

It was hard for Jack to know how to take this. He smiled. "Sounds like you know Nikki."

"Oh it ain't just her," Tony said, shaking his head. He turned abruptly to the guys at the table. "Slivovitz, man, come get these drinks." But just as quickly, he had turned back toward Jack and moved his head closer, as though confiding in him. "You know what I mean? It's all these chicks... gettin' so you can barely say anything about it out loud, right? I sure as hell wouldn't want *my* woman on the job." He clapped his enormous hand on Jack's shoulder, destabilizing him with the first blow so that Jack had to brace himself a little on the bar. "She's in good hands, though."

"I see that," Jack said amicably, and also because he didn't really feel like getting beat up, which never seemed especially far away whenever he found himself in the company of two or more cops, even if it had never happened.

"Anyway," Tony said, as if he had just given a too-lengthy speech and thought it was best to wrap it up. "She's tiny and she does exactly what I say. Which is how I like 'em."

Nikki was popping along on her way back from the restrooms by then, so Tony's attention swiftly - and thankfully - was drawn away from Jack's reaction.

Jack watched his wife, who wasn't especially *tiny* at 5'5," while he weighed the possibilities of Tony making a clever sexual joke that just happened to touch on the most erotic of Jack's fantasies, against the likelihood that the

comment was more benign, and Jack was just hearing what he wanted to in it.

"All *right*," Tony said, handing a Car Bomb to Nikki, who took it and smiled at Tony, then Jack.

"This your old man, Hiller?" Another broad-shouldered cop was at the bar, eying Jack and using one huge hand to hold onto three pint glasses by sheer finger strength and zero technique.

Nikki slipped her arm into Jack's and squeezed him to her side while bubbling with her strange energy. "It *is*. This is Jackson. Jackson, these are the guys... Tony you know, Slivovitz, Mike, Dan, and Pops." She pointed at them one by one, and Jack nodded in return to each of their stern nods.

Jack smiled and gave everyone the quick, palms-down wave that they all gave each other on scene. "Nobody but Nikki calls me Jackson," he said.

Nikki squeezed him, still talking. "Don't worry, there's also Kiley, she's another paramedic, and you know, do you remember from a long time ago, I had a shift with a floater I really liked, and we ended up at that gas explosion together? Probably not. Anyway she's in our group, too." Nikki smiled at him and squeezed his hand. "Just so, you know. You know. They're usually here, too."

"Instead of all buff guys," Jack said, smiling back.

Nikki had been expecting this, he could see, and she looked to Tony for sympathy. "See?"

"Don't worry, there, Jackson," Slivovitz said, handing his beer off to another guy who had come up behind him to shuttle the drinks. "We got your wife's ass *all* covered."

"Yeah," another guy added, coming up from behind Slivovitz, the same grin on his face. "We'll teach her how to handle *all* our guns."

And then they laughed, and Jack supposed that from Nikki's perspective this all looked like the typical shit-shooting and trash-talking that went on among the guys.

But it wasn't, not exactly: there was plenty of subtext.

Maybe too much subtext?

Jack's heart was racing, and his circulation was going haywire. His heart seemed unable to decide what speed to beat at, and his brain was telling his blood to go in two different directions at once. He had the distinct and sickening sensation - which he hadn't felt for a long time - of being "amped up." The kind of jittery, tunnel-visioned adrenaline that was jolted into his veins long ago when the tones dropped for a call, or someone pulled out a gun, or any of the other myriad of things that had once screamed "emergency" to him and no longer did.

Tony, though, glared at them.

It was a subtle glare, but effective: Slivovitz was almost sheepish as he practically interrupted himself mid-sentence. "Okay, guys. Down the hatch." He held his shot up, plunked it into the beer mug, and waited as the rest of them followed. They all watched Nikki over the tops of their glasses as she expertly disposed of the drink. A creamy stream of foam escaped her lips and ran down her cheek from the center of her lower lip. She used one finger - Jack would say, salaciously - to wipe it up and into her mouth. He didn't have to look away from Nikki to know how that was received. A brief and loaded silence took place while she did this - clueless as always.

And then the usual cheers and hoots, a round of applause, but it was all a little subdued because Tony was still leveling everyone off at the dick with the semi-frigid look he was distributing to them.

He grinned at Nikki approvingly and leaned on the bar, folding his hands together. "*There's* a skill I can sign you off on already," he chuckled.

Jack's eyes shifted, as subtly as possible, to his wife, to gauge her reaction. Tony's words were neutral enough to be plausibly deniable, but his manner reached into Jack's gut like a fist and grabbed every nerve and every blood vessel connected to his cock and yanked them hard.

An ordinary Nikki reaction would have been sassy. Nikki cut guys off at the balls all the time - supervisors, coworkers, street urchins, candidates, drunks who opened their eyes and saw her tits and slurred something about them as a matter - purely - of observation. Nikki had a sharp, dick-slicing quip for them all, delivered perfectly: she didn't make people mad, but she let them know the score.

A real talent, actually.

Nikki looked at Tony, though, and smiled.

That was it.

Then she lifted her water glass and took a sip.

Then she slapped her hand on the table, remembering something. "Oh shoot!" she said. She craned her neck around. "Sliv - you're not getting off that easy, man." She twirled in her stool and hopped over to the table where Slivovitz and his friend had retreated.

They were all smiles about that. Most of them directed at Jack.

Tony chuckled, watching her. Languidly, he turned his great big head toward Jack. The grin looked a lot more sinister facing it head-on. His eyes went up and down Jack again, like he was appraising him, and something knowing glimmered in his eyes.

But whatever it was, he chuckled and brought another beer to his lips, giving Jack no explanation.

The next half hour went by without incident. Jack talked to Tony, and then to Mike, and the conversations were the typical exchange of unimportant, job-related information, another confirmation that Jack had, in fact, been the paramedic to "save" their buddy, and then things became awkwardly quiet and Nikki herself suggested that they head home.

CHAPTER 7

"So you're trying to tell me that you're not just like the tiniest, teeniest bit turned on by all these big dudes, with their big guns, saving you from dangerous criminals and being your bodyguards?"

Nikki rolled her eyes and leaned her head on the headrest, looking out her window. "Oh, yeah," she said softly. "It's so hot, especially if I'm like, packing someone's guts back into their abdomen with a big roll of gauze so that they can maybe salvage his colon and he won't need a shit bag. *Hot.*"

This was a usual Nikki answer, for sure.

But not Nikki's usual tone. It seemed rehearsed, delivered without really thinking about the words. Nikki's mind was definitely elsewhere, wherever her thoughts were, which judging by her long stare at nothing out the window, was inward.

To her darkest desires, Jack thought.

Hoped.

Feared.

Jack looked over at her after a long pause. His heart was in free-fall, sinking through his internal organs, twisting his insides. Nikki's mind really *was* on something else.

"I'm just saying. You know. I can understand how you might get, I don't know - to thinking," Jack ventured.

Okay, so it wasn't really "venturing." It was a compulsion. He was compulsively saying things he knew he probably shouldn't, and he wished he'd shut up, but he just couldn't stop himself.

"You know?" Nikki said, turning toward him, her tone suddenly confrontational. "Just because *you* couldn't go do a job with a bunch of like, hot, skinny twenty-year-old newbie medics without 'getting to thinking,'" (Nikki emphasized "thinking" by pantomiming a pair of tits) "doesn't necessarily mean that *I* can't."

"You have a job with nubile twenty-year-old medics? Hot, skinny ones?" Jack said, being deliberately overzealous to try and turn the whole thing into a joke.

Please God, he prayed. I will never get that close to the danger zone again, if only you save me today.

While she might have been on the edge of the fence before this comment, something about Nikki's mood tipped fully into the serious zone, and she folded her arms over her chest. "Right. Like that isn't every fucking workshop you teach. And do I go up to you afterward asking *you* if *you* aren't just the tiniest, teeniest bit turned on by all these hot, clueless girls who came to you and your big, big brain and your CCP seal for 'guidance?'"

Air quotes around the "guidance."

Nikki shifted sexily - and confrontationally - in her seat and looked at him. Her arms were crossed and she was getting pretty fired up, which wasn't an ideal situation.

"Actually," Jack said, and he knew it wasn't wise, but couldn't stop himself. "That's an excellent example. Because I can say for a fact that I do *not* get turned on by any of those girls."

Nikki scoffed loudly at this and faced the windshield. "Right."

"I don't," Jack said, and he was being fairly close to truthful.

"Okay. Well. There you go. *I* find that hard to believe, and *you* find it hard to believe what I'm saying."

Nikki jutted her chin out and began to fume.

"Hmm," Jack said.

But he couldn't let it go. It was reasonable, as far as reasoning went, but it also just completely missed the point.

"You know, I'm sorry Nikki, but no. I'm not letting you get away with that. I *don't* have a thing for all those girls. That is not even the same situation at all -"

"It is *exactly* the same situation -"

" - and anyway - oh, is it?" Jack interrupted himself and looked over at Nikki incredulously. She was pretty drunk, and he wished he had thought of that factor before starting this conversation. It was probably best just to let it go entirely.

But he didn't.

"When, exactly, was I popping out to the bar with all those little paramedics and having cosmos with them and then... I don't know, picking out throw pillows for their living room? Hmm?"

"What are you even *talking about*?" Nikki said, feigning a level of disbelief that wouldn't have been appropriate even if Jack had just tried to convince her he had two heads. Typically Nikki. Typically hyperbolic to win an argument.

"I'm just saying," Jack said, gripping the steering wheel. He wasn't even sure what he was arguing for at this point, and he wished - again - that he would shut up.

But knew that he wouldn't. "When was the last time I was like, oh, hey, you should meet my new workshop, which I only, by the way, have for the weekend, so come out and have some drinks with us, and then you get there and I'm like, I don't know, trying on clothes with them or something? Never."

"Trying on clothes," Nikki repeated sarcastically. "Seriously?"

"Nikki, honestly," Jack sighed. But a bug bit him, and he got fired up again. Clenching the steering wheel, he shifted in his seat and looked over at her.

"You know what? Yeah. Trying on clothes. Basically. That is the... I don't know. Female equivalent of what you were doing back there. Okay? You're out there with these guys, who I don't need to point out to you are pretty jacked up on testosterone to begin with, and then you're like, 'Oh hey, show me how to use that big gun, talk to me all night about tactical... whatever.' So yeah. Yes. That is the direct equivalent of if I went... you know, to the fitting rooms or whatever it is with those girls and watched them try on their clothes and said like, 'oh yeah, your ass looks hot in that.' Yes. Come to think of it: yes. This is exactly the mirror image of what you are doing."

Nikki looked, for a moment, like she was going to blow apart the universe. She stared out the window, but her irritation was simmering just beneath her skin. Her lips had formed a tight, pretty shape, but it was more downturned and tense than Jack liked to see.

He braced himself and was already looking for a place to pull over, because Nikki could really be something. His own heart was racing, and he'd scooped enough brains off the pavement than to drive a car in a hyper-agitated state like that.

But Nikki just exploded into laughter.

Jack drove on. Nikki was rolling her head from left to right on the headrest by then, laughing. "Where do you even...? How do you even *get there*?"

"Jesus, Nikki. How do you *not*?"

"I am doing a *job*, Jack. Not trying on fucking... clothes, asking if my ass looks -"

"I'm not saying that, Nikki, and you know that I'm not."

"Oh, okay," Nikki threw her hands up. "Because it sure as hell sound like you're -"

"I am *saying* that hanging out with a bunch of *cops* at the bar and talking to them about their guns is *like* me going to the bar with my students and having a Cosmo and asking them to do a fashion show or something."

He knew it was bad as soon as he said it, even if he did really believe in the logic of it.

Next to him, the air shimmered with the heat Nikki was giving off, and it was not the hot-hot kind.

He held up a finger. "I can see how you might have -"

"So... let me get this straight," Nikki said, icily. "A... tactical paramedic in training wants to go out with the team she's likely to be paired up with in a live fire, like, police emergency, with guns - for some beers and talk about their guns, and that is the same thing as if a bunch of freshly minted paramedics go to the bar with their instructor to show them their hot outfits?"

Jack shook his head and hung it a little. "Of course that's not what I'm saying."

"It sounds like what you said. It sounds exactly like what you said. Why would *I* even be *saying* this if you hadn't said it?" She huffed. "I sure wouldn't have thought it up all on my own, it's so *dumb*."

"The comparison," Jack said calmly, "Was between the clothes, and the guns. You know? Metaphorically. And just... I'm just trying to illustrate -"

"Please tell me," Nikki huffed.

Jack pressed his lips together. "What it like, means to a guy, like that - a cop, okay? - if some very good-looking woman is like, 'ooh, tell me about your guns.' Okay?"

Nikki was back to laughing at him, it looked like. She pointed her finger at her upturned palm.

"So in this metaphor, then - this is a metaphor right? Or the other one? Simile? Whatever. So in it, you are the good-looking woman, and the guns are new... 'outfits?' I believe that's what you said. 'Outfits.' Is that right?"

"I can see how this may have come across wrong -"

"Oh, that's good to hear," Nikki howled.

"Not everything is some... feminist bullshit, Nikki. It wasn't the best comparison, but it's like... on par with that, you know? Not about -"

"You're comparing the job that paramedics do to dress-up," Nikki said, leaning forward in her seat and raising her voice.

"I'm so... *not*. Nikki. Jesus."

Nikki slumped back in her seat, sighed, folded and re-folded her arms, and then glared out the windshield.

Then she laughed. "You're really not, are you?" she said, suddenly.

He turned to her, surprised. "No," he said. "No. And thank you. I am just saying, it is a little difficult to see how there's... zero, absolutely no, you know, attraction. At least on their part. Is all. Is that fair to say, at least?"

Nikki shrugged, but she smiled, which meant she was willing to agree.

"And *you* are the one who always says cops treat their guns like their dicks."

"I said that?" Nikki said. She thought about it and shrugged again. Another smile. "Yeah, okay."

"Okay," Jack said. "So I'm just saying... it's... a little difficult, from a man's perspective, to, you know, not get any ideas about any of that. Is all I'm saying."

Nikki was silent for a moment.

"Wait. Is this you, or them?"

"What?"

"Getting ideas?"

Jack was turning onto the long boulevard that led to their subdivision, a soft, uphill curve that gave him a moment to ponder his answer.

"Them, obviously," he said.

"Not *you*."

He looked over at her. She was perched differently on the seat now, and something different was in her eyes: keen interest. A little glimmer of having caught the scent of something. Her arms were still folded across her chest, but not in exactly the same way. She was on the offensive now, not the defensive.

Jack had the distinct, chilly feeling he suspected most men got when their wives had carefully laid out a verbal trap of some kind, and he was about to put his foot right into it.

"Uh..." he said, and scratched his head. "Not... wait.... *what?*"

They were pulling into their driveway, and Nikki was still looking at him with her strange new look. "It's them, they're the ones getting ideas. Not you."

He hesitated. Just a second too long.

"Not me," Nikki added, and raised one eyebrow sexily. "*Them.*"

This was not a mistake you could make around Nikki, whose eighteen or so years as a paramedic, a lot of which had been spent at some of the worst stations in the city, had made her an almost foolproof lie detector.

"Not... uh, yeah. No. Wait." He laughed, hopeless. "I don't really know what we're arguing here."

Nikki arched her eyebrows.

He was all prepared for an all-out assault, because it wasn't Nikki's style to be passive-aggressive or averse to confrontation. If she thought something, she told you so, and then you were going to talk about it, because she said so. *She* wasn't going anywhere.

It was a largely tolerable situation that he had come to terms with. At least you always knew where you stood.

"Huh," Nikki said, tilting her chin a little and smiling a perfectly sublime, wicked smile. She found the door handle without taking her eyes off his.

"That's funny. Because it kind of seemed like *you* for a little bit."

Jack stared at her.

"Getting ideas."

"Uh..."

"But *you're* not?" Nikki pulled on the door handle, slowly, so it unlatched, but she didn't push it open. She let it slip from her fingers and clack back into place. Jack's heart was beating violently, and his body had gone cold in the limbs. He hadn't breathed for a while, and the pain was building slowly in his lungs.

"I..."

She was staring at him, and he back at her, and something simmered between them. Nikki's lips parted, her eyes seemed large and damp, and from the way she scooted her butt back a little and gave her chest a slight tilt, displaying her breasts just a smudge more prominently, it *seemed* like whatever Nikki was thinking about was as moist and sexual as what Jack was.

"I must have had it wrong," Nikki said, and pushed the car door open, hopping out and away before Jack could even process the sentence she'd uttered. "So I'll just stop teasing you about it."

He exhaled, and blinked, watching his wife as she scooted around the front of the car to get to the garage stairs.

He was imagining things.

But what if he wasn't?

What did that *mean*?

Nikki opened the door and looked back at him, smiling.

Mysteriously.

Which was not like Nikki at all.

He followed, after almost forgetting to turn the vehicle off. Nikki was already coming back from the living room, flushed with excitement. "No one is home..." she said, reaching for Jack with a beckoning hand.

He walked toward her uncertainly. The uncertainty didn't come from a logical place: it was obvious that Nikki was inviting him back to the bedroom. It was obvious that something about the car ride, or the afternoon at the bar, or the training session with all the guns and burly men - or all three - had made her horny.

This was his fucking fantasy.

Perhaps that was why: it disturbed him the way held-out meat disturbed dogs. Sure, he wanted it. But he was wary of what lay beneath her intentions, and he couldn't sort that part out.

However, he was a man. So he reached for her hand.

She pulled him toward her, putting his hands on her hips. He let her guide him, still semi-wary: it wasn't like Nikki to initiate this kind of thing, in the afternoon, after a disagreement, however jokey. She seemed hotter, like a hum was inside her that she needed to get out. Energy buzzed beneath her skin.

She stood up on tiptoes after placing his hands on her hips and pulled on his neck to kiss him. Her own hands were busy: she worked them under his shirt and pushed it up and over his head, taking steps backward to draw him toward the bedroom.

"Hmm," he ventured. "What has gotten into *you*?"

Nikki smiled, then delivered a smattering of kisses, down his neck, onto his shoulder, over his chest, while her fingers went to work on unbuttoning his pants. She pressed her body close to his chest and shoved her hand into his jeans, her eyes lighting up noticeably when her fingers closed around his stiff cock. "Into *me*, huh?" she joked. "I don't know..." she kissed him and bit into his lower lip. "Maybe you weren't *all wrong*..."

"No?" Jack breathed. His cock was so hard that it was starting to hurt, and he veered their stumbling, clumsy walk toward the living room, unable to wait. "So you really did get turned on handling all those guns?"

Nikki looked back at him, her face a mixture of unreadable emotions - except for the hunger that was present in her body and her eyes, flitting about as untamed energy that seemed to sparkle. "The guns... the gun owners... who can say who's at fault?"

This was an incredibly clever joke, and Jack would appreciate it later, remembering it. It flew over his head though, because he only read into exactly what he wanted to hear. He guided Nikki onto the armrest of the couch, grasped her shirt and yanked it over her head, then shoved her so that she fell backward. Nikki went willingly and sprawled sexily, her hands going to her pants to push them off her hips.

They were attacking each other like teenagers now. Jack pulled her shoes off, ripping at the laces and then tugging them roughly, letting them thunk to the floor haphazardly. He pulled on her pants and walked backward to yank them free, tossing them, and her underwear, somewhere behind him. The whole while he was kicking himself out of his own pants.

He crawled on top of Nikki while she pushed herself with her feet back to stretch out. Their eyes met and the kind of erotic heat that had long, long

ago disappeared from their marriage simmered between them, liquid and distorting. It wiped Jack's mind completely blank except for the desire to fuck: somewhere in the back of his mind, things he wanted to say, fantasies he wanted to play out, burned with enfeebling light.

He entered Nikki as soon as he got on top of her, after quickly slipping a finger into her hot slit. She was soaked with a thick, rich syrup of excitement. As he sank into her, a visceral thought filled his mind: she was as wet as if someone had already fucked her and blown up in her pussy.

The thought manifested itself, and from that moment forward he had to actively concentrate on baseball stats and financial products until he felt Nikki's orgasm winding up tightly in her thighs, which she squeezed against him just as her pussy clenched around him ferociously and she opened her mouth to let out a satisfied holler.

He let the burst of hot cum bathe his cock, enjoying her orgasm for as long as he could, and then the thought of her pussy being sloshy with another man's cum surfaced again in his mind, and he thrust deep, lying down on Nikki and grasping her hair for dear life as his intense climax shuddered away to the blissful, brief satisfaction of the few minutes after coming.

"Holy hell," he breathed, and Nikki nuzzled his neck, smiling. He pushed up on his forearms, kissing her, ready to start a conversation about what had gotten into her.

But the door lock made a scratching noise, and they froze for a second to listen to it. Determining that it was one of their kids coming home, they reacted at the same time: Nikki's eyes went wide, Jack hopped off of her, and they scrambled to collect their clothes from the floor and run toward the corridor to the master suite.

Nikki laughed and shrieked, running naked ahead of him. She sat down on the bed and got dressed faster than it seemed possible, jumped up, kissed him as he was sinking slowly onto the bed - still stunned, and popped out the door. "Hey there, Cole," she called out, looking back at Jack with wild, caught-in-the-act eyes as she closed the door behind her.

Still smiling.

CHAPTER 8

Mike rolled in late to work, like he always did, and plopped into his chair loudly, tossing some files on his desk. A big sigh, like he always did, and then he cracked his knuckles.

Mike drank a lot and had a huge hangover almost every day, and the only way for him to get through the day was to hammer his work as hard as possible. If he finished early he turned his chair around and faced the window with his eyes closed and one hand on the keyboard, in case anyone asked what he was doing.

No one ever did. Everyone knew that was how Mike operated, but because he got his shit done and looked alive when he needed to, and because his partner had gotten smashed into the ambulance by a car sliding on the ice and died from crush syndrome, everyone let him be.

Today, though, Mike didn't do any of this. He trained his eyes on Jack instead of his computer screen.

"I heard a rumor," he announced, when Jack ignored him.

Mike clicked his mouse, but he wasn't even looking at the screen.

Jack kept "working," tabbing through his spreadsheet, his heart suddenly racing.

"Is it true your wife went to tactical?"

Jack shifted his eyes to meet Mike's. They were alive with hunger. Mike liked anything to do with Nikki, or at least it seemed that way to Jack. He liked asking about her, talking about her, probably for exactly the reason Jack believed: she was hot - too hot, in Mike's opinion, for Jack.

He got that a lot.

"Yep."

Mike grinned, turned his eyes back to his screen, and whistled.

"That don't bother you?" he asked, when Jack continued to ignore him.

Jack shrugged. "Should it?"

This made Mike exhale a laugh through his nose. "O-kay," he sneered.

"Right."

"What's that supposed to mean, man?"

Mike actually leaned over to look at Jack like he had two heads. "Seriously, guy?"

Jack sighed. "When's the last time tactical actually went on a real call?"

"*Never*," Mike was already saying, before Jack had finished the question.

"But that's not the problem."

"No problem," Jack told him, eyes back on his screen, leaning in to squint at something to make himself seem especially nonchalant.

Mike leaned over his desk, which faced Jack's, spreading his elbows wide and peering at Jack. "No problem? Dude."

Jack looked over at him.

Mike threw his hands out wide, palms open. "She's training with *the tactical team*. Cops. Have you *seen* those guys?"

"As a matter of fact, I had a beer with them the other night," Jack said, matter-of-factly. He cringed a little. He sounded gay, or like a woman. He cleared his throat. "They're cops."

Mike laughed, and straightened up, opening his mouth to say something.

"Oh man, don't get started on this shit -" Jack began.

"They're *cops*," Mike was already saying. "But they're like, the alpha cops. And they're training to shoot at people -"

"Seriously, Mike, this shit is crazy -"

"-while protecting your *female*, dude. This is like -"

Jack shook his head vigorously and rolled his eyes. "Oh God here we go..."

" - a fucking recipe for getting *cucked*. Hard."

Jack sighed even more loudly and leaned back in his chair, placing his hands folded over his stomach, noting the slight pudge of his belly with some dismay, and glaring at Mike. There was no stopping the guy once he got started on this shit.

Mike, pleased to have Jack's attention (as always), dropped all pretext of working and leaned even more to talk to Jack. "She is like, out there with all these jacked-up giga-Chads, man. And they're like, forming a circle around her while the bad guys are coming." He opened his eyes wide and looked at Jack like there was a very obvious conclusion to draw about all of this.

Jack nodded amicably, his gut twisting in spite of his resolve not to let anything Mike had to say about this - because he had known that eventually Mike *would* - and deployed his usual tactic with Mike when he got revved up about his psychosexual hierarchy malarkey, which was to nod and agree.

"It's a doozy," he agreed.

Most of the time, Mike sounded like a raving lunatic who spent way too much time on Reddit or YouTube or something even worse, steeping himself in videos about alphas and betas and then getting wasted and watching porn while playing Call of Duty.

And yet...

He hated to admit it - and he never would, in a million years - but some of the crap Mike droned on about had a seductive sheen of truth to it. In particular, what he was saying right now... well, it wasn't so far away from a real fear that lurked in Jack's mind.

Or maybe somewhere else, somewhere more primal, closer to his testes.

That's where he felt it.

But Mike was not in the agreeing mood. He seized on this like raw meat.

"A doozy? Dude. Think about it for a minute."

Jack really wanted to tell Mike that he *had*, and for more than a minute. For hours, in the dark, cold night, his wife sleeping next to him and his cock painfully hard.

"No woman is immune to that shit. Okay? Women are hard-wired to want some fucking muscle, want some protection -"

"If you start sounding like Andrew Tate or whoever it is -"

"- this is not Andrew Tate, bro - dude, I am not a fucking Gen Z loser - it's just the way it is, it's in their fucking heads, it's hardwired, don't be an idiot, man. These guys are all jacked and they have big guns and they're like, literally down there training, over and over again, rehearsing the *one thing* that all women want, they're all: 'Here, little cute paramedic, we'll keep you safe in this super-dangerous situation that you should be really, really scared

of... good job, let's practice it again..." Mike trailed off and looked back at his computer, a smug, self-satisfied grin on his face. "Don't believe me, just check her panties when she comes home, bro."

Jack made a big show of shaking his head and looking really interested in his computer screen.

"And dude," Mike continued, after a well-timed pause. "Why do you think these fucking guys *do* this shit? Huh?"

Jack rolled his eyes.

"Yeah, you roll your eyes, but you know as well as I do that none of these fuckers are running around thinking about civics or law and order when they gear up."

Jack continued pretending to work.

"Thinking about pussy," Mike continued, clicking his mouse loudly to emphasize "pussy."

"Okay," Jack agreed.

"Your *wife's* pussy, in this case."

Jack glared at Mike, who smiled without looking away from his screen.

And then they worked for a little bit.

"Like, dude," Mike said, after about ten minutes. He rolled to the side and spread his elbows out again, feigning exasperation. "Would you let your wife go, like, volunteer to be the hot chick the fire guys are hauling out of a building, over and over again? They go and throw her around, toss her on the ground and rip her clothes off to see if she's, you know... okay?"

"They use dummies for that," Jack said, evenly. "And anyway, fire just throws people on the ground and takes off without doing fuck-all. That's literally like, half my fucking job here, Mike. Telling fire not to do that exact thing."

But the thought - Mike's greasy thought - started worming into his mind.

Mike held up a finger and wagged it theatrically. "Maybe they use dummies for exactly that reason, you ever think of that? *Fire* likes to have a clean rep about the wife-fucking. But *cops*..." Mike grinned evilly. "They don't give a *fuck*."

Jack was annoyed. "Man, look. This is not the same thing at all, for one."

Mike's eyebrows shot to the ceiling. "It's not?" he said, in a stupid voice. He howled and spun back to his computer. "I thought it was a pretty apt comparison, actually."

"Nikki is not a dummy."

Mike grinned. "My point exactly."

Infuriating.

"She's not getting rescued. She's doing her job," Jack continued.

"Uh-huh," Mike said, clicking obnoxiously. "Under fire. Bullets flying. Fear making her blood rush everywhere, jacked-up dudes there to keep her safe. *Everybody* is just doing their *job*. Sure." He leaned in to squint at something on his computer, growled, let out a string of cusswords, and seemed to get caught up in whatever it was.

But five minutes later, he had evidently sorted it, and he smiled to himself.

Click, click.

"I guess if you don't mind -"

"Do not say beta cuck."

" - getting cucked. Man! I told you. You got this beta shit *all wrong*. You're not a beta. You're not even gonna get *beta* cucked, fool. Jesus. You are a fucking delta. All the way."

There he went. Jack glared at his own screen. "Mike, why don't you get a fucking *life*, man?"

Mike laughed at this and started typing, shaking his head. "I am here for you if you need me, bro," he said. And then he laughed again.

*

Mike had never exactly been a normal guy, and it was anybody's guess how he ended up being a paramedic. Rumors abounded: he had grown up in the UK and couldn't get into med school here without repeating a bunch of shit; he had gotten kicked out; he had tried for fire and been rejected; he had been in the army and was a medic. No one really knew if any of this was true, because Mike was a weird guy before the accident, and he was a total weirdo now that he had a desk job.

His wife had left him, which was the usual entry point for guys his age into what all the other guys referred to derisively as astrology for men.

But, like most of the guys who said this about Mike's "passions," Jack found himself thinking about the crap Mike said long after he said it, long after everyone made fun of it and told Mike to shut up.

Everyone rolled their eyes, Jack thought, but he would have placed big money on everyone having left a trail of cookies to Google searches for

"sociosexual hierarchy" and then hundreds of insane websites and blogs and videos about exactly that.

In Mike's world - and Jack refused to think of it as the real world, because *bonkers* - Jack was a delta. Keep your head down and do your work. The description of this type of man not only fit Jack to a "t," it also appealed to him, the way a favorable description of his personality did on a Chinese restaurant menu.

In other words, it was stupid bullshit. Bromides to captivate the frustrated and obsessed.

The thing was, in his heart of hearts, Jack felt like there was a little more to it than that. He didn't think every single thing that everyone did was tied up with that crap, but he'd been a post-pubescent male for thirty years now, and nothing in his experience really contradicted this shit Mike talked about.

Some dudes were just fucking scary fuckers.

Some dudes were losers who couldn't make friends or get women.

Some dudes were betas - sneaky, smart little worms who attached to big, scary dudes and told them how to steal money or went to court for them.

And most guys were deltas: doing their job, raising their kids, and going about their business.

Where it got shitty in Mike's telling of things was when he pointed out that Jack had scored himself a higher-value female than he deserved.

Which was just sociosexual hierarchy-sprachen for "out of his league."

"You're an idiot," he had told Mike with confidence, the first time he had spilled all this garbage at the bar. "And you will never get girls if you call them 'females'."

"I don't say it to their *face*," Mike had countered, drunk off his gourd.

And yet, it stuck in Jack's craw. It crept up on him in the dark moments. Thoughts about this very thing: his high-value Nikki.

And who could argue with the ideas that Mike had planted in the dark, fertile soil of Jack's mind, that now grew like vines, creeping into every thought and action, every memory and dream?

Women *did* have some kind of evolutionary radar for a stronger, taller, faster, bigger, male. And what good would that be, if not for protection? If protection wasn't, as Mike put it, "the moist seed of their most primitive desires? "

The tactical team training was, then, if not the distorted and fevered COD-fueled nightmare that Mike had described, at the very least, a conjunction of both the symbols of a protective male and the actions of one, repeated over and over for good measure.

A re-enactment of every woman's deepest desires.

Desires they maybe only felt on a primal level.

So, sure:

Mike was an immature idiot, a bit brainwashed by his internet choices and his wife leaving him.

There was no reason to take anything he said seriously, or even think about it at all.

But of course, Jack *did*.

CHAPTER 9

There hadn't been much discussion about any of it again after that, and weeks went by. The seasons changed. Training were rescheduled because of outbreaks and shift chaos among the paramedics, and the sheen of the whole crazy thing began to wear off.

Jack had gone in circles, first hoping that things would pick up again where they had left off, then grateful that they might not. He had probably flown too close to the sun. He had been willing to risk something precious - his marriage to a woman he loved and who was definitely above his pay grade - for a cheap thrill that, if he put enough distance and sobriety between himself and events that fueled his fantasy, was really pretty perverse.

He had, in fact, just gotten around to shoving the whole idea back under a rug in a dusty corner of his mind, and get back to the serious business of counting himself lucky for what he had, keeping his head down and paying the bills. They were busy, and Nikki's shifts were always being dragged out by delays at the ER, and so there was no room in the day for thoughts about any of this, and nights were just an exercise in trying to get more than four hours of sleep.

As they had done for a good part of their marriage, they began sleeping in separate beds most nights - Nikki, with her insane hours, migrated to the guest bedroom. They mostly communicated through text messages, and most of this was about whose job it was to pick up what child or what groceries, where to drop something off or pick someone up, an unexpected shift change, a rescheduled meeting.

Jack - and probably Nikki, too, to be fair - fell into the mind-dumbing drudgery of every day life, of just trying to get everything done every day, of being impossibly behind and out of breath and never feeling fully on top of anything.

So it was easy to understand how, in all of that flurry, he might have missed a message from Nikki, or a conversation, in which she told him that she had training on a Saturday. He knew, somehow, that she had something that day - or maybe he had just come to accept that his wife wouldn't be home most of the time, and definitely never *on* time. The pandemic might have been over for everyone outside of health care, but in its messy, bloody bosom, the whole system was still in disarray. They'd gotten used to it over the past two years, slogging through it, not bothering to even comment on it anymore.

The kids had gone off to their various adolescent activities on a Saturday afternoon, and Jack was using the free time to catch up on the paperwork that plagued him day and night in his new position. He was exhausted - not so much physically, or even mentally, but more spiritually than anything else: holding all of this shit together was monotonous. Nikki had the more difficult job, if you talked about their jobs to a total stranger: it was Nikki getting hit with shifts that went four hours longer, Nikki who had to hustle, Nikki who was out on the streets getting spit at and called a bitch, Nikki who everyone screamed at when they were parked in the ER hallways for three hours with symptoms that in other times would have gotten them admitted within five minutes.

But cleaning up after the disasters that all of these long shifts and hard hours inevitably brought upon their family fell to Jack - and maybe it sounded easier, if you were telling this story at the bar to some friends - but

it was actually excruciating. It was boring, it got no respect, and the monotony of it was making him a little crazy. But Nikki had done this exact thing for a decade, so he didn't have any ammunition to complain. Fair was fair.

He didn't even really react when he heard the puff of air that chased the opening of the door to the garage. This was followed by the clanging of dishes, so his mind categorized the intruder as one of his kids, grazing through all of the food in the entire house, which was another thing that he couldn't find a way to stay on top of.

The smack of lips behind him made him jump.

Nikki was standing in the doorway, a plate of leftover food from KFC in her hand, her thumb between her lips as she sucked grease from it. "Whatcha doin'?" she asked.

"Oh," he said, surprised, glancing quickly at his computer to make sure he hadn't left any scandalizing porn site open in a random window. It wasn't like Nikki cared; she was really cool about that kind of thing. (He supposed this was the kind of attitude that made him suspect that Nikki knew exactly what hand of cards she was actually holding. Only a woman who felt confident enough about her own assets and her husband's devotion could shrug porn off like Nikki did). "Hey."

There was something off about Nikki. A jittery energy bubbled inside her. Her eyes were bright and her pupils dilated - if he'd been on a call he would have suspected light drug use. She was eating the KFC like she hadn't had a meal in ten days, and looking at him in a strange way as she sucked the grease off her fingers - which was something she never did.

"Kids around?" she asked.

What *was* it? What was it about her that was making him... almost nervous? The way she asked this question, the way she came in and scooped her butt onto a narrow table where they piled all kinds of things, mostly handbooks, and then forgot about them. She pushed them out of the way and set her chicken plate - the chicken now gone - on a teetering column of textbooks and papers that looked like it had been designed to fall over.

He reached for it, and Nikki ignored this, which was not something she normally did with good cheer. Nikki was also inviting disasters at home, and when he averted them by calmly doing something like picking up a plate off a teetering pile of books, she always rolled her eyes and mumbled something about it.

Not today. Her eyes followed him as he moved the plate, but the action itself did not seem to make it into her thoughts.

Nikki had something on her mind, some plan, some reason for coming in there.

"Kids are... out with friends, the mall or something for Cole, and Rye is, I think, out with a girl."

Nikki's eyes went up for this last part, but like the moved plate, the actual information did not seem to enter any part of her brain where she was actually thinking about it. "Good for him," she said.

Not what Nikki would ordinarily have said, if she had really heard that Rye was out with a girl.

Something else was obviously working away in her thoughts, at the forefront, blocking all of these things from getting into her thinking brain. A patch of pink splotched her right cheek - this was the remnants of the flush that plagued her. It appeared on her right cheek first, then the left, and it

went out like it came in, leaving a bright pink stain on the right side of her face, closer to her jaw than her cheekbone, that persisted long after the thrill that had caused it.

A stab of dread, mingled with fear, plunged through Jack's core. This had the look and feel of Nikki having something she needed to talk to him about, and those things were never great. He braced himself, and folded his hands together.

Nikki slid off the table. She was wearing black tactical pants and a tight gray t-shirt that he had only just bothered to look at carefully - a small crest with tiny letters surrounding a Star of Life gave him a little pang of relief - paramedic something.

"Aren't you going to ask me how it was?" Nikki said, approaching him. She stepped toward him playfully, hitting his knee with hers, making his chair rotate, and then, as he stared at her in astonishment, sitting down on his left thigh and leaning back while putting her arms around his neck so that she could kick her feet up.

He sniffed for alcohol, but couldn't smell any.

Nikki was looking at him, expectantly. She had distracted him so much with this weird behavior that he had forgotten she had asked him a question.

"Huh, what?" he said, blinking.

His eyes were all over the place. The tactical pants - black - had set off an alarm that blinked haphazardly somewhere in the back of his mind. She smelled strange, and he couldn't place it - some kind of recycled air seemed to have clung to her. Her breasts were pressed against the shirt through a thin bra - unlike Nikki, again. She always wore sports bras that left no chance of the contours of her fat, chewy nipples showing through. The

shape of her breasts was scandalously apparent as she leaned back and kicked her feet, unrestrained by the compression of a sports bra, he (or anyone looking) could see the plump, conical shape of them, the place where her aureole began, the contours of her nipples.

Nikki didn't answer; like everything he had said to her so far, the question skipped over the surface of her mind like a rock on the water, and then plunged suddenly into the depths of her mind, where it sank like a stone and left no trace. She had her own agenda, that much was clear.

Less clear was what the hell it was.

She pulled herself to sitting, then stood up, only to push one leg onto his right thigh, and the other onto his left, worming her calves down and out the back of the chair so that she was straddling him.

His erection had been revving up since she arrived, but this made it jump into fierce and full action. He knew that Nikki could feel it against her inner thigh, bouncing, and this seemed to be the only external information that could pierce her thoughts.

She smiled, deliciously, and cocked an eyebrow.

"*I've* been at the shooting range," she said. Her forearms were resting on his shoulders now, and she was leaning back, wriggling seductively, a thing she *had* done in the past. But so far back in the past that it was a distant memory, and groggy. She had always been drunk when she did this before.

"Are you high or something?" he asked her.

"Something," she said, biting into her lower lip.

And then she leaned forward and reached her whole right arm between their legs to run her fingernails over the stretched fabric of his sweats, grazing

his cock as she did. "It turns out," she said, in a half-whisper, "that I am very, very good at firing guns."

Jack marveled for a moment at the extraordinary predicament he found himself in. His cock was hard and robbing his brain of plenty of blood, but he was a middle-aged man with seventeen years of marriage under his belt, almost three of them during a pandemic, and so he knew how to keep a few of wits about him by then.

Sure, his wife had plopped herself in his lap and purred like a sexual kitten, and was now mewling and wriggling, running his fingers all over his cock - and this was, summarily, all he had believed he wanted out of life at certain points.

But it was also terrifying. And when the details - the smell of gunpowder, which he recognized now, the shirt, which said something-something "tactical" on it, the black pants, the sultry vixen who inhabited his wife's body, the lingering, ever-present thought of Tony and his band of muscled cops, Nikki's bright eyes that indicated extreme arousal... everything combined to make him seasick more than anything.

Nikki was looking at him. She was walking her fingers up his chest, protruding her lower lip a little (surely, *surely* this was deliberate?), and squirming in his lap in a way that, as far as he could see, had only one purpose.

"Oh you are, are you?"

What else was he supposed to say? Sure, it was all *fucked* on a number of levels, but Nikki was hot, and the flush had returned to her cheeks, and now that she had been sitting there on his lap with her legs spread for a bit, he could smell the faintly sweaty, slightly dirty sweet scent of her pussy, which

must have seeped thickly into her underwear to make it through the almost impenetrable fabric of the tactical pants - their color again biting him, out of nowhere, like a mean snake: black.

At some point, they'd had marital rough patches like anyone else, and it had mostly revolved around sex, like everyone else's. They had gone to a therapist about it - an EMS services counselor who had heard the same problem about a million times before and had suggested that Nikki try to consciously initiate sex more often.

It had all come across as very weird back then, because Jack had reacted pretty much the same way he was acting now - distrustful, even though he was getting exactly what he had said he wanted.

But back then, Nikki had gotten pissed off as all hell by his attitude, and the whole sordid thing had ended in more fighting than it ever could have possibly staved off. Nikki had accused him of wanting things he couldn't have, of blowing her off, of having trust issues, the whole nine yards.

Now, though, she just didn't seem to care.

Was that it? Or did she just not notice?

The thing was, Nikki's overtones had seemed forced back then.

Now they were raw and visceral, and as real as they could get. She kicked a foot playfully again, gave him her glassy eyes, and nodded slowly and sensually. "I'm a real hot shot," she said.

Jack put his hands on Nikki's back, just beneath her ribcage, and had a stern talk with himself inside his own head. *Do not speak*, he told himself.

Because whether or not Nikki was acting weird as fuck, it was hot as hell, and he was pretty sure they hadn't had sex in almost two weeks. If he said

what it was occurring to him to say right now, he could blow it for himself. And he did *not* want that.

So guns made Nikki horny.

This was a problem for him, why?

He very much had a desire to stand up and carry Nikki with him into the bedroom, but he didn't trust his ability to lift her from a seated position like that. He wasn't a fucking firefighter. Or a tactical cop. The deficiency, however, made him more turned on than anything else.

He shoved his hands beneath her shirt and under the thin bra - its feel unfamiliar to him - and squeezed her breasts. Nikki reacted to the raw energy of it by coming harder at him, dipping her hand into his sweats, squeezing his cock. They started kissing - noisy, wet, sloppy kisses that had the same frantic feel as the time they had fucked on the couch.

Nikki was the one who got off the chair and pulled him with her to the bedroom. When they got in there, Nikki pulled her shirt and bra off in one swift, agile motion, ripping something in the process. She didn't pay any attention; instead, she went for his joggers and tugged them down, moving closer to him, grasping at his cock. She turned him until he had his back against the bed and then pushed him onto it.

From there, almost like a reversal of their earlier tryst - also fueled by guns and cops - she pulled his sweatpants off by grabbing the cuffs and walking backward, tossing them off to the side. Jack stared, momentarily unable to move, watching Nikki take her pants off and squirm out of them, then slide her underwear down slowly, looking at him.

He sat up to take his shirt off. Nikki's underwear were off by the time he could see again, and she jumped onto the bed - almost maniacally - and

straddled him. She walked her knees up to either side of his hips, reaching down between her legs to put her hand forcefully around his shaft.

Still raised up on her knees, Nikki lowered her body a little - showing impressive thigh strength, like it was no big deal - and moved the tip of his dick into the flesh of her pussy. Warm, sweet juices rolled from her lips down to his shaft, coating the crown, tickling in tiny, branching rivers. Jack moved his hands to her thighs, felt the faint tremble of her muscles as they poised halfway into a crouch.

"I really, really liked it," Nikki said, moving his cock over her clit and smiling as she pleased herself. Jack stared at his dick and the dripping petals of her pussy gulping at it as she rubbed it against herself. He felt a little tremble in her thighs, and gripped her hips, wondering if Nikki's intention was to make herself come and then leave him wanting. The idea made his cock twitch, which made Nikki smile, but then she abruptly seemed to lose control and plopped herself onto him.

Jack stared up at his wife as she rode him, tits bouncing gloriously. She put her hands on his chest and dug her nails in, but shortly after that, raised herself up tall and tipped her head back, bouncing on his cock and rolling her hips to drive it deeper inside of her. She closed her eyes and seemed to become completely absorbed in what she was doing for herself, the fantasy she was playing in her own head.

Jack watched, stunned, as his wife rode him like an actual banshee, and then came, driving her body hard onto his and howling, her hands up in her hair, her pussy suddenly so wet that juices poured down his balls.

He gripped Nikki's hips and rolled her body against his, and with no more than a few moments of fantasizing that Nikki was thinking about Tony

under her, inside of her - he was seized by an orgasm that seemed less mechanical than purely psychological, and his own cum joined hers in rolling wetly down his balls.

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"Well," Jack said, stroking Nikki's back. It was almost half an hour later, and they hadn't said anything to each other, just lay there, caressing each other. "*That* was definitely... something." He craned his neck to look down at Nikki, whose eyelashes were immobile, her eyes vacantly staring in front of her, her mind clearly on other things. "What got into *you*?"

Nikki didn't move for a while, or even seem to hear him. When she spoke, it almost startled him - his own eyelids had started to get heavy and he felt an urge to doze.

"How serious were you about what you said?" Nikki asked, suddenly sitting up, turning around, folding her feet underneath her, and propping herself up on his chest to look into his eyes. "Seriously?"

He was wide awake just as suddenly. "Huh? What?"

But he knew what: his heart was racing ahead of him moving, and Nikki had moved her fingers down to the crook of his elbow, where she was surreptitiously feeling for his pulse.

"About... you know. Like, being turned on by, uh..." her eyes dropped to her fingers, which already had the answer to her question. Maybe she couldn't read "seriousness," but she could feel that his heart was racing. Her eyes flew to his, and her face grew even more serious. "You know what I'm talking about," she said quietly.

He pushed himself up on his elbows, head spinning. Nikki sat back on her heels, her fingers going to her twisted bra straps and straightening everything out. Her hair was pleasantly mussed.

Jack tried to think of what to say and found himself tongue-tied instead. "I... you... well, I thought... why... are you asking?"

Nikki bit into her lower lip and shifted onto her hip, looking up at the ceiling. "I, uh... okay. I'll tell you but you have to promise not to freak out or anything, okay? Because I'm not, like, actually, you know -" she cut herself off and seemed ready to take everything back, but then had a surge of her peculiar, sudden, truth-telling energy, and rapid fired the following at Jack:

"I just - Tony, uh... like don't take this the wrong way at all, okay? But he was - I mean, you know he was - you saw it at the bar - getting kind of friendly with me, the uh, other day at the gym, and I was sort of, I guess, reciprocating a little bit -" her eyes got wide and she looked down at Jack to squeeze his arm - "like not *seriously*, but just, in a fun way. Because of our other conversation, that night you met those guys. And so... I guess, just for fun, you know, I was like, flirting back with him, and we were making all these jokes, and then... he sort of, uh, you know, actually - it felt like he *actually* put the moves on me." Nikki lowered her eyes, and started moving her hand over his forearm. Very quietly, she added: "And I, uh... didn't exactly shut him down."

Jack's mouth fell open, and his erection returned in almost full force, violently. "Put the moves on you?" he repeated.

But what did that mean to Nikki, exactly?

Voice cracking slightly with his burgeoning excitement, Jack touched her fingertips and stroked them, looking at her fingers to deflect his exuberance, in case it frightened Nikki away from saying what he really wanted her to. "Tony's always putting the moves on you," he breathed. "What did he do differently?"

Nikki was staring at him when he looked up at her, after she didn't respond for a moment. Her pupils were dilated and she glanced down - toward his cock - before she looked up, and, seemingly encouraged, leaned over his chest to talk to him, her lips closer, the scent of her humid skin filling his nostrils. "So we have to go to this, uh... thing. Like, training session, and, uh... for us, we can, um... come home every night, or we have the option to, um... stay at a hotel. And so Tony came up to me at the gym, and I was doing the shoulder pull thingy, and he like, came up behind me and corrected my form -"

"How?" Jack's voice was flat, robotic, but his eyes were alive with greedy hunger.

Nikki blinked, thrown off her rhythm for telling the story.

"How did he correct your form?"

Nikki blinked again, and then a quiver of a smile shook in her upper lip. She looked down at Jack's chest, her fingers moving over his skin.

Abruptly, she retracted her hand. "Turn over," she said, in her most assertive paramedic voice.

Jack was more than happy to comply, shifting to accommodate his growing erection, one eye warily on Nikki's hands.

Nikki moved his arms out so that they were basically in the position of the shoulder pull, and then she hopped on top of him. "So he wasn't, you know, sitting on me...but he walked up and went like this..."

Nikki placed a hand on Jack's right shoulder, and then traced her fingers sensually from there, over his shoulder blade, down the contours of back muscles he'd long forgotten the names of. "He was like, 'make sure you're keeping this aligned with...something..." she lowered her voice to imitate Tony, and leaned close to Jack's neck, her moist, hot breath grazing his skin as she spoke. She put both hands on his ribcage and moved them down to his hips, scooting herself back so that she could imitate the way Tony had - allegedly - adjusted her hips and dragged his finger close to the crack of her ass. "Square your hips..." she was saying.

Her hands were definitely in the "definite moves" category, moving into territory that, if she had wanted to press charges, would probably be considered sexual assault. She went back up his ribcage and then to his neck. "And then he was like:" she dropped her voice even deeper, moved her mouth close to his neck again, and imitated Tony. "You're signin' up for a hotel room for this thing, aren't you?"

Jack exhaled, and let the wave of arousal that engulfed him subside a little before reaching behind himself to push Nikki off his ass and roll over on his stomach. Nikki was looking at him sheepishly.

"Am I reading too much into -?"

Jack snorted. "Uh... no."

Nikki looked off to the side. Jack wondered, for the thousandth time, if she was *seriously* unsure whether or not men were "flirting" with her in situations like this.

"And you said...?" he prompted, when Nikki didn't continue.

Nikki's eyes dropped to the bed. "Uh... well, I said..." she pressed her lips together. "That's just it, I didn't really say... yes... but I didn't exactly say *no*. At first. And then I was like, I don't know. I panicked. And then I went, "oh, jeez, no, no hotel, I have to go home!"

Nikki did a very good impression of herself there, raising her voice to silly, cheerful pitch and chirping it out like a bird.

But there had to be more to the story.

Jack smiled, taking Nikki's hand and bringing it to his lips. "So you... left the door open?" he asked, treading very, very carefully.

Nikki blew air out of her lips at her bangs, which were heavy with sweat and barely moved. "I don't really... know *what* I did. Okay, this isn't actually the point." Nikki re-settled herself on her feet and pressed onto her hands to do it, getting her face close to his chest for a moment. "The point is... uh... so Tony goes, after I said..." she fluttered her hand in the air rapidly to dismiss "whatever" she had said. "Then *he* said, uh..." Patches of bright pink were splotchily appearing beneath her cheekbones.

"He said... okay, I'm going to tell you, but you have to understand, this was like, super casual, the way he said it. He said..." Nikki expelled air loudly and shook her hands. "He said not to worry about *you*, because you were *into it*. Like, he said he could tell your *type*. And he said, I should go home and just ask you about it. And see... what you said." She lifted her eyes again. "And so of course, I was like, "you're crazy," and I sort of giggled my way out of there..." Nikki looked at him helplessly. This was so easily envisioned it was ludicrous. "But then I was thinking that, you know... I'd ask you, I guess. Just because it's sort of... come up. In a roundabout way."

Nikki looked for all the world like she really didn't have any idea whether Tony was right or wrong. Even after all of this.

Jack shifted onto one arm and took Nikki's hand in his, slowly moving it down his torso to his cock. Nikki didn't take her eyes away from his, but squeezed him when her fingers found him, turgid and pulsing, ready for another round.

"What do *you* want?" he asked her.

This sent Nikki's eyes scurrying to her own thighs again, a little bashfully. Color rose in her cheeks. "I... don't... know?" she said, pouncing on the last word with glee. She looked up at him and shrugged.

Jack moved her hand on his cock. "Okay, so... this is where I stand, Nikki," he said. "So now it's just... what about you? What do *you* want?"

"I want to know what *you* want," Nikki complained.

Jack sat up all the way and pulled Nikki's thigh over his lap, lifting her body with a strength and an urgency that had long ago run out of steam in their marriage. His cock was so hard, and Nikki's pussy slippery with his cum and her own excitement, so it was an easy matter to slide her onto his shaft and let her weight settle over him. He drove his cock deep inside her, pushed her hair from her face, and kissed her hard. "I want to see you with another man," he said. He growled it, more than anything, gripping Nikki's hips and driving himself deep inside her.

The honesty, the nakedness of his admission, was surprising to Nikki, but even more so to himself. He dropped his hand to balance himself and started rocking his hips, grinding Nikki's sopping flesh against his body.

"But I only want that..." he trailed his fingers over her ribcage, making her whole body shudder once, the aftershocks gripping his cock in velvety

waves that by themselves were enough to drive him almost to orgasm. "If that's what you want. Okay?"

Nikki's lips parted, and she exhaled. She stared down at him, saying nothing, and her damp hair swung back and forth, slapping her shoulder with a barely audible, wet smack, with each of his thrusts.

They fucked again like this, neither of them saying anything. Jack was absorbed the entire time in the vacancy of Nikki's expression. Behind her eyes, it seemed still and almost dissociative, but her body was hot and insistent, and she ground her hips against him and made them both come within minutes.

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Nikki was on her back, one hand outstretched to the ceiling. She opened one eye and closed the other while she put her fingers together with different amounts of space between them, which was the kind of thing Nikki did while she was thinking deeply.

Jack rolled onto his side. "Okay," he said. "Spill it."

Nikki retracted her hands quickly and folded her arms up to her chest to roll toward him. "I'm just... you know. Thinking." She smiled, then dropped her eyelids. She pushed her hands toward his chest and stroked him with her pinky finger.

He caught her hand and kissed the tips of her fingers.

"This is crazy," she said. She lifted her eyes. He felt his cock filling rapidly again, lengthening in shuddering starts and stops. "This is what crazy people do and then they end up getting divorced like two years later."

"I don't think that's true."

Nikki opened her mouth to argue, but then snapped it shut. She smiled.

"Yeah, I guess I don't... actually know about that."

"Lots of people have this kind of relationship and it's just the way it is, and it all works out," Jack suggested, still treading lightly.

"It just seems like it would be... *bad*. You know? Cause a fight."

Jack kissed her hand. He was largely convinced he was dreaming, anyway, so he decided to plunge right in.

"Look. It's only going to cause a fight if it's something we didn't agree to do. Right?"

Nikki looked at him, a cross between confusion and disbelief on her face.

"Uh... I guess so."

"So it's -"

"Unless something goes wrong," Nikki countered.

"Like what?"

Nikki thought about it for a moment, staring at his chest as she ran her fingers through his wiry, sparse chest hair. "Like maybe you're saying you're not going to be mad about it, but then you are, once I do it. Like that. Or vice versa."

...once I do it...once I do it... once I do it...

Nikki was looking at him. "Right?"

He scrambled to bring himself back into the room, rolling on top of Nikki, perplexed (and impressed) that he seemed to be ready to go again.

"I promise," he said, very solemnly, kissing Nikki on the lips. "I won't get upset if you sleep with Tony. Or vice versa. Whatever that is. I guess you don't get to get upset if *I* sleep with Tony?"

Nikki giggled and slapped him on the arm. "I'm serious."

He kissed her, his hands moving into position to attempt another round. "So am I." He slipped his hand between their bodies, sliding through sweat and hot flesh, Nikki's squirming body, to find her juicy slit. "I promise," he breathed into her ear, and smiled with satisfaction as goosebumps rippled along her shoulder and arm. "I won't get mad if you fuck Tony. Not if you tell me every detail..."

And why not, he remembered thinking. YOLO.

"... not if you let me watch someday."

Nikki's only reaction to *that* was to mewl, and squirm to get the crown of his cock to slip into the folds of her pussy.

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Nikki finished typing and stare over the top of the computer screen at Jack. "Okay," she said. "I'm requesting the room."

She held her finger over the Enter key and looked at Jack.

"You don't have to *do* anything," Jack reminded her. "It's just to see what happens. Remember?"

Nikki gave him a look like he was trying to feed her a line. "I mean... he's sending some pretty clear signals."

"Mmm-hmm."

"So it would probably be a lot more responsible *not* to get a room," Nikki said.

Jack looked at her finger. They had already talked in circles about it.

He reached for her hand and pushed down, forcing her to press the button. "You can always just book it and come home," he said, when she gasped and looked at him, panic-stricken.

Nikki shook her head and looked at the screen. For a million dollars, Jack couldn't have been certain what she was going to do next.

"And waste taxpayer money like that?" she said, deadpanning again. She pressed her lips together in a scowl. "*Never.*"

And then she smiled, and looked up at Jack, who would have instigated another round of sex right then and there, if he felt capable of such a thing after the marathon they'd just had.

"I just want you to be happy," he told her. "So just play it by ear, okay?"

"Maybe nothing happens," Nikki said, repeating something he'd told her over and over, nudging her towards securing the room.

Just in case.

No commitment to anything in particular.

"Exactly."

And maybe something does, he thought.

CHAPTER 10

The first day of her training workshop, Nikki sent him a few text messages throughout, but they were the kind of benign texts that she would have sent anyway.

Sort of.

Got my ass kicked in the obstacle course.

A picture of herself, t-shirt and pants dark with full-body sweat, bulletproof vest on, tactical helmet covering her face in shadows, mud caked on one cheek. Her smile radiant.

Someone else had taken the picture.

Nikki loved excitement. The pink flush was present on her cheek, and he stared at it, wondering if Tony also found it as alluring as he did. Something about it seemed very youthful. Almost dangerously, illegally so.

LOL I don't know if I can do anything tonight but sleep.

Someone else had taken both pictures.

Jack didn't know why that particular detail stuck in his mind. It recirculated, sharp and painful whenever it bobbed to the surface of his consciousness.

Who had taken the pictures? Had Nikki asked someone to take it, or had one of those strapped-up GI-Joes walked past Nikki, sweating in her skimpy t-shirt and jeans, the sweet-pungent flavor of her sweat luring him to her.

"Hey girl," Jack imagined this faceless RoboCop saying. "I'll take that selfie for you."

The truth, he knew, was probably something much more banal. In all likelihood, the pictures had to be taken by someone with authority to take

the pictures. It was always like that in training.

They were typical texts from his atypical wife, and nothing that any normal man would stare at for hours on end, balls inky blue with pain. The kids were gone, he was alone in the house with his thoughts and his phone, and his wife was rolling around with Tony - and his crew - with guns and danger and testosterone pouring through every pore.

She finally called at 7 pm, ending a mind game of epic proportions that he had been playing with himself, holding his fingers back from typing a text that would reveal him to be as desperate and pathetic as he felt.

He had to remind himself several times that *he* had suggested this game plan.

He had given Nikki permission to feel things out, to flirt with Tony, to play dangerous games and see where she wanted to go with it. He had told her that this was what he wanted. And he did.

So he couldn't act like a little bitch about it.

He waited three rings before answering, which made him feel as childish as when he had been dating. Then, as in now, he hated himself for having his phone in his hand, for the way it leaped to life when her name appeared on the screen and the phone vibrated in his open palm, hated that he had to tell himself not to answer right away.

But there was a familiar and delicious sense of familiarity and excitement about doing just that. Playing games. Not knowing the outcome of events.

Not 100% trusting Nikki, either to fulfill his fantasies or to not.

Not 100% trusting himself to be satisfied with whatever her choice was.

It was a video call. She had a towel on her head, and she appeared quite sleepy, but content. For a moment he had a terrible thought: maybe she had already fallen for Tony, had sex with him, and his dark face would float into the screen any moment. Grinning.

Jack's insides lurched, cool and liquefied, as an errant thought ricocheted through his mind: what did the grin of man who just fucked your wife look like?

"I am soooo tired," Nikki said, breathlessly, without a greeting. She rested her head on her hand and the towel teetered, then crumpled, off to the side, and her wet hair spilled out in shiny, darkened blond waves. Over the phone, wet, in the light of her hotel room, her hair looked reddish.

Jack forced himself to ask her about her day. Her day of tactical training. Because that was what Nikki wanted to talk about.

"That sounds as bad as the military," he said, when she was done listing their activities for the day.

"Does it?" Nikki asked, dreamily. She yawned. "I was thinking maybe I was being a wimp about it." She smiled.

He smiled back.

"So... does this mean you're just going to bed?" he asked.

A tremor of excitement warbled in his question, and he hoped she didn't hear it. Nikki had her own agenda at this training, one that was professional and serious, and he didn't want to be the kind of dick husband who walked all over her dreams with his own desires.

But that was really all he wanted to hear about.

His heart felt squeezed, cold, raw. He waited while Nikki thought about it, looking up at the ceiling for inspiration.

Did she know what she was doing? This was always his question. Did she know that she tortured him in the most perverse ways when she did stuff like this, which was either exquisite, purposeful teasing, or just Nikki being Nikki, unaware of the thoughts that plagued her husband and all men she came into contact with. When he told her in detail what men were thinking, did she laugh at him from inside the vaulted places of her mind, wondering how he could be such a fool? Or did she really think he was exaggerating?

He would spend the rest of his life trying to develop a sure test to find out.

"Probably tonight," she said at last, her head tipped to one side.

It wasn't 100% sure, her voice was saying. She smiled playfully.

"Hmm," Jack said. "Is that... Tony's orders?"

Nikki lifted her head from her hand. Jack thought he saw a glimmer in her eye. "*Tony* wants me to come downstairs," she said. "And have a drink."

She adjusted herself, holding the phone away from her body, but moving it all over the place so that all he saw was a blur of flesh tones and white sheets. When the image steadied, her hair was free of the towel and she was reclined on the pillows. "I don't know," she said, in a throaty, sexy voice.

"I'm sooo tired. And I don't want to fuck up at training."

Jack stared at her. He wasn't speechless - three or four things were jammed up in his mouth, tumbling all over each other, trying to get out. They stuck behind his lips and he moved his mouth uselessly in several false starts before giving up and saying, "And...?"

"And..." Nikki said, shrugging casually. She yawned again. "I'll probably..."

She looked skyward again. And then Jack heard three rapid, forceful knocks on a metal door and Nikki sat up, taking the phone with her. Her eyes went wide, and she shared a conspiratorial smile with Jack. "Someone's here," she said. "I'll call you right back."

And then she was gone.

*

Jack paced the house with his phone in his hand, looking at it every few seconds. His organs, slowly solidifying after each unrequited glance at his phone, melted to a liquid that felt like it was pouring out of his feet, every time the face of his phone stared back at him, no calls, no missed class, no texts from Nikki.

Occasionally, a wave of panic washed over him. He pictured Nikki going to the door of her hotel room - he could envision it all so easily, so perfectly, even the way it smelled, because air ambulance had done joint drills with the cops all the time, and they had also been offered rooms at the same hotel.

Nikki. What had she been wearing? He hadn't seen it. He could only assume a towel, loosely wrapped around her body. A white, too-small, middle-end hotel towel. It would wrap around her, and she would be able to tuck it at her cleavage, the way women did. But it would be short, just covering the tops of her thighs, barely down to the bottom curve of her ass. When she walked, it would rise above the supple flesh of her bottom, giving anyone behind her a peek at the expanse of smooth, pale roundness, before snatching it away as she took her next step.

Whoever had come to the door would have to struggle to keep his eyes on her face. A slash of skin where the towel came together at the side would be

screaming at him to look... to see if, where the ends of the towel did not quite come together, he would be treated to a sliver of thigh, or even a view of the damp, hot crease where her leg and torso met. Maybe it climbed higher, revealing some of her hip bone, a flash of stomach. Maybe the whole thing was precariously tied together, the weak knot slipping apart, the whole towel sliding open in minuscule increments, about to fall to the floor at any moment.

No amount of suggesting to himself that maybe Nikki had not answered the door in a towel that barely covered her body could wash these images out of his mind.

There was nothing for him to do with that, though, but sit. And wait.

At first, he thought it would be a matter of minutes. His fantasies aside, it was only reasonable to believe that Nikki had looked out the peephole, told whoever it was to please wait, found some clothing to throw on, answered the door, and sent the person away.

She would call him back any moment.

But five minutes turned into fifteen. He kept a tight fist closed around his paranoia and the dark corners of his mind for that long, but when the minutes continued to tick by with nothing from Nikki, his grip slipped completely.

He stared at his phone, looking at the time and the time stamp on Nikki's call, subtracting and adding and then performing complex and unnecessary calculations to figure out, time and again, that half an hour had gone by. Then forty-five minutes.

He started to type a text to her, but by then it seemed like too much time had passed. His finger hovered over the send button, while he tormented

himself with possible explanations for Nikki not calling him back. Was Tony there, in her room, right now?

He closed his eyes.

That was preposterous. Nikki wouldn't have taken these things from zero to one hundred in such a short time.

That wasn't like her at all.

For every thought like that one - reasonable, centered - another would chase on its heels.

Was anything Nikki was doing "like her" at all?

And if Nikki *had* opened the door for Tony, thrown her towel on the floor, and walked backward to the bed with a crooked finger, saying "Come and get me, bad boy," well, that wasn't actually something he could get mad about.

It was, after all, what he had told Nikki he wanted.

He smashed his thumb into the send button theatrically, moving his whole hand and the phone.

Hey babe... you disappeared. What's up?

*

Two possibilities existed, as far as he could tell.

It was the usual: Nikki either knew exactly what she was doing.

Or Nikki was clueless, and if that was the case, she was out of control.

He stared at his phone and cursed under his breath. He had stopped pacing and was on the couch now, in the dark. Somewhere in his gut, among all the

lurching emotions and cold tremors, he sensed that he was hungry. But that was so many layers deep that he ignored it.

Was he drunk? He'd poured himself two whiskeys but he hadn't even finished the first one; he'd just poured more into the glass and then held it, staring at his motionless, information-less phone.

Nine o'clock came and went, and his text went unanswered. He sipped his whiskey and traveled in the same circles, over and over again. A quiet - and if he really thought about it, unfair - fury began to build inside of him. It was directed at Nikki, and it was unreasonable, which were both things he spent most of his married life combating. He swatted thoughts like these down all the time, and in this case, he had very little leverage.

After all, if Nikki was clueless, then she couldn't be blamed for not understanding what this wait was doing to him.

If she knew exactly what she was doing, then... well, she was doing it well.

Finally, finally, the small dots at the bottom of his text screen appeared and began to hop along the bottom frame, like a wave at a football game, popping up and falling down one at a time.

After they stopped - and still no message appeared, his heart kicked inside his chest with a frightening force.

When they began again, and again left him no message, his anger started to boil over.

He had an inclination to write to her, to tell her that he saw her typing. But what kind of idiot would he look like, then? At this point, Nikki knew he had a wild fantasy. She didn't really understand it, you could tell. Jack definitely had not opened the floodgates to his innermost thoughts, either.

She couldn't know - and probably wouldn't want to know - that he was watching the screen of his text messaging app and playing a pornographic scene of his wife with a black man over and over and over again until he had become a manic, depraved, shell of a man.

His hands had started shaking. He slammed his whiskey and started pacing again. Nikki couldn't possibly know that he was staring at his screen, desperate to know what had happened to her.

Finally, at eleven, a message.

So sorry honey, just got this. Went to the bar with the guys. Just getting back now. Call me if you're still up.

His eyes moved over the words "just got this," over and over and over again. He had gone cold when he first read them and the chill had not vacated his chest cavity. Every beat of his heart seemed to push against inflexible, frozen muscle.

It was a lie, wasn't it? He *had* seen what he had seen? She *had been* typing, hours ago. So this was not something she had just seen, and that was a lie.

A small, unimportant one. One that didn't even need to be told. And yet she had.

And if Nikki was going to lie about something like that, what else would she lie about?

Why would she even lie about this message and when she saw it? What was her motivation? Why even write that line, when she didn't have to?

He began a message, seeing red, his thoughts scattered and disconnected. Sharp thoughts, barbed thoughts, aching and painful thoughts - maybe they were better described as feelings, around which a few words and images

gathered, trying to pass themselves off as a thought - collided inside him and sent shrapnel everywhere.

He stared at the first word of his latest message: Hey.

And then didn't send it.

And perhaps this was what Nikki had done, at some other point in the evening. Perhaps it was nothing so sordid as he imagined, just an inability to find the right thing to say. Maybe Nikki, as confused as he was, had begun a message several times and then abandoned it, and there was nothing nefarious to this at all.

He was, after all, doing the same thing.

Suddenly impatient, he called her.

The phone rang, and rang, and then passed him to voicemail.

He had no idea how Nikki's phone was set up, how many times it would ring for her before naturally going to voicemail.

Or if she had swept his call away the way you would swipe away an unappealing Tinder profile.

He sat in the darkness and let his demons crawl out from every corner of his mind, masturbated, and then found the bottle of whiskey, and, deliberately leaving his phone behind in the living room, took himself and his glass of pure whiskey to bed.

Where he lay, eyes wide open, staring at the ceiling, not having drunk any of it.

A man whose wife was three hours away in a hotel, writing platitudes and lies to her husband, and doing something else entirely.

Maybe sleeping.

Maybe just drinking with "the guys."

Maybe writhing beneath the bulky, black muscle of Tony the badass cop, too busy "playing it by ear" to call him.

It was a long night.

CHAPTER 11

I fell asleep! It's like two am now, I won't wake you.

Tell you all about it tomorrow.

Xoxoxo

Jack stared at the messages. His throat was dry, he needed to piss, and a brutal, gnawing hunger - or acid reflux - clawed at his stomach and chest.

Maybe he was having a heart attack.

The thought came and went, like all the others that occasionally broke through his trance as he stared at the messages from his wife, and their time stamps.

He wondered what series of events had led to Nikki sending these messages at 2:34 am, 2:41 am, and then, as an after thought - the "Xoxoxo," ten minutes after that.

It was early; not even six. He felt like he hadn't gotten a moment of sleep, and yet this couldn't be true - he would have heard the beep of these messages over the roar of an airplane if he had actually been awake at that time. With sleep, though, it really didn't matter what had actually happened, it only mattered how you felt. And he did not feel good.

Nikki's messages were many things. A trail of breadcrumbs that made jealousy flare inside him. That jealousy fueled dark and filthy fantasies that he felt a little sordid for even having *thought up*. But like porn scenes that, for whatever reason, stuck in his head, he replayed them over and over again and they didn't lose any luster.

His rational mind occasionally broke through this fever to point out that he had no idea what had actually happened, and no reason to believe that Nikki was, even now, still riding Tony in her hotel room, his dark, thick column sliding easily through the thick semen soup that oozed from her pussy.

If he would only stop imagining that scenario, and others like it, he knew he wouldn't have to experience the constant, shredding pain of the conflict that gripped his psyche: if his darkest fantasies *had* taken place, was he excited and happy, or distraught and miserable about it? If Nikki hadn't been up to anything last night, was he relieved or disappointed?

A blue, empty light was just piercing the night. It had been a full moon, and the yard from his window had been bathed in a bright silver glow that had somehow made it that much harder to get through the endless, waking hours. It was almost six am.

Was that too early to call Nikki?

He asked himself the question and it hung in the air around him, unanswerable. Unanswerable because he was so tired, but also because he didn't know what Nikki was doing, or what Nikki had done.

He made his way to the bathroom to take care of the pressure on his bladder, then started the coffee and began moving around like a robot, focusing on the tasks that would get him from the bedroom, through the kitchen, to his car with a cup of coffee. It was actually a semi-fun mind game, taking him back to his days as a CCP before he worked the air ambulance. The only way through a shitshow of a scene was one task at a time, focused on the great procedural flow chart in his mind, never thinking backward, only thinking as far ahead as absolutely necessary.

That's how you got things done in a chaotic situation, and if this situation wasn't chaotic, he didn't know what was.

Calling Nikki was not an actual priority in his real life as a real man with a real job who did not have any real reason to believe that his wife was fucking a black man all night, and even if she was, there was nothing he could actually do about it.

Sometimes you had to make that kind of call.

It worked fine, as far as it all went, and he got himself into the car with a cup of hot coffee in a mug and down the street to the first intersection without the intrusive thought barging in too much.

But out on the freeway, in stop-and-go traffic, his grip on his own thoughts slipped.

It was tempting to call Nikki now - it was seven forty-five, and surely her training started at 8am like every daytime thing in emergency services started.

But Nikki could have called him, too, he reasoned.

And he was more than a little miffed that she hadn't.

Didn't she *understand* what was going through his head? How could she possibly not?

It infuriated him. It infuriated him either way: whether she was doing this deliberately, or carelessly, or because she was just so preoccupied with Tony and his cock, it didn't matter. Whatever the reason, he found a way to contort her motivations in his own mind into something beastly: his wife was too caught up with a new dick to even think of him. Or she was aware that she was torturing him and didn't care. Or, she just... what? Didn't know

that writing something like that was the equivalent of sticking his balls in a vice, cranking it closed just to the point of pain, and then leaving him there and not telling him when she'd be back?

His cock throbbed painfully in his pants.

He looked at his eyes in the rear-view mirror and they were frantic.

Which only made him more distraught.

The minutes ticked away on the clock, and soon it was past eight, and he was still crawling along in traffic, late for work and with a wanton wife somewhere in Aderville, either shooting guns with Tony's broad chest against her back and his biceps against her arms, or rolling around in the bed with him.

"It's okay," Tony in Jack's mind said. "I'll excuse you for being late. You can make it up to me later."

Jack's brain flashed forward to his wife on her knees apologizing to Tony for being late to class, which almost caused an accident.

Just as he recovered from the shock of almost rear-ending a sizable semi, which may or may not have killed him, his phone rang and the annoying car voice droned on about it. It was a private number, but he knew it was Nikki without looking at it.

He wanted very much - very much - to have the balls to not answer the phone. He was, after all, about two minutes from work, and he didn't really want to have this conversation blaring loudly through the parking lot. The idea of making Nikki wait to talk to him had a pleasant taste to it. How would she like wondering all day why *he* didn't answer the phone.

But his thumb had already moved to the answer call button on the steering wheel, and evidently already pressed it, because a ring cut off mid-warble and the white noise of cellphone airtime filled the compartment.

"Jackson?" Nikki asked, when he didn't say anything. There was no reason for his silence, he just hadn't caught up mentally to the actions of his thumb.

"Hey. Yeah. Hey babe, sorry, I didn't realize I had..."

He cut himself off. He sounded like an idiot. Nikki didn't give a shit about his phone-answering foibles.

"Uh.. okay. Hey. I didn't expect to actually get you - are you at work right now?"

Nikki's voice was:

Totally normal.

Totally, totally, totally normal.

She sounded exactly like a woman would sound, if she had stayed up late at a hotel bar on a work trip, woken late, called her husband before hurriedly heading to a breakfast buffet to grab a half-toasted bagel and a container of cream cheese that she would try to eat in the car on the way to the training center.

"Just getting there," he said. "Had a rough night."

"Oh," Nikki said. "Oh, sorry, I didn't - I was up again at like two, but I didn't call you 'cuz I thought you were asleep..." Nikki's voice trailed off, as she was obviously thinking about all of that, and how it sort of didn't add up. "Anyway, me too, and I'm running late, but I just wanted to leave you a message so you didn't worry. So. Here's the message. I actually gotta run, I woke up late and I think they're all waiting for me, so..."

As she spoke, Nikki breathed a little heavily, and he could hear the distinctive sound of hotel door slamming shut on their spring-loaded hinges in the background. Voices bouncing around in the acoustical nightmare of a Holiday Inn corridor came through from time to time in the background.

She was not, Jack told himself sternly, rolling around in bed with Tony.

"Okay," Jack said, stupidly.

"I'll call you as soon as class gets out."

Jack paused, considering his choices. He wanted to ask her about the previous evening. So much so that it itched in the back of his throat. But Nikki was in a hurry, and that made sense, and so he knew he should just shut up.

It didn't matter. In the time it took him to think about all of that, Nikki had already started saying goodbye. "Oh, there they are, babe, gotta run, bye... hey Mike, hold that door for -"

And then she was gone.

*

Jack stared at his computer.

"You look fuckin' faded, man."

Jack moved his eyes toward Mike who was, as usual, working fairly diligently, because it was Friday. His eyes were bloodshot, as always, and it was a certainty that whatever he was doing over there, he was doing the least good job of it that he could while still doing it passably. He tended to fuck around all week and then come to work half in the bag on Friday and shit out most of the tasks on his diary so that it looked clear on Monday.

"I am."

Mike snort-laughed and tipped his head, treating Jack to a rare grin.

"What'd you do, have a glass of wine?"

Jack's eyes were watery from lack of sleep. He rolled them toward Mike for a second time, and, seeing that Mike wasn't really listening to him anymore, sniffed. "Couple o' cups of whiskey while I waited for my wife to get back to me after going to the bar with all her new boyfriends in Aderville."

Mike clicked his mouse furiously and squinted at his screen, his attention obviously pulled more by the computer than by Jack's story. "Cups, huh? You drinkin' out of a measuring cup?" Mike laughed and clicked some more. "Tried that once."

His eyes shifted to Jack. "Didn't work."

"No?"

"Nah," Mike agreed happily, eyes back on his computer. "Still a drunk."

"I didn't realize that was something you were trying to change about yourself, Mike."

Mike shrugged and smiled again. "'M'not, really."

Jack returned his eyes to his own computer screen, and his own diary of tasks, which remained unchanged from the morning. His eyes scanned the list of tasks for the hundredth time, in search of an easy punt - a phone call to someone he could leave a message with, a quick fix, a letter he needed to mail. But everything was horrible and an hours-long project, and he knew he didn't have the concentration to finish a complex task right now.

Mike hadn't even nibbled at the bait he had offered him, which was just as well. Mike didn't have anything great to say about women, or anything that

any woman did, so he was the last person Jack should probably be talking to - even cryptically - about his wife and her activities. The conversation would almost assuredly go like this:

"What would you do, Mike, if your wife was at training with the tactical team in Aderville and she got home at three am and didn't even bother to tell you what she was doing when she called you, and you suspect her of having an affair, but you kind of want her to?"

"Meh... shoot her for sure."

No one knew if Mike was serious when he said things like that, but it wasn't exactly uplifting either way. It was definitely - categorically - useless advice.

But he felt like a shaken bottle of soda. He had to do something. Call someone. Go *somewhere*.

And maybe that was where he got the idea.

CHAPTER 12

The Holiday Inn Aderville was in a drab expanse of industrial park wasteland. All sorts of emergency services training centers were stashed away among the yards of rusting machinery, shipping containers, and enormous, steel-sided buildings. Ubiquitous blue and white signs meant for no one but delivery drivers announced cryptic names like "Stevenson Industrial Supply." Almost everyone figured that at least one in every five of these buildings was probably laundering money or trafficking in something illegal.

Jack knew the way: air ambulance had trained him there - in Aderville - but they hadn't offered him a hotel room. Strictly for people from the sticks. Suburbia didn't qualify.

Which was something that Jack thought of on his way there, which he let blossom into a whole line of paranoid thinking. Was he expected to believe that AEMS and AFD had suddenly loosened their purse strings and started offering hotel rooms to people who could, ostensibly, make it home from the training center?

Or was this Nikki's sleight-of-hand?

Or perhaps it was all just Tony. Jack could see a man like Tony doing something like that. Booking a hotel room and paying for it, telling Nikki it was all covered. What better way to get a pretty thing like Nikki all by herself for a few days?

The more he thought about it, the more real it began to seem. By the time her rolled into the Holiday Inn parking lot, he had almost convinced himself that the whole training session didn't even exist.

Which was, of course, ridiculous. He knew this as soon as he sat for a moment, the car no longer running, and looked at the scene in front of him.

"This is fucking crazy," he said to himself.

But he went in, and in less than ten minutes he was in his hotel room.

So crazy.

*

He was doing everything wrong, if you went by certain sets of advice from the "hotwifing" crowd.

That was all about communication. Laying out rules and boundaries. Together.

This was his thought as he sat on the edge of the bed of his *extraordinarily* overpriced hotel room. He was fucking everything up.

This was the thought that had nagged him as he made his reservation online, as he walked into the lobby with his eyes shifting left and right, looking for signs of Tony, or his wife, or cops in general. But it was still afternoon, and he checked in so smoothly it seemed unreal. There had been nowhere to go but down the path he had chosen for himself.

What was it he really wanted, though? He dug deep, trying to find it. But it was slippery and dark, resisting cool, level-headed analysis. He wanted Nikki to have sex with Tony - he had his head around that much.

But the how, the where and the when, and most importantly, the *why*, eluded him. Something about setting it all up the way they described on hotwifing forums was missing something that he wanted.

Danger, maybe.

The risk of the unknown?

Those were the kinds of things a man was obviously seeking if he crept around at a hotel an hour and a half (and only in bad traffic) from his own home, hoping to... what? Just *see* his wife with Tony? Who he had already insinuated she could have sex with?

"Okay," he said, taking stock of where he was after an hour of sitting on the bed, looking at the mirror and wondering who he was.

There was no way to "return" the hotel room, so that was a done deal. But he still had options. He could just stay here and never leave the room, never tell Nikki what he had done, and leave in the early morning hours. He could probably get away with something like that.

Or he could *tell* Nikki he was here. That he had come as a surprise.

But as soon as he started spinning up that alternate future, the wheels came off pretty quickly. He could almost hear Nikki, almost see her frowning face:

"Why the hell did you get *another* room?"

That was the kind of question he didn't have an answer for.

He looked at the clock. It was past five, so they'd be getting out of training soon and returning to the hotel. Nikki would call him, or maybe just text him, and he would have to decide whether to confess his craziness - and now it *did* seem like craziness - or hide it, and lie.

And then what?

Annoyed, feeling like he had already dug himself a hole and making it slightly deeper couldn't possibly make it any worse, he got up and opened

the fridge. Without considering the consequences, he fished a few whiskey bottles out and poured them into a glass.

He would have liked ice, but he didn't want to run into anyone in the hallway.

He gave himself a final look in the mirror: a middle-aged man, with a beautiful wife, sitting alone in a hotel room in Aderville, drinking a slightly chilled double of Crown Royal that would probably cost him \$30 in the end. Hoping to... what? Catch his wife flirting with her colleagues? Be closer in physical spacetime if she wanted to fuck one of them? Or was he here to make it all happen somehow?

He lifted the glass to his reflection.

Cheers, you stupid fucker.

*

Time crawled by slowly, and once his inhibitions were knocked down by the first whiskey, it didn't take too much brooding in the darkening hotel room with no messages or peep from Nikki, for Jack to decide it was a good idea to have another.

This was also not highly recommended - if not actively discouraged - on the forums he had been on. He could see why. Alcohol was doing nothing for him except for making his wildest ideas seem more likely.

Seven o'clock rolled around, after what seemed like an eternity, and he lost his patience waiting for Nikki to contact him.

And really, he thought, he was justified in doing so. What kind of woman stays out until two at the bar, insinuating that things they had been insinuating for months now had actually taken place. Or not. But either way

- leaving him to wonder? All day long? And then not typing him, at the very least, a message... for hours?

It should have been, he reasoned drunkenly, the very first thing she did when she got in the car after training ended. And it couldn't possibly be going this late.

A wave of heated shame washed over him as he took his phone out and pondered being the first to send a text, but then decided he didn't want to look desperate.

What was he? Five years old?

But it was so *infuriating* that Nikki was just leaving him hanging. No matter what she was doing. Didn't she understand anything? Did she really not understand the *thirst* that she was causing, the paranoia and the insanity?

"Obviously not," he answered quietly, to himself, staring at his phone.

And there it was, layers peeled back from it so that he could touch the raw, tender nerves of it:

He wanted Nikki to be doing something - getting a ride back with Tony, because they obviously would have carpooled to the training facility - that made her forget all about her husband. He wanted her to slip here and there, to find herself in an awkward position, to see for herself that Tony had one thing on his mind and one thing only, and then to... lose control.

He didn't know why. But that was the fantasy that he turned over and over in his mind, the sequence of events that he liked to replay in his imagination.

At least - this is what he wanted in theory. Now that it seemed like it might actually be taking place, he wasn't so sure.

As if his thoughts had been broadcast straight to Nikki herself, his phone vibrated in his hand.

Hey. Just heading back to the hotel now. Call you in half an hour?

*

Nikki was freshly scrubbed, her cheeks flushed rosily on her cheekbones and cheeks, which was what happened when she showered in excessively hot water for a longer time than usual. He supposed he should have been grateful that the flush came from a shower, and not some internal fire of shame or excitement that Nikki had brewing inside her.

Instead, he felt equal parts disappointed and relieved as he scrutinized her appearance. Her cheeks shone like she had scrubbed her face clean with cleanser - something Nikki only did before going to bed. Her eyes were glassy with excitement, but she seemed physically tired, her eyelids sleepy and sexy.

This could all be interpreted several ways: she was tired, exactly as she said, from training. Excited *because* of training - firing guns and rolling around on the floor, pretending to get protected by bulky, elite cops in a life or death scenario. Tired from staying up too late, excited from learning new things. Freshly showered because she had sweat a lot doing intense physical activity, and scrubbed clean because she had only one thing on her mind right now: getting a responsible amount of sleep.

Of course, she could also be glowing from the excitement of flirting with *sexual* danger. Exerted from the emotional thrill of being rescued by burly cops, from squeezing Tony's bicep as they huddled together in some kind of attack team, his sweat mingling with hers, making her think of all the ways that could happen in a more private setting...

"Hey," she said cheerfully, her features animated and shining - the excitement - but her eyes heavy. She yawned. "Sorry I'm calling kind of late -" she interrupted herself with another yawn. "Everybody wanted to go on a run after class, and I didn't want to look like a wimp, so..." She yawned again - this was now enough yawning to make Jack think it might be theater. "How was *your* day? Hey, I can't see you by the way."

"Uh, yeah... I don't know what I did with my, uh, camera," Jack said. A stab of guilt punched through his chest as he lied, but it turned into a warm, gently vibrating thrill. "You went running? After class?"

"I *know*," Nikki agreed, looking down at something that captured her attention. "These dudes are *crazy*."

There was a pause, one which was uncomfortable only for Jack by the look of it - Nikki was preoccupied with whatever she was looking at, in the vicinity of her legs, if he was reading her position correctly. It was hard to tell how she was sitting. Her hair was wet and loose, which meant nothing at all, but sent Jack's mind to all sorts of places, wondering why. Why not wear it in a towel? Or braid it, like she usually did for training exercises?

"Anyway," Nikki said, distractedly, after frowning at whatever she was looking at and looking back into the camera. She yawned again. "I'm really tired, honestly. I hate to disappoint you, but I think I might just go to bed."

She smiled.

There was a lot to read in that smile, Jack thought. And yet, nothing at all.

"Really?" he asked. He tried to say it in a neutral voice, but the disappointment soaked through.

Nikki's ears seemed to pick up, almost as obviously as if she was a fox in the woods. Her eyes glittered and her smile became more liquid, more cryptic. Sexier. "You sound disappointed," she said, and the screen turned blurry as she changed position, winding up on her stomach, pillow bunched under her chest and chin, feet swinging playfully behind her head in the background. "What did you think I was going to do?"

He shrugged, forgetting momentarily that he wasn't on camera.

"Uh, no..., not... what?" he bumbled.

Nikki smiled into the camera, without opening her mouth. "What did you *want* me to do?" she purred.

She waited, and he stared at the phone with his mouth open. Nikki grinned again. "This is pretty hard, not being able to see your face," she said, and the screen went blank.

Jack was actually pretty happy. This was an issue he knew exactly how he felt about. "Hey," he complained. "No need to turn off the lights."

Nikki's throaty laugh came through, sound only. "This seems more fair," she said.

Another pause.

"So... are you going to ask me about... training?" Nikki asked. There was something coy in her voice. Jack's own brain was working a little slowly, so he was nitpicking his reply, thinking of a way to politely dismiss the training talk and get Nikki around to what he really wanted to hear about - last night at the bar, with "the guys," and not getting back to her room until 2am.

But Nikki surprised him. "Or did you want to hear about last night?"

Everything in his torso lurched, turned to a cold sludge, and seemed to crawl down the insides of his skin like splattered guts on a wall. It was a sinking feeling, but cold and violent. His heart was the only thing that remained painfully intact, beating palpably in his chest. An errant thought flitted through his head: he was having a heart attack.

But he wasn't. His mouth was dry and his cock was rigid, and he could feel every staccatoed beat of his heart, but he was very much alive.

"Hon?" Nikki asked, in a saccharine voice.

"Last night..." he said. He wasn't trying to be coy, it was just the only thing he could get out of his mouth.

But Nikki took it as a game. "Oh. No? Oh, okay. That's good, that's fine..."

"Nikki..."

"... not much happened anyway..."

"Nikki," he said again.

Nikki laughed.

Another pause.

"You got home pretty late last night," he prompted.

"Mmm-hmm," Nikki teased, sending his guts through a mulcher again.

"You said you'd tell me all about it," he continued. His voice had a strange, hoarse, robotic quality to it. It was, he realized, the sound of desperate desire throttling his larynx.

"I *did*," Nikki purred. Her voice changed suddenly, back to the tones of a sunny kitchen and not a vixen's dungeon. "I can't *believe* you didn't call me

about this all day."

Jack made a sound that left his mouth like a groan and "Eh," smashed together.

"Maybe you didn't want to," Nikki said. Her voice had returned to the unfamiliar, but titillating and terrifying, teasing voice. "Maybe you weren't all that interested."

Her voice licked at his insides like flames, like the tongue of a cat. A quality that he had always fantasized about lurked in it, rising to the surface like the fin of a shark and then disappearing. It unsettled him, attracted and horrified him.

"Of course," he croaked, and the "c" caught in the back of his throat, his flesh sticking together like the physical embodiment of his filthy thoughts - a slimy, gagging, wet, fleshy darkness made into sound. "Of course I want to know."

Another purr from Nikki, and he felt like the room shifted around him. This was not his wife, this person on the other end of the phone. He wanted more of her, to linger with this creature and make her tell him stories in that *voice* - but his high felt like the crest of a roller coaster, his body slipping out of the grip of the most fundamental things. Gravity. Control. All the rules that had governed his marriage and his understanding of it.

"Hmm," she said. "Well... I went down to the bar to meet everyone -"

"What did you wear?" he interrupted.

A pause. He felt like he could hear Nikki's smile through the phone. The brush of her lips close to the microphone as she grinned seductively. Then

she laughed, bringing him back down to earth. "What did I - wear?" she asked. "Just pants. And a shirt."

The roller coaster of disappointment, on which he was also traveling, crashed into the ground.

"God. I didn't want to seem, like, *obvious*."

And then went hurtling back up to another peak.

"I mean, what could I do? I can't go down there in some cocktail dress."

"You don't even have a cocktail dress."

"Exactly," Nikki laughed. "Anyway. I went downstairs -"

"But which shirt? Which pants?" Jack asked. He was drunker than he thought.

Nikki sighed, and then he heard the smile return to her voice. "Okay... jeans... and a red shirt."

"*The* red shirt?"

"I didn't know there was *a* red shirt."

There was. It was off the shoulders and fit her snugly, and she had a lipstick color that matched it exactly and Jack knew the date, time, and event they had attended each and every time she had worn it.

"The sexy one," he said. "No shoulders."

"Oh. Yeah. That's the one I wore."

Another pause.

"Anyway." Her voice was sexy again. "I went down... to meet everyone, and we played some pool..."

She let this linger, Jack had no idea if she was doing it intentionally, letting his visual imagination run wild, picturing her in her tightest jeans and the sexy red shirt, bent over in front of Tony, a long stick sliding between her fingers while she lined up a shot, which Tony would have every reason to bend over and help her with, because Nikki was *awful* at pool.

"And how did you do?"

Nikki demurred, and then purred. "Actually, I won, if you can believe that."

"Oh, I believe it," he quipped.

"Why?" Nikki asked, hamming up feminine confusion in her voice. He could practically see her striking a pose that she did whenever he insinuated she couldn't do this or that stereotypically male thing.

Which, to be fair to him, was often the case.

When she did this, she put her finger to her lip and opened her eyes wide to look up at the ceiling with her lips protruding the way the first girls of the selfie generation posed for pictures like drunk ducks. "You don't think they... gasp... *let* me win?"

Did she know what she was doing? There were layers and layers of possibilities, all of them darker than the one before, and Jack was peeling them away as fast as he could. Nikki really didn't know what she was doing, which was bad because it meant she had no control over anything. Nikki knew *exactly* what she was doing, which meant that she had psychic powers and had also been lying to him all through their marriage in the worst way possible - in every action, every proclamation, every gesture, every deed.

Or it was some combination of these things, which made it messy, complicated, and terrifying.

"Because I'm a girl?" Nikki asked, feigning innocence again. "Oh, Jack, you don't really think... guys would do that, do you?"

Jack had the distinct feeling that he had floated past a warning buoy into extremely dangerous waters. This was all fun and games, with Nikki verbally rolling her eyes at the suggestion that she didn't know what made guys tick when they let an attractive woman win a game of pool (after "helping" her with her form).

But if anything spilled over from there into the territory of questioning her professional qualifications, she would blow right the fuck up in his face. And it was a very thin layer of ice between a bunch of cops on an elite tactical team (who quite obviously would not suck at pool) using a game of billiards to flirt with a woman, and an elite tactical team choosing a hotty over other candidates to be on their elite tactical team in order to get in her pants.

"No," he said, firmly. "Not in a million years."

Nikki laughed.

"Those guys definitely tried to kick your ass, and it's amazing that you beat them."

She laughed again. "Maybe I had a *little* help."

Another thrilling ride to the bottom of the roller coaster for Jack.

"Like Tony?" His voice was dry again, too serious. He couldn't stop himself.

He heard a sucking sound, and pictured Nikki sucking the fattest part of her lower lip behind her front teeth, inhaling, and letting the pink flesh slip out

bit by bit, in rolling, wet bubbles of distended lip. She did this whenever she needed to buy time.

"Well," she said, in a throaty, tantalizing voice. "He *did* line up all my shots for me."

Jack's head swam with visions of Tony's dark muscled frame plastered to Nikki as she leaned over the pool table, butt upturned, shirt riding down to expose a sliver of her midriff. Tony's hands moving from her shoulder, down her arm, his chest piling slowly against her back, his cock hard against her ass, Tony not trying to hide it at all.

"Uh-huh," Jack said, sinking fully into the fantasy. "I imagine you had to get pretty close for that."

"So close," Nikki said.

Another pause.

"And...?" Jack said.

"And..." Nikki teased, and then the screen flashed as she put the camera back on. She was still propped up on her pillow. "Everyone was still there, you know. And like, Tony was flirting and everything, but... yeah, they were all still up around two and so I was like, I have to get to bed. So I did."

Jack was crestfallen. And relieved.

Which one was it? Jesus. Nikki would tell him to pick a lane.

"And Tony just let you go."

Nikki raised her eyebrows.

"You were like, 'I'm going to bed,' and he was like... 'okay, see you tomorrow?'"

Nikki shifted and bunched the pillow up. She seemed both amused and somewhat distressed. "Yeah, basically," she said. "I don't know." She put her thumb to her lips. "Maybe we're reading him all wrong, you know? Maybe he's just... one of those guys who just likes to flirt with the idea, you know?"

It was impossible to tell whether Nikki was fucking with him or not at a moment like that.

"Honey," he said, calmly. "That isn't... that isn't a *thing*."

"What isn't?"

"Whatever it is you're trying to say there. Okay? Guys don't do "flirting with the idea" of having sex with a hot chick."

"He's kind of my superior officer," Nikki said, her voice flat, as if that sentence explained everything and proved her point.

"Something else is up," Jack said, dismissing that hypothesis out-of-hand. Of *course* Nikki would think *that* would matter to a guy: she was used to dealing with the fire department, which was just about as do-gooder, Iowa farmboy, aw-shucks as you could get.

All that meant, in real terms, was that they would not *play* pool with a married colleague while at training, but would instead lock themselves in their room and not answer the phone to make sure that the possibility never came up. Those guys were all about fire prevention.

No wonder she was so bonkers clueless. Her sample set for male behavior was pretty skewed.

Nikki laughed. "Oh my God, you're so paranoid. No, look, the truth is, I got a completely different read on Tony last night. Like, this was fun and all,

but it's just a game. I think. And I don't know..." she looked up at the ceiling. "That's probably for the best. Anyway, I was a train wreck today and I really need to get some sleep. Even though..."

Her voice trailed off.

"Even though...?"

"Huh? Oh, just... it's not a very big day tomorrow. I mean, this is all just like, basics for now. But still."

Jack had an image of himself suddenly, a man in a hotel room by himself, hoping to... what? Catch his wife cheating? Make his wife cheat? What was he even doing here? What the hell had his plan even been?

He pondered all this, and Nikki turned her attention to her leg, looking down at it without moving the hand holding the phone, so that mostly all he could see was the top of her head.

"I got such a huge bruise," she was murmuring, "but it's one of those really annoying ones that doesn't look like anything at all..." She looked up at the phone and her expression changed immediately.

"Jack," she whispered. She looked almost ashen. A jitter made the picture shake minutely in her hand.

"He's calling." Her voice was a whisper.

Jack watched himself in the mirror, a smug grin spreading across his face. He was happy Nikki couldn't see him. The feel-good punch of being right was canceled out by a punch to the gut that made him want to double over in pain, leaving a scowl on his face that looked more like constipation than anything else.

"What do I do?" Nikki sat up, and for a moment he had a view of the ceiling and her hair hanging over the camera, a sliver of her towel-encased breasts at the edge of the field.

Jack stared at his own, contorted features in the dim light reflected in the mirror. Something monstrous and foolish looked back at him.

But when had that ever stopped him?

"Answer it."

*

If time had been moving slowly before Nikki's call, it slowed to an excruciating near-standstill after she hung up. He wondered if Tony had *called*, the old-fashioned way, using a phone, or if he had gotten treated to Nikki half-naked and wet from a shower, with her flushed cheeks and glassy eyes, answering in a sleepy drawl.

What did a guy like Tony say when he called a girl like Nikki: married, hot, technically under his supervision? He would have paid anything to know, anything to hear what kind of verbal jiu-jitsu Tony was performing on the phone.

Whatever it was, he didn't understand why it would be such a lengthy conversation. Five minutes seemed like more than enough, but seven minutes had gone by, and his wife hadn't called back.

After ten minutes that seemed like an eternity, his phone vibrated in his hand. Nikki. He stared at her picture - it was old, a photo from his own phone that he had captured when she had looked back at him after stepping into their yard the day they had bought their house. It distilled perfectly the

essence of Nikki: her golden hair back-lit by the sun, her skin flawless and her smile broad and authentic. Sweet, pretty, sugar-cookie-like Nikki.

Good Nikki.

He answered but didn't say anything immediately, and neither did Nikki. For a few moments, her breath was all he could hear - this may have been a hallucination - steamy and hot, shaking with excitement. Some nervous, wound-up energy made the edges of her words jagged with a tremble of lust.

"Okay, I don't even know what happened."

His thoughts came to a screeching halt and a wave of disappointment crashed over him.

"Jackson," she said, after a bit. "Did you hear what I said?"

"I did," he said, his own voice shaking with the same tremor as hers. "What did he say? Specifically?"

Nikki laughed nervously. "Okay," she said, lowering her voice like there were twenty people in the room she didn't want hearing her. "He called and he said I looked a little tired, and I was like, yeah, I am, and he said, well, you know tomorrow is mostly classroom wrap-up... and then, yeah, I don't know, he said, you already told everyone you're going to bed early, I'm gonna head to the bar and show my face around, and then *I'm* gonna turn in early. And so I was like...oh-kaaay. And he goes: 'Unless maybe you're not so tired.'"

Jack processed all of this and really wished he could have heard the actual conversation, because he was pretty sure Tony put a much smoother spin on it.

Nikki giggled. "God, I don't know exactly how he put it, but it was, you know. A pretty clear implication. Invitation. Whatever. But also he tried to make it sound like it *wasn't*... so maybe, you know, it's not." She sighed loudly, like she had just finished a performance and was relieved it was over. "Anyway, I freaked out and just kind of babbled, like, okay, well, see you tomorrow." She laughed.

"You know he's going to stop by your room later," Jack said.

Nikki made a weird noise. "Jack, I don't know... I don't think so."

Jack waited. "What if he did?"

Nikki let him simmer through a long pause. The purr that left her throat felt like her hand closing around his cock, squeezing, teasing:

"I guess I'll just have to play that by ear."

He exhaled.

"I hate to disappoint you," she laughed. "But I really think -"

"What if you went down there?"

Nikki's voice was caught in her throat, and she struggled with the beginnings of a few words before she managed to say, "I would - Jack, seriously. That's kind of... *desperate*, don't you think?"

It was. It was desperate and insane, and he knew it when he said it. But the whiskey had him making bad decisions, taking crazy risks, believing stupid ideas. He had a sudden urge to confess his presence, to tell her he had come as a surprise, to hang his head and go to her room and try to weasel his way into hot sex as a form of forgiveness, when a series of loud knocks and bangs echoed in her room. Muffled voices through the door, male voices, saying her name.

"What the - hey, okay, hang on a minute," Nikki said, and muffled movements filled the speaker as the voices got louder and more intelligible. "Nikki, Nikki, Nikki, help us!"

Typical stupid guy talk, typically cheesedick, they would start making jokes about needing CPR next.

"Oh, God," Nikki said, and she sounded both happy and annoyed. "Hon, I gotta call you back, okay?" She opened the door as she hung up, and the chorus of male voices cheered. Just before the sound cut off, leaving Jack in the room in utter silence.

*

Okay, there was no getting rid of them.

I'm just going to have a beer and then I'm going to bed. Path of least resistance.

I'll call you

This was hours ago.

Jack tried watching TV. He ended up cycling through an endless carousel of commercials and channels, seeing nothing, thinking nothing. He took a shower, jacked off, checked his phone incessantly. The pit in his stomach expanded, swallowing the rest of his organs, leaving him hollow and filled with jealous rage. He was disappointed on two fronts: he didn't want Nikki in the bar with all the guys, he wanted her in her room, wearing her thin, white shirt and no panties, waiting for Tony to stop by and see if she needed anything...

It didn't matter. Any way you sliced it, he was a man consumed by desires that he couldn't even articulate to himself, drunk in a hotel room, probably 200 yards from his wife, hoping to... what? It didn't even matter. Whatever it

was he had come here to say or do, he couldn't tell Nikki about it. This was the height of weakness and mistrust, dishonesty and lurid lust. Perversion. His wife didn't want to sleep with some other guy for him; she was just amusing him by playing this game.

Or maybe she *did* want to sleep with some other guy, just not for him. For herself. Purely and entirely for herself. And now she was cutting him out of the picture.

He was sure Nikki had good reasons for letting "the guys" drag her out. Maybe there really was "no getting rid of them." No way to just look them up and down and say "Look assholes, I have to sleep so get lost." Nikki would have all kinds of reasons for explaining why she did what she did - it was easier to diffuse the situation this way, before it got too pranky, having drinks was an important part of team-building, and team-building was crucial on a tactical team.

Even though he was drunk and feeling pissy toward her, he had to admit that she had a pretty good case for all of that, if it's what she chose to say.

But she didn't *really* believe that there was nothing else to this?

And why did he care? It wasn't realistic to think that good, sweet, Nikki was headed to the bar with her male colleagues (of sorts) as a precursor to a filthy, raunchy gangbang.

And she obviously didn't feel like jumping in headfirst with Tony. Not yet.

He was just a man with perverted fantasies, sitting in a way overpriced hotel room by himself, because he had let himself get carried away.

He looked at the clock again. Now it was almost ten.

God. Someday, he supposed he'd have to confess all of this to Nikki.

Ten. What would he do, if he were the man he wanted Nikki to believe that he was? A sensible man, with a fanciful sexual fantasy that he didn't *really* care if she indulged or not, who was sitting at home salivating for details about her... probably very tame trip to a hotel bar with her coworkers.

Hey, he typed. *You back yet? Don't forget about your husband.*

He sent it without too many second thoughts. It struck him as what he would say, if he were the man he wanted Nikki to believe that he was.

But time just ticked away, and she didn't answer, and he delved into some more whiskey, and then he lost patience. All of these things combined and distilled into a compulsion.

He went out for ice.

*

Slivovitz and three guys poured out of the elevator. They were loud, raging, humming with a certain kind of mildly terrifying male energy. The kind of guys who, if they were at a bar, smart men would quietly move away from, parolees slipping silently out the back door. A felony assault was in the air, ready to break out any moment.

Jack turned to glance at the commotion just as he put the lid on his ice bucket. Seeing Slivovitz immediately, he recoiled, looking down, thinking only of how he could escape them if they rounded the corner.

They were yelling incoherent things at each other, snippets of stories, cop talk, trash talking nonsense, and his ass was puckering up as he formed his plan: look like he had somewhere to be, make no eye contact, and walk swiftly in the other direction.

"Yo yo yo yo yo," one of them yelled. "This isn't even our fucking floor, man."

"Huh what?"

"Dumbshit get back here. This is two."

And away they went. Jack glanced in the direction of the elevator as soon as he heard the doors closing: they were swatting at each other with violent punches and making jokes about how stupid Slivovitz was. Four white guys, he recognized them all from his uncomfortable trip to Stripey's.

It turned out, their faces were etched into his memory.

His phone vibrated. Nikki *calling*.

The ice rattled as he shifted the ice container, and then it tipped and the ice spilled. "Fuck."

He missed Nikki's call, abandoned the ice, and scurried back to his room.

The door clicked behind him, his heart racing, fingers frantically typing his voicemail password.

"Uh, hey, it's me. I guess I missed you. Sorry, I lost track of time. Um..."
There was a long pause. "Okay.... I'm just going to bed. So... I love you, have a good night, I'll... call you tomo - "

He replayed it. There was a tinny echo in the background. An obvious bathroom. A hint of deception, hesitation, *something* in her voice. She was almost whispering. And there, at the end, just before her message cut off...

He played it again. And again.

A high-pitched, lilting female voice in the background, beginning just as Nikki started to say "tomorrow." The kind of drunken squealing that

preceded, without doubt, a woman and her friends stumbling into a public restroom at a bar.

There were choices to be made, and he was sure he could have made a better one, but what harm could come from just having a little peek downstairs?

If he was wrong, he was wrong, and no one would know.

And if he was right...?

*

There were many, many bars and restaurants in the sprawling complex at the bottom of the hotel. Kids, up way too late, sloshed past him dripping wet, coming from the water park. The bars were full of all kinds of people, mostly men, mostly blue-collar, mostly alone. Bad karaoke had begun in one of them, and every time he thought he had covered the entire place, another set of doors or corridor would take him into another vast expanse of apathetic waiters, slightly changed decor, and more people, scattered around, looking for the most part as pathetic as he felt.

He had just decided to give up, telling himself that he had been wrong about the message, wrong about Nikki's plans, wrong about everything. But he was especially, especially wrong to be lurking around in the hallways of a hotel he wasn't even supposed to be at, trying to catch his wife doing something he'd suggested she do. Something she communicated honestly with him about.

There was no *reason* for Nikki to tell him a lie about going to bed, no matter what she actually wanted to do.

And then he saw her.

He stepped to the side to put a large column between himself and her, and as he did so, his eyes took in the rest of the scene: Nikki was standing, hand on the bar, one foot crossed over her ankle, twirling a little. And in front of her, seated on a tall bar chair, the ebony mass of Tony, seated, looking right at her.

Tony's presence fizzled into his consciousness just as he tucked behind the column, and his heart stopped cold. He paused behind the column and made a quick decision to keep walking, toward an expanse of black leather booths and TV screens flashing with sports programs.

A waitress approached and spoke to him; as soon as she left, he realized he had no idea what he'd ordered from her.

His attention was on Tony and Nikki, who were just talking. He tried to put himself into an objective mindset: did it really look like these people were flirting with each other? They weren't *touching*.

But flirtation was complex: tilts of the head, fingers to lips, differences in tone. From where he sat, it sure looked like flirting.

Nikki tipped her head to the side and chewed on her lip, staring at Tony. She was hesitating, unsure. Was she thinking about her husband, weighing her options, wondering if she could be forgiven for stepping over the line tonight, given that Jack had given her implicit permission?

Tony put a hand out to hers and started tracing little circles on the top of her hand. His mouth was moving, and Nikki's eyes dropped to his fingers on her skin. Jack couldn't see from there clearly, but he knew: the splotchy patches of pink were streaking her cheeks, her insides burning up. She tucked a strand of hair behind her ear nervously and fidgeted, then looked up

at Tony as if for instruction. She moved backward, caught in his stare, and sat on the bar stool next to him.

Tony lifted a finger and what looked like a Cosmo was produced almost instantaneously by the bartender, with a smile for Tony. Tony started talking to Nikki again, moving a little bit closer as he did. Nikki kept looking at her hand, where the lazy circles were getting larger. His fingers moved up her arm, and Nikki's eyes snapped up to meet his.

Then she took out her phone, shaking her head. Tony reached for it, calmly, and Nikki looked at him but let him take her hands in his and slowly retract the phone from between her palms. Still talking again. Nikki was blushing very clearly now.

Jack shuddered, a tremor that began deep in his abdomen and violently wracked him, when Tony lifted a hand to Nikki's face and brushed her lips with his thumb. Nikki stared back at him, motionless, not even breathing. He pulled on her lower lip as he retracted his fingers, and Nikki let him, captivated.

They sat there, staring at each other for a moment, and it seemed as though they were waiting for something. A pain had begun in Jack's abdomen and under any other circumstances, he would have doubled over and groaned.

But he was imprisoned in the scene before him, unable to move at all.

Nikki suddenly tipped her head, leaned on one arm on the bar and looked up at the bartender. She said something to him, and leaned back a little. The bartender shrugged, and Nikki turned back to Tony.

He was waiting for something.

Nikki's hand shot out and she grabbed her phone, and Tony sat up straight, physically indicating that he wasn't going to try to intervene.

Nikki looked at the phone, swept her fingers over it, and then lowered it slowly to look at Tony again. She brought her fingers to her mouth.

Indecisive. Her eyelashes fluttered. She started to turn her head, and Tony reached out and caught her jaw gently, turning her back toward him, talking to her. His sonorous baritone rose above the clatter in an unusual pocket of quiet. "You see what I'm..."

Jack didn't hear the rest. Tony waved a room key and set it down on the bar, sliding it toward Nikki. His hand went back to her jaw when she tried to turn her head again, and he leaned close to her and whispered in her ear.

Whatever he was saying, Jack would have paid a lot of money to know. Nikki was at first obviously resistant, protesting whatever he was talking about - although not very hard - with tiny shakes of her head and a tension in her body. But as he spoke, her body softened, her eyes became unfocused on something on the floor, and then she gave her lip another slow, sexy chew, before sitting up straight and looking at Tony.

Another long, intense stare. Jack was paralyzed. What was happening in front of his eyes was painfully obvious: Tony had his hooks in Nikki, he was sweet-talking her, and she was... maybe resisting, but not very hard. He could see she had already made the decision, that Tony had already talked her into something. It didn't take a genius to figure out what that was. Anyone in the bar could see they were going to bang within the next half hour.

Was Nikki thinking of calling *him*? Is that what Tony was talking her out of?

He fished his phone out and stared at it. He could probably still diffuse this whole thing with a single text. Nikki would get it, feel guilty, and the whole seduction scene would implode on Tony.

A deep, horrifying abyss opened up inside of him:

Or she wouldn't.

In a way, he realized, that was really what he thought he wanted. But faced with the possibility of actually running the experiment, the ultimate loyalty test, he balked. Was that the kind of question he wanted to risk having the answer to? What would he do with it, once he had it, if it was as horrible as he secretly feared it was? What if he texted her right now and then got to watch her lift her phone and read his text, and then shrug to Tony and go upstairs with him anyway?

Tony put a thick finger on the room key again. Nikki squirmed but didn't take her eyes off him.

She was thinking.

And then, out of nowhere, everything changed. Nikki brightened, smiled, and leaned toward Tony. She put her mouth to his ear, the one facing Jack, so that he could see her lips as they grazed Tony's ears, whispering her devious plan to him.

And then she slid off the barstool, smiling at Tony. Whatever she said made Tony grin, impressed. Turned on. His smile was smug and satisfied. Nikki turned and walked off, taking the room key with her.

Jack stared, watching her leave, confused. Was she going to bed after all? Or going to Tony's room? Of course they would go separately. Of course

she was going to his room, that was the exchange of keys, the discussion. Tony had just smooth-talked her into not calling her husband.

Or maybe everything was lies, all the way down. Maybe they already had a relationship, and he was a cuck who was still stupidly trying to get his wife to sleep with a guy that she was already banging?

Tony rolled toward the bar, took a sip of his drink, and spoke to the bartender, whose eyebrows went up. Tony paid his bill, stood up, and walked in the direction of the elevators to rooms.

His waitress came by and looked at him strangely. "You okay?" she asked. And then she looked alarmed. "Hey man, are you choking? Can you breathe?"

Jack started to nod, and then looked at her quickly. "Yeah, fine, breathing," he said. "Grab me my tab, will you?"

She squinted at him and held her tray away from her hips, exasperated. "You just had water so far, remember?"

He fished a twenty out and set it on the table, wordlessly clambering out of the booth and pushing past her, muttering thanks and apologies. She was not real. This was not real. Where was he going?

He didn't know.

*

They weren't on floor two. He assumed the rooms would have been booked as a group, in a block, so he would go looking.

Why? He didn't know. What was he going to do if he found the room? Barge in? Bang on the door? Hold a glass to it and listen in?

No. None of those things. But he had to go see what was happening, had to grab whatever snippets of it he could.

He didn't know if he was angry or thrilled. His muscles felt saturated with venom, with the agitation of adolescence, the irrational, aggressive, snarling beast that lived inside him and came out less and less as he aged. The kind of thing that made him want to destroy things. Testosterone, surging, filling his head with so much nonsense that he knew he wasn't thinking straight, knew he was walking right into trouble, and yet he couldn't stop himself.

Forty-two years of life experience tried feebly to talk him down: he was going to get his ass kicked, he was going to make a fool of himself, he was going to start something he couldn't finish. He didn't care. Alcohol hadn't helped, it only enhanced the worst instincts.

They were not on the second floor, and not on the first - because why would they get in the elevator? So they were on the third. Maybe their dumb, loud voices would lead him there.

What then? He didn't give a shit. He stopped even thinking about it.

But the third floor was a quiet, eerie place. He got a hold of himself as he stormed down the corridor. He was not going to start screaming his wife's name like some idiot. He had pushed her into this, basically okaying it.

Nikki would call him tomorrow and tell him all about it, and then he would get this all back under control, back under *his* control. He should have set more explicit rules, been more clear about what he wanted.

He just hadn't expected Nikki to be... so willing. So easily talked into doing something offside, especially when she didn't *have* to do that. She could have called him, she could have told him this was going on -

He fished his phone out as he threw the staircase door open violently.
Maybe she had.

But she hadn't.

He hadn't expected this level of aggression, of fury.

But then, he hadn't *really* expected Nikki to do anything like this. It was a fantasy, a dark, yawning abyss that he liked the *idea of*, but now that he saw the grotesque reality of it, he wanted to have never opened this box.

He was so mad he went all the way to the basement, where several workers looked at him strangely, and he had to awkwardly turn around and dash up the stairs. The exercise felt good. He jogged up to the third floor and then went back down, talking himself down the whole time.

He could call her.

He should call her.

What if she didn't answer?

He played her voicemail again in the stairwell, listening for every nuanced rise and fall of her voice.

He called.

She didn't answer.

*

Walking through the basement like a madman. An employee asked him if he was looking for something. He mumbled something about the gym, and the guy walked with him to a sad room with exercise equipment.

Jack pretended to examine the gym for a few minutes - there was no point, giving what he was wearing, trying to pretend he had gone there to work out. The pantomime was for the employee, who was lingering down the hallway with one eye on Jack.

This made him feel insane. He needed to go back to his room and get his head screwed on straight. Wandering around the hotel with wild eyes was going to end in a call to the police and, potentially, utter humiliation.

He was reading Nikki's messages while walking, fixating on the time stamps. He tried to create a narrative that made sense - a narrative in which his wife had done everything she had done, all the same - but in which Nikki wasn't lying to him in her voicemail.

That single issue stuck in his head, burning painfully through him. How had everything gone from exciting dream to nightmarish reality so quickly?

He was so preoccupied with this thought, looking at the screen of his phone, that he didn't notice anything amiss as he walked into his room. He *heard* something, and the lights were on, and somewhere in the back of his mind he registered those two pieces of information. They clashed with his memories of turning everything off on his way out there door, but Nikki's strange bathroom voicemail and subsequent behavior crowded everything but perplexed jealousy from his thoughts.

But his entire mind was wiped clean, in a sudden, heart-stopping moment, when he stepped into the main room and saw what was on his bed.

Nikki's face, first, before anything. Nikki's panic-stricken face, her features rounded and angled and contorted into an expression of guilt. Her mouth open, one hand on the bed behind her, the other in her hair. Sweat shiny on her skin.

All of her skin. All of it out, no clothing covering it, except for a clack lace bra that had been unhooked and pulled down her shoulders, the straps caught at her elbows and the lace covering nothing but a strip of skin across her abdomen.

She was seated on the edge of the bed, her legs spread apart.

That was all he saw for a moment. A wet, clicking sound drowned out everything else in the room, echoed in his ears over the rush of his own blood.

The scent of Nikki's pussy arrived in his thoughts next.

And only then, after processing these inexplicable visions, did the full picture congeal in his mind's eye. Tony, shirt off, large erection making a huge tent in the crotch of his tactical pants, was sitting next to Nikki at the edge of the bed. His mouth was against her neck, his arm resting over one spread leg, and his fingers were embedded in her pussy, sliding in and out, while he expertly worked on her clit with his fat thumb.

"Jack," Nikki whispered, letting her mouth hang open. "I..."

Tony moved his big head, rolling his gaze slowly in Jack's direction. He smiled, emitted a low laugh, and then dropped his eyes to his fingers and Nikki's slit. He continued to finger-fuck her, more slowly than before.

"Hope you don't mind, man, but we were waiting forever. I had to start in..." He nuzzled Nikki's neck and growled.

Nikki was looking at Jack, a pleading panic on her face. "I thought you would be right up," she said, blinking slowly.

Tony grinned and turned to look at Jack, who was still standing, frozen, with his phone in his hand. A feeble, waning circuit in his brain was still

trying to connect the dots, to make sense of what he was looking at.

This *was* his room.

This *was* his wife.

This *was* Tony, wrist deep in his wife's pussy.

But why they were all together was a mystery he couldn't put together.

His desire to figure it out, furthermore, was drifting away, pushed out of his mind by what was actually happening in front of him.

"Have a seat man," Tony said, his fingers still working in Nikki's pussy. He turned back to Nikki and kissed her mouth, as he slowly withdrew his fingers from inside her. They were shiny with her juices, and her pussy sloshed and spluttered when he pulled out completely.

He drew his hand up her body, over her mound, up the center of her torso between her breasts, along her neck to her lips. Then he fed his pussy-soaked fingertips to Nikki, who hesitated only a moment before opening her mouth and closing her lips around them, her eyes still on Jack.

"I made her come once already," Tony said, watching Nikki suck on his fingers. He emitted a growly laugh. "Now we can get started for real."

CHAPTER 13

Tony pushed Nikki back gently, and she went with him, lying down on the bed, still sucking on his fingers. He rose as Nikki folded her legs together and squirmed on the bed, watching Tony.

Tony glanced at Jack and smiled again, then gave a very deliberate turn and looked at the chair in the corner of the room. Back to Jack, his eyes delivering the message: Jack should sit down in that chair without saying anything at all.

Then Tony started to take off his pants.

Jack stumbled forward, moving closer to the wall and away from Tony, his head pivoting as he moved to keep his eyes on his wife. He was still reeling, but the confusion of thoughts about how all of this had happened was a dull roar somewhere far away. He sank into the chair, staring as Tony's pants and boxer dropped to his ankles, and his erect cock unfurled in front of him, heavy and thick.

Nikki was draped on the lower half of the bed, squirming a little, and her eyes went to Tony's cock and widened. Her lips, closed together almost primly, parted, and she sucked in a sharp breath.

Tony stroked his cock while Nikki watched, fascinated.

A better word might have been mesmerized. Whatever guilt or hesitation Nikki's face had been expressing when Jack walked into the room, it disappeared from her features as her eyes took in Tony's cock. Her pupils filled the blue of her eyes and followed the movement of Tony's hand along the many, many thick inches of his cock.

Tony was turning his body, rotating slowly, out of Jack's view except for his dark, naked backside. Jack's eyes were fixated on his wife, on the absorption she was displaying as she watched Tony. The creature on the bed, naked, rolling onto her side, looked like his wife, but wasn't - couldn't - be her. Nikki never looked at him like this, however much he wanted her to. This was an animal, reptilian force that had gripped her.

Tony moved to the head of the bed and heaved his considerable weight onto it as Nikki rotated onto her knees at the end of the bed, facing him, her hands on her thighs; a dissonant, child-like pose.

Tony settled in, stretching his legs out, resting against the headboard. He stroked his cock and looked at Nikki. "Come on up here, girl. Have a taste."

Nikki hesitated, then looked over at Jack. He stared back at her, serious, trying to beam his approval - such as it was - to her. But she looked at him fleetingly, her eyes drawn back to Tony's cock.

Tony was amused, and seemed to have written Jack's presence off completely. "Get on up here, baby. Don't be shy." He tipped his dick toward Nikki, pointing the swollen mass of his crown in her direction. A bead of precum oozed from the eye of his shaft, and Tony held himself while he collected it with a finger on his left hand.

Nikki had started crawling, slowly, toward Tony. He reached his cum-stained finger toward her, and watched it for a moment before leaning toward it. As Jack watched her tongue leave her mouth and curl up to the tip of Tony's finger, swiping at the cum, a pain seized him in the balls and lower abdomen that under any other circumstances would have caused him to keel over. His breath left his mouth shakily, rattling a little, as Nikki's tongue delivered the droplet to her mouth.

Tony moved his hand from her lips to her head. His fingers dove into her golden locks, weaving through them like black snakes until her entire head was cradled in his wide palm. He steered her slowly toward his cock, and Nikki went with him, offering no resistance, her lips parting, her eyes widening but fixed on the mass of cock nearing her mouth.

She put a hand out as he pushed her toward him, and Tony released his cock from his own fist so that she could wrap all over her slender, pale fingers around it at the base. Her jaw fell open a little bit more as her hand closed around him.

"Don't be shy, baby," Tony repeated. He watched Nikki as she hesitated, then grinned abruptly and rolled his head on the wall to look over at Jack. "Tell her not to be shy, man."

Tony's abs - not a prominent six-pack but a wall of thick flesh over a mountain of usable muscle, indicative of real strength - flexed beneath his skin as he leaned forward a little to take Nikki's hair up in both hands as Jack said, in a voice that was almost a whisper, "Don't be shy, honey."

Tony grinned. He was already back to watching Nikki's mouth as he helped move it ever closer to his cock. His fingers moved in her hair, pulling it into a rough ponytail that he held in two hands. Nikki looked up at him, her mouth inches from his cock. "It's so... big," she whispered.

It was difficult to know if this was said in awe or disbelief, with longing or a tremor of fear. Whatever it was, she didn't stop. She opened her mouth and closed her lips around the whole of Tony's crown, sucking on it like a Popsicle until it popped from her mouth with a wet sputter.

"Keep going," Tony murmured, his hands rearranging his grip on her hair, shifting the hold to his right hand. Nikki took a deep breath, and then

opened again as Tony gently pushed her further down his cock. She sucked on him down to her own fist a few times, and then lifted her head to take a breath, panting. Saliva dripped from her lips.

She had crawled up next to Tony's enormous left thigh, her knees together. She sucked on Tony a few times, and the picture was perverse, especially with her sitting primly like that. Tony let her suck on him, staring at her mouth as his cock disappeared in it, holding her hair in his hand and moving her head slightly with his fist, though Nikki seemed to be moving under her own power.

Tony watched this for a while, pleased, but moved his right arm forward after a bit, flexing his abs again to lean forward over Nikki while she sucked on him, to grab her ass and roughly pull her hips up the bed. He manhandled her, moving her around like a piece of meat, until he had planted her body on his left side, still sucking away at his cock.

Tony lifted her ass by wrapping his arm around her body and under her, between her legs. He propped her up with her ass in the air - facing the wall, which disappointed Jack in some ways but not others: Nikki was now facing him, and she lifted her eyes as she diligently sucked Tony's cock. Her gaze met Jack's and she looked at him while Tony's black dick disappeared and reappeared, slithering from between her lips, a wet sound crackling in the room.

Tony rested his left arm on her lower back and ass and wormed his fingers down her crack. Jack could only see the rolling motion of his knuckles, the secondary, incidental flexing of his forearm and fingers, but he could hear quite clearly as Tony slipped his fingers into Nikki's pussy and fingered her while she continued to suck him off.

Nikki squirmed and murmured, her mouth full of cock, as Tony played with her. This went on for a bit, Tony rolling his head to one side to get a better view of Nikki's mouth on his cock, then rolling it the other way to look over her rump at his hand cupping her ass, his fingers plunging into her pussy behind it.

"Mmm," Tony murmured. "I knew she was one of them girls with a real tight, real wet pussy.... man. Slow down there, baby," he said, interrupting himself. He lifted Nikki by the hair so that her mouth hovered at the tip of his dick.

Nikki flicked her tongue at Tony's cock and tipped it toward her mouth. She looked up, at Jack, when she did this. Two things were in her eyes: guilt, and hunger. They mirrored so exactly the war that played out in Jack's own psyche that it strangely, satisfyingly, seemed to connect them across the room. Jack nodded almost imperceptibly, and mouthed, "It's okay." Nikki smiled, the fear receded in her expression, and the void was instantly - uncomfortably, in Jack's opinion - filled in by a rush of raw, hungry, arousal.

"Don't get greedy, now, little girl," Tony chuckled, pulling her head away from him when she lunged with her mouth open to take more of him in. He looked up at Jack and grinned. "She likes that, huh? Sucking on dick. I can feel it in her pussy."

Something warm spread out in Jack's chest: maybe what Tony was feeling was that Nikki liked making eye contact with her husband while she was sucking dick.

He had no way of knowing which one it was; he had never finger-fucked his wife while she sucked his cock. He *couldn't* do that.

Tony was back to watching Nikki by the end of his sentence. "Yeah, I can feel it," he murmured. His left arm, all muscle, flexed and rolled like an animal in its own right, slithering further over Nikki's body so that his fingers could burrow deeper into her pussy. "She's gonna come again for me, aren't you, baby?" He sucked on his lower lip and closed his eyes briefly, growling in pleasure. The hand in her hair slipped from her head and wound around the hand she was holding Tony's cock with. Nikki, freed to go after it, seemed momentarily confused, her fingers slipping from beneath Tony's, her mouth open and her eyes on his dick.

Tony slapped his cock at her lips, against them, making a wet splatter that roiled Jack's insides again. He stared at the fat black flesh as Tony slapped it against her lips. Her mouth fell open, her tongue darted around, trying to lick him. Tony languidly whipped his cock around, his left hand still working on Nikki's pussy.

Nikki's eyes were beginning to glaze over, tension building up in her limbs. Her focus was being siphoned away by the orgasm Tony's was successfully building her up to, and so she was staring emptily in front of her, her mouth opening for Tony's cock and her tongue lapping at it when it came near. But her concentration had moved to her own pleasure, and her upper lip curled a little and she mewled.

Tony murmured something in approval, driving his fingers deeper and faster into her pussy.

"Oh," Nikki moaned, her mouth falling open. Her hips began to rock back and forth as Tony started hammering her with his hand in earnest. Jack couldn't see it, but it was obvious from the way Tony's arm and hand were twisted that he was stuffing three, maybe four fingers into her. His own eyes moved between her open mouth and his hand in her ass. "That's it, baby."

Open your mouth..." Tony lined his shaft up against her lips, so that Nikki's face and open mouth dragged from his fist to the top of his dick as her body - propelled by his hand in her pussy - rocked back and forth, making her face slide up and down his shaft. "That's it. Mmm. That's hot. Fuck, your pussy is so hot. I been thinkin' about this pussy all day..."

Nikki mewled and her face contorted, her eyes scrunching up. The fingers of her left hand, bracing her body on the bed between Tony's legs, balled up the duvet beneath them. "Oh...oh, my..." she gasped incoherently.

"Here we go," Tony said, grinning. "Mmm, yeah, I can feel it, she's gonna come. That's good honey, you're gonna need a nice wet pussy to take this on."

Nikki tipped her head to try and get Tony's cock in her mouth, and he teased her, pulling it away. "Nuh-uh, baby, not yet. You want some of that, I know. And I'm gonna put it in you. I'm gonna put a load in your mouth, and then I'm gonna put a load in your pussy, and then I'm gonna put a load in your tiny little ass -"

"Hey," Jack said, to Tony's amusement. Tony rolled his head in Jack's direction and grinned. "She's not... only if she wants to, man."

Tony raised his eyebrows, smiling. Then his face got serious, fearsome even. "She gonna do whatever I ask her to. Don't you worry about that." He looked at Nikki, whose consciousness was not even in the room anymore. "But first you're gonna get that pussy even wetter for me, aren't you?"

"Oh," Nikki gasped, but it seemed like a response to something Tony was doing, not anything he was saying. She was moaning her words, and they left her mouth as insensible syllables as Tony's cock slapped against her lips and rubbed her face, her hips rocking with his finger-fucking. "Oh... oh..."

Her eyes opened and rolled toward Jack. An expression of surprise, tinged with guilt, surfaced for a moment in them. "I'm coming," she whispered. The expression darted away into the depths of her mind as quickly as it appeared, replaced by the insentient, inward stare of sexual pleasure erupting.

She screamed when she came, and the sound of her pussy became instantly, explosively wetter. Tony grinned and rammed her from behind as she tilted forward and her legs shook violently and her arms collapsed, making her crumple, her head leaning against his stomach.

Tony grinned and played with her pussy as she howled and complained, squirming and trying to break free from his attentions. "Oh God," Nikki said, twisting her body around, forcing Tony's hand from her pussy. She was trembling, sweaty, and slippery in Tony's arms.

Undeterred, Tony moved his hand around to her torso, as Nikki twisted until she was on her back, sliding away from him. She put a hand to her head, looking stunned. "Oh God."

Jack shifted uncomfortably in his seat, eyes on Tony, who was moving the big mass of his body into another position, a grin on his face. "I think she needs a break," he said, in a low voice that might not have even been audible.

Nikki was limp like a rag doll, still murmuring incoherent words. She pulled her knees together and squirmed - it looked like she was trying to curl up - but Tony was having none of it. He tossed her arms open and rotated out of the bed, dropping Nikki's head onto the mattress and standing up before climbing onto the bed on his knees, legs spread, huge dick pulsing and pointing straight in front of him.

He climbed onto the bed, one knee weighing it down at a time. Jack opened his mouth to object, because it looked for a moment like he was going to fuck Nikki's face over the side of the bed - standard fare for porn, but too far for Nikki, and Jack himself.

But Tony's huge balls swung, inches from Nikki's head, as he leaned over and jerked her by the hips like she weighed no more than a feather, sliding her ass into place so that her feet were pointed back at the end of the bed. He shoved her by the shoulders in the opposite direction, tossing Nikki's head onto the pillows. Then he climbed over her, straightening her out as he did, moving her arms like limp spaghetti, tossing them above her head.

Nikki let herself be tossed around, mewling softly.

Tony was straddling her now, over her waist. He was up on his knees, languidly stroking his cock again. "You one of them guys who likes it when I get her pussy all sore?" he said, looking at Nikki. He dropped a hand and drew his fingers over her body, sliding on her sweat, tracing circles around her aureole.

It took Jack a second to realize Tony was talking to him. Not that mattered: he wouldn't have known what to say, and Tony didn't seem to care about the answer. "I like making them sore," he continued, his fingers moving up to Nikki's lips. He played with her lips, smashing them and distorting them, his other hand dropping to flick at her hardened nipples. "I like it when they whine about it. You gonna whine about your sore little pussy for me, aren't you, baby?"

Nikki stared up at him, her eyes vacant. She sucked on his fingers and squirmed. "It's so big," she murmured. "I don't think... I can..."

Tony chuckled. "Yeah, she's gonna whine about it all right." He drew his finger from her lip - dragging her lower lip with him so that it turned inside out and bulged, grotesque and wet, like the swollen lips of her pussy, until it snapped back to place as he continued his journey down to her sternum.

"That's all right," he hissed. "That's the only kinda whining I allow."

He looked down at his cock, which seemed to have grown in length and girth since this began. He watched himself as he stroked it, his other hand still flicking her nipples harshly. Nikki started to move her hands to her chest and Tony stopped her with a slow, deliberate shake of his head. "Nuh-uh," he said softly. "This the biggest dick you ever fucked, little girl?"

Nikki's eyes dropped to Tony's cock, and for a moment she seemed to fade away into subconsciousness.

"This the biggest cock she ever fucked?" Tony asked, without looking at Jack. He didn't wait for Jack, just grinned and leaned over Nikki, sliding his knees one at a time down the side of her body. He let his cock flop onto her stomach as he stretched out to scoot backward, then sat back on his heels.

He swatted Nikki's hands away as she moved them again toward her breasts, then toward his cock. "It is," he he said. "I can tell that it is."

Tony looked over to Jack slowly. "I can tell by how tight this pussy is," he told him, and then grinned. He looked back at Nikki. "Nod your head, baby. Look at me and nod your head, this the biggest cock you ever had in your mouth?"

Nikki, mesmerized, nodded vacantly.

"You gonna have a sore pussy tomorrow, aren't you? Man I love that, fucking me some pussy all night and watching them squirm all day,

thinking about my cock." Tony shifted his eyes to glance at Jack. "She gonna be thinking about it every time she moves."

To Nikki: "Aren't you, baby?"

Nikki's right arm was above her head, her fingers dangling onto her face. She stroked her own skin, looking almost absent-minded, and nodded. Her eyes were on Tony's cock. She was completely absorbed by it, watching him as he languidly stroked himself from base to dripping crown.

"Put your hands down on those titties, honey, I want to fuck them first. Yeah, there you go," Tony rose up on his knees and began to walk his way forward again, pointing the tip of his dick to Nikki's torso and dragging a smear of his precum from her navel to her sternum as he went.

He guided his member to the fleshy sheath that Nikki obediently plumped together for him, wriggling beneath his thighs in the most whoreish way Jack had ever seen her behave. He lay his cock between her breasts and Nikki pushed them together to wrap his flesh in her own, her nipples hardened into pebbles that jiggled in the rolling flesh as Tony spread his legs apart and started fucking her tits.

"Open that mouth for me, honey," Tony told Nikki. He used the voice of man who was accustomed to giving commands - any commands - and seeing them followed immediately. Which is what he got from Nikki, who, after a quick glance toward Jack - again, fleeting and seemingly precursory, burning Jack from the inside-out - opened her mouth and extended her tongue while pushing her breasts together.

Tony's cock emerged from between the ivory humps of her tits and bumped against her chin. Tony reached down to lift the crown so that it slid over her chin and into her panting mouth.

Nikki moaned and her tongue wrapped around Tony's cock, her lips sucking like a fish mouth, seeking to enclose it. Tony chuckled again - a sinister, smug chuckle that felt like a grater on Jack's balls.

And then Tony, in a display of pure, grotesque filth, grasped Nikki's head with one hand, tilting her face a little to aim his cock right into her mouth. Nikki arched her back and squeezed her tits together, her body moving as though Tony was manipulating it himself.

For a few moments, the only sound in the room was the rubbery, rhythmic squelch of Tony's dick pumping furiously between Nikki's breasts, with the wet glug of her mouth and throat marking the beat. Each time Tony's cock drove into her waiting mouth, Tony drove it into her right cheek. The rounded shape of his dick swelled and popped beneath the surface of her skin.

It was spectacularly horrifying. Jack didn't breathe at all, the pain of his lungs screaming for air undetected among the searing psychological wounds that clawed at his insides. Nikki's hands went to Tony's ass, but only to hold on, her fingers digging into his skin.

"I told you I'm gonna come in your mouth, baby. So get ready," Tony grunted, his fingers gripping Nikki's hair more tightly. "I gotta fire this off so I can fuck that pussy 'til she's *beggin'* me to fuck her ass."

A sharp sting made Jack's eyes water, and for a horrifying second he thought he might vomit, or cry. But the pain in his dick, now pressing uncomfortably against the zipper of his pants, was too intense for him to linger long on the thought.

When Tony came, it seemed to have gotten away from him. A jet of white cum burst from between Nikki's breasts, splattering against her neck and up

to her open mouth; then another, just as the dark bulb slid over her tongue, sending a spray into her mouth. Tony rammed his cock into her mouth for the final spurt, and tipped his head back to groan, as Nikki leaned forward, her lips sliding further and further down his shaft. The veins on the underside of Tony's dick were straining against his skin, pulsing and reptilian, visible to Jack in the final inches that Nikki didn't even try to get into her throat. She gagged, but kept her lips sealed, her nostrils flaring as she tried to breath and swallow the load of cum that Tony, as promised, was dumping in her mouth.

Tony released her hair, and she fell back onto the pillow as his cock slipped from between her lips, still rigid and full, over her cheek, and to the side of her face. A dribble of white leaked from the corner of her mouth, and her eyelashes glistened with beads of it as she fluttered her eyes open to look at Tony. Her arms floated down to the bed, limp and lifeless.

Tony played with her lips again, his big chest heaving silently. He caught the dribble of cum and drew it back to her mouth. Nikki licked it from his fingers greedily while Tony admired his handiwork, lazily tracing his fingers over her face.

"I gotta recharge," Tony said, tipping to the side and rolling onto the bed, stretching his legs out. "Whoo-wee." He propped his head up on his hand and ran his fingers over Nikki's chest, rubbing his cum into her like a lotion. He took Nikki's jaw in his hand and turned her head toward Jack. "But that don't mean you get a break, little girl."

Nikki looked at Jack. Her mascara had smeared beneath her eyes, and a long streak of gray-ish black ran from the corner of her right eye, down her cheek to her ear. Her lips were puffy and rubbed clean of all traces of

makeup, and a rope of white cum shone on her right cheek. She met Jack's eyes, but her attention was still partly somewhere else.

"You one of them guys likes to eat a creampie?" Tony chuckled, and Jack felt a pulse of alarm. His eyes shifted to Tony, who was already grinning with amusement. "He ain't sure," Tony mused, and it was unclear to whom. "You better get in on that now then, boss, before I fill her up, 'cause I'm gonna." Tony leaned in to Nikki's ear. "Gonna fill that pussy up 'til it pours right into your ass." Tony grinned at Jack over his wife's face, as Nikki sucked on his wandering fingers. "Better get on it," he told Jack, and Tony's huge cock pulsed, making it bounce lightly against his thigh.

Jack was already rising, unsteadily, as though in a dream, to his feet. He fumbled with his pants, hurrying to get them off, and then stumbled a little as he climbed out of them. He left his shirt, forgetting it entirely, as he moved toward the bed.

Tony rolled Nikki so that she ended up on her stomach. "Get that ass up in the air for me, honey."

Nikki complied, scooting her ass up just as Jack rounded the end of the bed, turning her head to face Tony, who smiled at her approvingly. "That's it, I like that, I got a good view this way." Tony's eyes drifted over Nikki's body to Jack, who was staring at her engorged pussy. "I don't like it so wet I can't get a little friction goin,'" Tony said. "So clean that up a little." He played with Nikki's hair, stroking her cheek. "I want her to have the full experience."

Jack was managing a logistic problem at the end of the bed, but settled on falling to his knees on the floor, reaching for Nikki's legs as he did, tugging at her calves to pull her toward the end of the bed. To his surprise, Nikki

rose up on her hands and tossed her hair to look back at him, but then backed herself to the end of the bed, spreading her legs wider as she went, so that by the time her knees were at the edge, her legs were spread open wide, one tangled up in Tony's black tree trunks, and her pussy lowered right into Jack's waiting mouth.

Her juices gushed onto his tongue, over his chin, and her flesh seemed to flower and spread out, soft and hot, inside his mouth and over his nose, his tongue darting into the wet, sticky mess, unable to orient itself, to find her clit, to grasp at anything. Nikki rocked her hips and pushed herself into him, grinding against his jaw. He felt the darting, hard ball of her clit, slippery and evasive, moving somewhere in the folds of sweet pussy that quivered and pulsed around his mouth.

Finally, he seized her hips and found it with the tip of his tongue. Nikki mewled when he pushed against it, and he set to a steady rhythm, encouraged by the wild electricity coursing through her body. In his hands, her muscles contracted and shook, and her flesh stuck and un-stuck, squelching and spurting. Her tiny, and as far as he knew, virgin, asshole winked at him. Tony's promise to fill it with cum echoed in his mind as his wife's moaning became heavy and she gasped and squeaked, her thighs humming against his hands and face.

"Oh, oh my God, oh, I'm going to... come again...." Nikki began this sentence almost screaming, but whatever overcame her cut off her voice for a moment, and she barely managed to say the last two words above a whisper. Her thighs shook violently and warm, sweet liquid poured from her pussy. Jack drove his tongue inside her and felt the trembling, shaking flesh trying to squeeze at anything it could.

"Don't stop, man," Tony said, his voice now calm, the kind of measured, controlling voice you'd hear from a scene commander fully on top of his shit. Jack was compelled by it instinctively, and wormed his tongue into Nikki's pussy, lapping up the cum from her folds, cleaning her flesh the best he could, even as Nikki howled and tried to move away. "Ohhhh," she whined - and Tony really was on to something here - "I can't, baby, stop, please, I need a break... it's too much..."

This made Tony, who had crossed one ankle casually over the other and turned completely on his side to watch the show, chuckle. It was a brief, low chuckle that went immediately serious as he lifted a hand to Nikki's face and stroked her cheek. "Nuh-uh," he said softly. "No breaks for you. Keep goin,' Jacky boy" He leaned in to Nikki. "Don't worry, baby. Tony's just gettin' started. So be a good girl and just take it."

Nikki mewled and dropped her chest to the bed, going limp. Her legs still shook in Jack's hands. Jack continued to diligently suck the juices from her pussy while she moaned into the bed.

"There we go," Tony said. He pushed Nikki's ass gently and tipped her to the side. Nikki collapsed and rolled onto her side, pulling her leg over Jack. She was panting, mewling, and totally disheveled.

Tony looked at her for a moment, and Jack rested back on his heels, wiping his mouth. Nikki's face was almost at eye level with Tony's cock, and her eyes had gone to it, widening, and the vacant stare was back.

Tony tapped it against her lips, but then reached for her hair and gently wound her locks in his fist. Jack's mouth fell open as he anticipated another horrifically beautiful face-fucking scene, but Tony's forearm strained and he

tugged on Nikki - gently but firmly - so that she had no choice but to kick herself, along with Tony's drag, upward toward the head of the bed.

Tony sat up, climbing over Nikki's body as he shoved her around - tossing her arms above her head, coaxing her legs together until he shifted himself down to her hips, at which point he pulled her legs up through the v-shape of his own squat and flung them out to the sides. When he was finished, Nikki's legs were spread wide, the undersides of her thighs resting against Tony's, her knees bent and her feet bouncing limply with each bounce of the bed.

Tony's cock was fully hard again, and as he jerked Nikki by the hips so that her ass rested on the end of his thighs and knees, the full length of it landed against her slit. The shaft nestled into the spread-out mess of her pussy, like a hugely oversized sausage in a pink, shiny bun.

Jack was still on his knees at the end of the bed, but he had moved sideways, slowly, one step of his knees at a time, so that he now had an eye-level view of Tony's cock against his wife's pussy. Nikki mewled and brought her fingers to her mouth. Her eyes were on Tony's cock, staring, hungry. "It's too big," she whispered, tapping her lower lip with a roll of the three fingers that touched it.

"Nah," Tony coaxed, grasping his dick and shifting his weight and Nikki so he could drag it down, working the crown closer to the entrance of her cunt. "But you gonna feel it."

Nikki's limbs trembled and kicked, as if she was being shocked, as Tony's cock rubbed over her clit. She mewled and whined whenever he struck an intense place.

Jack was shakily standing up, his eyes on Nikki. A concern for her flitted vaguely around in his mind: Tony's cock was so thick it really did look "too big" - but he knew that Nikki knew as well as he did that it wasn't *literally* true.

He was looking for a clear sign from her that she wanted to stop, and the terror of having to assist subduing Tony gnawed at him - it was probably not a possibility, if it came to that. But more horrifying and disturbing than any of those thoughts was the look on Nikki's face as she watched Tony's cock sliding down, between her legs, into the folds of her pussy, getting closer and closer to entering her.

Until then, Nikki had been staring at Tony's cock, her head tilted on the pillow and her eyes fixated on his meat. It was as if there was nothing else in the room. Jack was edging himself, walking on his knees, back around the bed, toward the chair, his cock aching.

Nikki's eyes shifted lazily to Jack as Tony's cock nestled into the folds of her inner labia. Jack glanced between the two sights: his wife's face, oddly disassociated and yet still seeking something from him; and Tony's fat cock, poised to enter her quivering, nibbling pussy.

He hadn't looked at Tony, so he didn't know what the man was watching in all of this. He chuckled softly, and, seizing Nikki's thighs, pulled her body, sheathing his cock in her pussy.

Nikki's mouth fell open as he entered her, embedding no more than his crown inside her. Jack's eyes darted to the scene: the inner lips of her pussy strained, the pink color draining away to stretched, pale pink, almost white, as her body tried to accommodate him. She sucked air into her mouth sharply and stared at Jack, eyes wide, mouth open.

Jack felt himself moving, on his knees, toward the head of the bed, moving toward Nikki's face. He had no plan, didn't even feel like he was in control of himself. Her arm slipped off the bed, outstretched but limp. He couldn't tell if she had meant to reach for him, or if she, like he, was a captive in her own body, her limbs moving mostly of their own accord.

He took her hand as he moved closer, and she gripped his forearm, and once she had clasped it, she dug her fingers into his flesh. He reached for a stray hair that was sliding over her face, and carefully pulled it across her sticky cheek to tuck it behind her ear. "That's hot, baby," he said, "You're doing so good."

Nikki gazed back at him, her mouth still open, her thoughts seeming to fall inward on their own weight, giving in to only the sensation of Tony's huge dick sliding into her.

His eyes shifted then, passing over her breasts, giving a very errant, wild thought to where the bra had disappeared to. As he wandered along her abdomen with his eyes, he was almost knocked to the floor by the sight of a round, golf-ball sized lump that was rolling beneath Nikki's flesh, just above the end of her landing strip.

Tony's cock, somehow even more massive in appearance now that it was being buried in Nikki's body, stretching her pussy until her lips looked dangerously white, the head nearly surfacing on the placid porcelain expanse of her abdomen.

Tony was not even all the way in. Nearly three, dark, veiny inches of his cock still protruded from Nikki's pussy.

"It's too big," Nikki repeated, in a whisper, staring at Tony now. Her fingers squeezed Jack's arm.

Tony smiled and shifted his weight, Nikki's impaled body rolling from side to side with him. He lowered a hand to the lump beneath her flesh and rubbed it, making Nikki's eyes flutter and roll a little in their sockets as she howled, making a pleased sound that bordered on pain.

Jack leaned over to kiss her. Her mouth tasted salty, a bitter aftertaste of cum lingering in the pockets of her cheeks. Nikki kissed him back and met his eyes frantically.

"It's okay," he said, his lips moving over hers. "That's so hot, baby, you can do it. Hmm? Can't you?"

Nikki stared back at him, her head moving in what could have been a nod, but also a random accident. As she tipped her head forward in a second, weak motion of assent, Tony's mass heaved forward, and a sound that for all the world mimicked a splitting melon - a hard, dangerous sounding cracking, followed by the wet sound of crushing fruit - filled the room. Nikki lifted her head and looked past Jack toward her abdomen, almost in disbelief, but she didn't make a sound. Her mouth hung open in shock.

"There you go," Tony said, soothingly. He traced another circle around the lump in Nikki's abdomen, now close to her belly-button. "That's it, it's all the way in, now you just gotta relax and open up for me, baby. Mmm," Tony made a few deep, satisfied sounds of pleasure, shifting his hips to drive himself into Nikki as deep as he could get. "Don't worry, honey. I'm gonna go nice and slow until you get used to it."

Jack exhaled and rested back on his heels. He had been crouching on tiptoes to lean in toward Nikki and his feet were throbbing in pain that he only noticed when he sat back. He squeezed her hand. She turned her head with

him, looking at him as if she needed some kind of explanation of what was happening.

Tony began to fuck her, slowly, as he had promised. Nikki was lifeless for the first few thrusts, other than a rattled mewl that gurgled in her throat, her eyes closing as Tony pushed back in from the very beginning of her cunt, deep into her body. After a few thrusts, though, she rolled her head back to look at Tony, watching the lump of his dick as it moved inside her, slowly.

"There we go," Tony remarked, apropos of nothing Jack could sense. "Now she's gettin' into it." He started to thrust more quickly, building up to a steady rhythm. Nikki's feet bounced on either side of her as Tony pushed and pulled her by her thighs, sheathing and unsheathing his cock, sometimes coming completely out of her, Nikki's sloshing pussy bubbling with rubbery spurts as he slithered back in.

"Uhn," Tony said, driving deep into Nikki and letting his head tip back. "Fuck, baby, that's so tight, you gonna make me come again." He let Nikki's ass slide down his knees and readjusted himself, laying his body over hers, letting her legs drop down. She was still spread-eagled, but her ankles came to rest on the bed and she lengthened them. The soles of her feet went to Tony's thighs, creating a stinging barb in Jack's heart: Nikki was the only girl he had ever known to do that, to spread her legs and put her feet against his thighs. When she did that, they rubbed, pretty and soft, against his skin, and that was what she was doing now to Tony.

"Hold on, now, girl," Tony was growling, smiling, his weight pressing Nikki into the bed. Jack was still listlessly holding onto her hand, but the life had left it, and it now swayed with each thrust from Tony, hinging at the elbow and floating, unnoticed by Nikki, in a wobbly arc.

Tony started to fuck her slowly, and Nikki began to mewl. Jack watched as she pressed her feet into Tony's thighs and rolled her hips up to him - Jack could almost feel this motion as though it was happening to him, because that was *his wife*, the way his wife fucked, and he knew every movement like the back of his hand.

Tony chuckled again, smiling, watching Nikki's face, amused. "She's a real wild cat, ain't she?" he murmured, as though it were a sweet nothing for Nikki, not a comment for Jack.

Jack collapsed onto his ass, his feet out in front of him, and stared, while Tony slowly fucked Nikki and she squirmed beneath him. He knew what every roll of her muscles felt like to Tony, the feel of her silky cunt as she panted and wriggled, trying to make herself come again.

For the fourth time. Jack was keeping track, making notches in his own mind, burning with jealousy and arousal that consumed each other in an endless cycle, like a snake eating its own tail. The bitter taste of semen that he had collected from Nikki's mouth mixed with the nectar of her juices, the aroma filling his head with disturbing emotion.

"You gonna come again for me?" Tony asked, smiling. "Yeah, she is," he said, answering his own question and pressing up on his forearms, like he was doing a plank, to better ram Nikki.

He started to fuck her hard, the sound of it echoing in the otherwise still room. Nikki began to make a series of gasping, sexual howls and shrieks, moving her head from side to side. "Oh my, oh my God," she murmured, squeezing her eyes shut tight.

"Yeah, that's it," Tony coaxed, grinning again. He took Nikki's chin in his hand and slowly rotated her face toward Jack. "Look over there baby, that's

what he wants to see. He wants to see you come with a real cock in your pussy."

Nikki opened her eyes, and for a brief moment she was in the room - again, a flash of realization about what she was doing seemed to overcome her, and panic flitted about behind her eyes - but it disappeared almost as quickly as it appeared, and she was consumed by the inward-looking, dazed, blank stare as her mouth fell open. Her head slid on the mattress, her breasts bouncing, eyes fixed on Jack but seeing something else or nothing at all. And then she screamed, grasping at whatever she could find with her hands - the pillow mashed up against the headboard, Tony's ass - as she came.

Tony stopped fucking her and let her wriggle, her pussy sloshing, her scream cut off by a wave of orgasmic passion. Jack stared at the horror of it all: Nikki, his fastidiously tidy, faithful wife, was in such a state of filthy mess, so out of control of herself, that she looked nothing at all like the woman he married.

And as Tony grinned, pleased with Nikki's squirming, and began to fuck her again - this time, meaning real business, Nikki squealing as he pummeled her sensitive pussy.

Teasing Nikki, after a few minutes he rocked his hips back and forth, making her howl. Tony chuckled and lifted Nikki's left leg up, tossing it in front of him and over her right leg, making her turn onto her side, facing Jack, without pulling out of her pussy.

Nikki was facing Jack as Tony continued to fuck her, one hand under her knees, the other braced against the bed as he leaned over her and drove deep into her. "I told you I was gonna make it nice and sore," he told Nikki,

slowing down. Tony reached for her face again and tipped her chin so that she was looking at him. He played with her lips, grinning lustfully, enjoying himself immensely.

"I like fuckin' them like this," Tony explained to no one in particular. "Gives her some time to just feel cock. Doesn't it, baby? You like that don't you?" As he talked to her, he fucked her slowly but firmly, her juices squelching, a reminder of her last orgasm. "I want you to tell us about it. Your pussy sore?" He tapped Nikki lightly on the chin. "Come on, little girl, I wanna hear it. Wanna hear you say it. Jackie here wants you to say it, too."

Nikki mewled and complained incoherently for a bit, then bit her lip. "It's so... it's too much..." she whined.

"Nah, it ain't too much. But you gotta say what I wanna hear. You tell me about your sore pussy and then I'll give what you want."

"I don't want it my ass," Nikki whispered.

Tony chuckled again. "Tell me what you want, then baby. Come on, don't be shy. Hubby here wants you to say it." Tony drove deep into Nikki and covered her body with his, pressing her legs against her abdomen. A puff of air left Nikki's lips, and she struggled to pants against Tony's weight. He wriggled to drive himself deeper inside. Tony played with her hair and licked the side of her face, biting her earlobe when he reached it. "Just tell me what I want to hear, and then I'll make your pussy all better."

Tony ground slowly into Nikki, who was sucking in shallow, gasping breaths. "I want... I want it, I want you to come in my pussy..."

"There you go," Tony said, grinning, shifting his eyes from Nikki's face to Jack. "Just say it."

"...come in... my pussy... it's so sore..."

Tony smiled, and turned Nikki toward Jack again. "Say it again."

Nikki looked at Jack. "My pussy... is... so.. sore..."

Tony grinned, and then pushed up again and began to hammer Nikki as she howled. Tony moved her right hand to her knees, and placed it wrapped over the tops and hooking under them, where he had been holding her before. He positioned her right hand under her own hip, fingers against her ass. Then, without instructing her further, he started to hammer himself into her while Nikki grunted and squealed, her pussy sloshed, and she obeyed his unspoken command to hold herself for him.

"Okay honey, here it comes, just like I promised," Tony told her, rising up onto his knees again, dragging Nikki's body with him. He gripped her hips, and, with his crown rolling like a big ball beneath her abdomen, he hammered her until he grunted and thrust in deep, letting out a grotesque groan as he emptied his seed into Nikki's pussy. She dug her fingers into her own flesh and held on for dear life, mostly a rag doll as Tony used her like a sock.

"Damn," Tony said, an aftershock of pleasure jolting him. Another spurt of cum, Jack knew, gushing into Nikki. Tony was breathing heavily, sitting on his own heels, looking down at Nikki's crumpled, used body with the arrogant, self-satisfied expression of a man who has just thrown a really good fuck into something.

After a bit, he backed himself up on the bed, his cock slapping onto his thigh when it slithered free of Nikki's pussy. A wet splutter accompanied the release of his cock, and Nikki rolled onto her side with her knees folded still, panting, listless.

Tony surveyed his work, smiled, gave his cock a shake, and backed off the edge of the bed. He looked at Jack, winked, and turned toward the bathroom, his cock swaying in front of him. "I ain't done with that yet," he called out. "Y'all got anything to drink in here?"

Jack heard the sound of water running, a slight muffle of sound as Tony evidently kicked the door partially closed, and then nothing for a few moments until a trickle of water indicated that Tony was taking a piss.

Jack looked at Nikki, rolling onto his knees, reaching for her face. "You okay?" he asked her, as Nikki reached for his hand and held it in hers. He pushed her hair from her face and Nikki blinked at him, like she was coming out of a trance. She extended her legs, and Jack's eyes were drawn to her lengthening body, to the shiny liquid smeared on her inner thighs, the milky beads of cum glistening in her pubic hair like dew.

Tony had begun whistling, and the toilet flushed. Jack felt a seizure of panic - he had so many things to say to Nikki, to ask her. None of it was related to why she was there in his room, though that dark mystery floated around in his subconscious, causing havoc with any thought it came into contact with. They more questions about what Nikki wanted, if she wanted tony to return, like he had promised, to fuck her ass. She seemed unable to take any more of anything. All of these thoughts congealed into a single, almost idiotic sounding statement:

"You have class tomorrow, remember?"

Nikki's eyes were glazed over, but this statement pulled her gaze sharply back into focus momentarily. She rolled onto her back and pushed herself to sitting, as if she had been in a dream and woken, confused. Tony barged out of the bathroom at that point, strolling, whistling cheerfully, dick swinging.

He looked at Nikki and smiled, then to Jack, to whom he gave an odd look. "I'm gonna help myself to your mini-bar here, man," he said. "And take a breather."

He strode over to the mini bar and opened it, looking at the contents without crouching to see better. "If you wanna get in on that, you better get goin', though, man." Tony looked down at his cock, which was bouncing back to life.

Jack looked back at Nikki, who was sitting with her knees folded akimbo, one hand touching her shoulder, almost caressing it, her hair damp with sweat. The vacant look was ebbing away, and with it, her body was curling and stretching in barely perceptible, sensual ways. She stroked her shoulder and then drew her fingers down her arm, her lips parted, and her eyes lit up with renewed hunger.

It took Jack a few seconds to process the invitation, a few more to act on it, as Tony selected something and plopped himself - naked - into the chair, twisting a bottle open as he did. He was behind Jack now, the heat of his body radiating into the room, a menacing presence. But Nikki was looking at Jack, not Tony, and her body was twisting, unfolding, her legs stretching out and rubbing against each other.

She wanted more.

Jack moved his hand to his pants, and Nikki's eyes followed, stimulated. Her lips trembled as he unbuttoned his pants, and her eyes went back to his.

Keeping his eyes on Nikki as if taking them away for even a moment would break the spell, he stood up and shimmied out of his pants and underwear, and moved toward the end of the bed to climb onto it. Nikki followed him, no longer hesitant, and reclined on her elbows as he worked his way onto

the bed. His cock was dripping with precum now; a glance at it told him that it was distended and reddened into a stiff, thick shaft, the robustness of which he hadn't experienced since he was eighteen.

Nikki opened her legs. A steamy, sweet and tangy heat rose from them, tinged by the acrid mess of Tony's cum.

"Is your pussy too sore?" Jack heard himself saying, his voice barely a whisper, shaking a little. His eyes dropped to Nikki's engorged pussy and his cock kicked violently. The red, sodden flesh was swollen, and the center of her pussy broke open to ooze a glob of semen that slowly rolled to her taint and toward her asshole.

Nikki lay back, angling her head a little to get it on a pillow, and nodded. But she smiled at Jack and moved her hands to her thighs, fingers pointed toward her pussy, spreading herself open a little more.

"Get up on your hands and knees, baby," Tony directed from the chair, opening his mouth to pour a few ounces of whiskey into it as a single, barbaric shot. He wiped his mouth and stared at Nikki.

Nikki rolled onto her stomach and backed her ass toward Jack, feet together, sliding between his own legs. Her ass was wet with cum, her pussy a violent red mess beneath the tidy, puckered contours of her ass. She bumped against him, looking over her shoulder.

Jack didn't need any more encouragement. His cock ached, and he groaned as he slid into Nikki. As her flesh - loose and soaked, swallowed his cock, a pang of desperate horror pulled what felt like a hot coil from his testicles to his heart, making it vibrate painfully as he sank into her to the base.

Nikki squirmed and looked at Jack, rutting against him with a whoreish enthusiasm that somehow carried disappointment in it - maybe as her pussy

squeezed and wriggled, wanting the fat girth of Tony back inside. She tipped her head back and moaned, but the moan was nothing like the sounds Tony had made come from her throat.

Sweat rose to the back of Jack's neck as a wave of heat overtook him. Nikki's pussy felt so good - so sloshy, so wet and filthy and used, and the feel of it was coming on a wave of such painful blue balls that the sensations threatened to overwhelm him. Nikki bounced against his ass, caught up in her own pleasure-seeking, and looked over at Tony with her mouth open.

"Nice and sore, baby?" Tony asked her, grinning. "I told you she'd like that." Tony didn't take his eyes off Nikki. Jack was gripping her hips, trying to slow his own erupting pleasure, his concentration painfully divided.

Tony kept staring at Nikki, his amusement fading to a serious, predatory look, his cock twitching violently back to its fearsome fullness. Jack's eyes moved wildly from Nikki's open mouth, spit gathering at the corner of her mouth, threatening to drip from it; to her ass, and the pink, screwed-up eyelet between her buttocks; to Tony's increasingly sinister mouth. He sawed at Nikki, dragging whatever thought he could cling to to try and keep himself from blowing up disappointingly soon.

Tony rose from the chair and walked over to the bed. "Your pussy getting nice and sore, baby? Hmm?" Tony dropped onto the bed at the headboard and - with a great deal of agility for such a large man - worked his way in, tossing the pillows, heaving his tree truck leg up and to the side, so that Nikki's head was hanging over his cock.

He guided it to her mouth, working his fingers behind her head at the neck, pulling on her, so that Nikki had no choice but to move forward, and Jack

had to walk himself up with her. He stopped sawing her pussy, staring at Tony's hands in her hair as the other man pushed Nikki's face into his crotch and she began to suck him off.

Tony smiled and slid his hand from her neck down her back, running his fingers over her bumpy spine. He lifted his other hand and finished off the bottle, then tossed it and lifted that hand to her ass. He grasped each of Nikki's buttocks in his hands and spread her ass, then looked up at Jack. Nikki's head was bobbing diligently on his cock, slurping and moaning. "You gonna fuck that or what?" Tony asked. As he did, he slipped both his middle fingers into the crack of Nikki's ass, over her eyelet, and down. His fingertips brushed over Jack's embedded cock as he swept some of the juices up toward her asshole, but the moment was so opposite of homosexual that Jack didn't even bat an eye at it. He was fixated on the black fingers that swirled playfully around Nikki's puckered asshole, teasing her.

Jack felt Nikki's pussy squeeze and clutch at his dick in time with Jack's caresses on her ass. He moved slowly, beginning to fuck her again, intending to drag it out as Tony played with her ass and she sucked Tony off.

"Man, just fucking *hit it*," Tony growled, transforming almost instantaneously into much more of a beast. He folded his torso slightly and grasped Nikki's buttocks fiercely, plunging a pussy soaked finger into her ass and starting to finger-fuck her.

Nikki made a sound, and Tony looked down at her head in his lap and grinned. She tried to wiggle side-to-side, but Tony gripped her fiercely and the movement was held still. Ricochets of her frustration shifted to her pulsing pussy, and Jack began to thrust into her, overtaken by an animalistic

need. He pumped into his wife as Tony slipped his other middle finger into her ass. Nikki moaned, Tony looked down again and told her not to bite, and Jack thrust deep, yelling, as the most violent orgasm he had ever experienced gripped his balls, his throat, and exploded almost painfully from his cock.

"Yeah," Tony said, enthusiastically, like the call of a football fan. As Jack poured his seed into Nikki's overflowing pussy, Tony gripped her ass and drove his fingers in deeper, spreading her eyelet open, parting her buttocks, lifting her slightly and jamming his hips up so that his cock went deep into Nikki's throat. The sounds that all of this made were indescribable, incomprehensible: her ass spluttered and her pussy glugged like boots in thick mud, while cacking, sticky gags came from Tony's lap. "Yeah, man, fuck it into her nice and hard. I told you man, she likes this, yeah, she's sucking on my cock like a pacifier, just fuck her good and hard."

It was Tony who was actually fucking her, pulling and pushing her ass, his fingers impaling her. Nikki at last reared her head up and gasped for air, and started howling. Tony watched, still grasping her ass, and Jack slipped from inside her, stunned, and fell to the side over his heels, panting.

"Oh, no," Nikki panted, looking behind her, whipping her head to see where Jack had gone. "No, I'm so close... oh," she complained.

Jack watched, utterly transfixed, as Nikki seemed to panic. The woman twisting lewdly, semen rolling down her thighs, her hair slapping against her skin in wet splatters as she whipped it around, was not his wife. Tony pulled her - his fingers still deep in her ass - toward him, and she got up on her knees and straddled him, thrusting her pussy onto his cock.

Nikki sat on Tony and started bouncing wildly, grinding against him. His sock disappeared easily and quickly into her pussy, and she bounced and ground against him while Tony leaned back, one finger slipping from her ass, the other hand sliding through her sweat and all the cum, dipping into her ass and then out. All the while Nikki bounced with abandon on Tony's lap, making herself come. Even Tony seemed surprised, watching her with a look of amusement and a tinge of bewilderment. "Damn," he commented.

"Oh, I'm going to come, oh, oh my God," Nikki howled. Jack put his fingers into her mouth and she swallowed them, licking and sucking and bouncing like such an outrageous slut that Jack had the brief, dizzying thought that he must be in a dream. It was hard to be sure: his blood boiled in his ears, muffling the sound, and he felt like he had no body anymore.

Nikki came, screeching, and collapsed against Tony's chest. Between his legs, the black column of his cock that wasn't sheathed in Nikki's pussy pulsed, stretching her skin, making her whine again and tremble. She lay her head on his chest and hugged him by the shoulders, slippery, used, and exhausted.

Tony continued to fuck her ass with his fingers. He slipped another one in and massaged her, cupping the valley between her buttocks and using his pointer and thumb to pull more juices up to her ass.

Nikki mewled and whined, twisting on his lap, but not really trying to get away.

Tony smiled and kept finger-fucking her, his cock throbbing visibly inside her. "You all used up?" Tony asked, smiling. "Nah. Not yet baby." He stroked her ass and dipped in with three fingers, twisting his hand to drive in deeper. "Is your pussy too sore now? Hmm?"

Nikki was limp in his arm, mewling sexily, almost childlike. Her mouth was close to Tony's ear, nestled in his neck, and she still jerked and trembled like it was all too much for her. "Yeah, your pussy's too sore, but now you're ready, aren't you? Tony still needs to fill that ass up. You gonna let me do that, sweetheart? You are, aren't you? Mmm. That's what she wants," Tony looked at Jack. "I can feel it in her pussy." He finger-fucked her, her ass stretching and slippery-wet, his fingers pushed together tightly to enter her and then spreading out once he was in, making Nikki howl with a sexy, non-complaining warble.

Tony slipped his hand from Nikki's ass and pushed her gently down onto her back, his cock still inside her. "No, Tony," Nikki complained, but even to Jack's ears it sounded more like an invitation. "It's too big, I don't think I can -"

Tony lifted her by sliding his hands under her back. Nikki flopped in his hands like rubber doll, her tits bouncing, as he used his immense strength to move her limp body up and down his shaft, her limbs spread and flailing. Nikki moaned and let him fuck her like a puppet for a few moments and then braced her self by putting her hands on his legs.

Tony abruptly pushed Nikki to the right, lifting her and tossing her, his cock slurping wetly out of her, so that her head fell right next to Jack's thigh. Jack reached for her hair and pushed it from her face, and Nikki looked up at him for a moment.

But Tony was already flipping her around, manhandling her like a piece of meat, getting her onto her hands and knees. "You already there," Tony said decisively, using a hand to scoop cum from her pussy to her eyelet, plunging it in with his thumb. "You all stretched out, now you just gotta take it."

Nikki fell onto her chest, her arms folded at her sides. Jack looked at Tony. "Hey," he said. "I don't know..."

"She can take it," Tony said, authoritatively, moving the crown of his cock from Nikki's pussy to her ass, lining himself up. "You can take it. You're gonna do it, aren't you, Nikki? You're gonna do it. Because you want it." Tony played with Nikki's ass again, slipping first one, then another finger in. "I can't believe you don't hit this, man," he said, his attention captured by Nikki's hole as he played with it, dipping in slowly, Nikki still, making only the occasional mewl.

"The ladies... they respond to this shit. They want it. There's nothing like..." Tony lined his cock up and slowly began to push forward, pulling Nikki by her hip with one hand while he steadied his cock with his other hand against the resistance of Nikki's tight ass. "... working it in there all tight - just relax baby, it's the opposite of what you'd think, you gotta push out - and it's all... tight... gettin' a lot of resistance... and then, suddenly..." Tony pushed, and for a moment Nikki just howled and it seemed like Tony wouldn't get in any further, until his cock slipped with an abrupt suddenness, a wet spurt, and then his hips slid forward, right up to Nikki's ass, his cock fully sheathed in it.

Tony's eyes rolled in pleasure and he tipped his head back, growling, before he slapped Nikki's ass hard with his right hand, making a loud sound and extracting no reaction from Nikki, who looked shocked and like she still didn't quite believe what was happening.

"..then suddenly, you go right in," Tony finished, grinning. He leaned over Nikki and gathered up her hair, pulling it away from her sweaty neck. "Like that, see? That's nice." Tony touched her face, playing with her lips again, smiling. "That's total submission."

He started to fuck Nikki slowly, grinning whenever she mewled.

Nikki's eyes were completely vacant now, her face relaxed, her fingers absently touching her lips. Tony started fucking her however he pleased, alternating his rhythm, staring at his cock sawing in and out of her ass.

"This is what they really want," Tony continued. "Don't you, little girl? You just want to take it until you're all filled up with cum. Mmm, that's nice, fuck this is such a tight, hot little ass...mmm..."

Tony fucked Nikki for what seemed like forever, her body sliding all over the bed, her ass slurping with every thrust. After a few minutes of lazily enjoying her ass, he started to pound her. Nikki took it, hollow-eyed, barely making a sound, even when he thrust deep and told her he was going to fill her ass up.

He groaned loudly and grabbed Nikki's hair after the first of his spurts of cum clearly exploded inside her. He lifted her by the hair, and Nikki got onto her hands, and then fell back ward against his chest as he brought her down on his thighs, leaning his knees against the edge of the bed. He grunted, violently thrusting, slamming more of his load into her. The final moments of the scene were loud, sputtering, wet, and feral. The sound of Nikki's sweaty, slippery ass plopping onto Tony's lap, cum spurting in a filthy froth, would never leave his mind.

Tony at last seemed to be finished. He grunted loudly as he slammed Nikki's body down on his lap and then held her there, his dick still pulsing in her ass. Nikki had started squeaking with each thrust, like the soundtrack of a porno, and when he didn't lift her again, she whined almost as though she was disappointed. But she leaned back against Tony and let him seize her breasts as he took a breather, his chest heaving against her back, pushing her tits out as he squeezed and massaged them.

At last, Tony grasped Nikki's head in one hand and held her ear to his lips while he spoke softly into it. Jack couldn't hear what he said; he suspected this was because his ears were ringing, full of the roar of his own blood. Nikki mewled and nodded, agreeing to something, squirming a little against him. But she seemed to expect that Tony would push her forward, tossing her onto the bed, rising up as he did so to standing.

Nikki looked up at Jack just as he did this, and her mouth fell open as Tony rose - smiling, amused - with his cock still embedded in her ass. One hand suspended her left hip by gripping it, from front to back, the way a lesser man might casually hold a sandwich. But Jack could tell by the expression on Nikki's face, and Jack's, that he was letting his cock do a great deal of the lifting.

"You sure you're all done?" Tony asked Nikki. He grasped her hip with his other hand and let her knees drift back down to the bed, then started to move his hips very slowly back and forth. "'Cuz I could probably get this back up and running for you baby." He grinned, looking at Jack, and Jack had no idea how serious Tony was about the proposal.

Nikki's eyes seemed to plead with Jack as she panted, between Tony's lazy thrusts, "Tony... please...I have to...sleep..."

"Mmm-mmm," Tony said, noncommittally, watching his dick as he sawed in short strokes. He sucked on his lower lip and moved his hands to the small of Nikki's back. "Still..."

"I think she's had enough," Jack said, touching Nikki's hair. "Haven't you, baby?"

Tony just kept rocking his hips for a few moments, which was terrifying, because Jack was only fully confident of one single thing at that time - that

Tony was not a guy he could get in a fistfight with and survive. This was always in the air, always true, but having the thought surface while Tony had his dick in Nikki's ass, it gave Jack a much fiercer jolt of fear.

Many layers below which, was arousal: he really wanted Tony to leave so he could get his hands on Nikki.

Finally, Tony cracked a smile, laughed like he had just heard a mediocre joke, and slapped Nikki lightly on the ass before letting his cock - which was, at long last, semi-flaccid, slip from her ass and slap against his thigh. Nikki tipped to her side and rolled onto her back, her legs folded over to the side, pretty much in the same position Tony had fucked her earlier. Her hand floated to Jack, and he took it and kissed it.

Tony had found his pants and was putting them on, as violently and manly as he did everything, shaking the material out and jerking it up his leg in one coordinated, rough go. He was dressed in no time, still smiling, looking down at Nikki occasionally and grinning smugly.

Once dressed, he climbed onto the bed again and hulked over Nikki's frame, working his hand between her legs. Nikki's sleepy eyes opened wide and her mouth fell open a little again, as the sound of Tony's fingers in her pussy, finger-fucking her one last time, filled the room.

"Now I don't want any excuses, no bein' late to class tomorrow," Tony told her, while Nikki squirmed and started to move her hips again, another orgasm building up, pleasure brimming in her eyes. Tony smiled, pleased with himself, and continued to fuck her with his fingers.

Then he grinned at Jack, and stood back up. "Seven-thirty," Tony said loudly. He looked down at Nikki. "That's when I want you to bring me a cup of coffee, and that pussy." Tony looked at Jack. "Not you." His eyes

drifted back to Nikki. "I just want a little bit of it. Maybe some lipstick on my cock. I like to have pussy on my dick all day." He was playing with Nikki's feet, looking like he was arousing himself again with all that talk and might strip down and start banging Nikki again.

But he slapped her foot and grinned at Jack, and began whistling as he strolled toward the door. "Y'all got a reservation for tomorrow night?" he asked stopped by the full length mirror and adjusting his rumpled clothing, smoothing it out, then smelling his hand.

"Uh..." Jack stammered. "We..."

Tony looked over at him, grimacing as he rubbed his neck. "Make one, then, fool." His eyes drifted to Nikki. "Want some more of that."

Nikki moved her feet, squirmed, and purred.

"Don't be late. Seven-thirty, you're gonna come by and start my day off right," Tony told her, his voice stern. And then he smiled. "Mmm," he grunted, shaking his head as he turned and strolled out of the room.

Before he was even out of the room, Nikki was already rolling her legs open, pulling Jack toward her. She guided his hand to her pussy. He stared at her, so stunned at first that he wasn't sure what to do, but as soon as his fingertips touched the slick stickiness between her legs, he acted on instinct and began to feel for her clit.

Her pussy was feverishly hot, and acrid cum still gushed from it. He slipped his fingers inside her and used his thumb to massage her clit, lying himself out alongside her, both of them wriggling so that they fit on the bed.

He put a hand on her forehead and stroked her hair back, kissing her face as he finger-fucked her gently. Nikki made all kinds of sexy, new sounds and

her body wriggled and squirmed next to him, her pussy clamping down on his fingers as she neared yet another orgasm.

"Is your pussy very sore?" he asked her, feeling inside her with his fingertips, as though he could absorb the sensation and know it more intimately. Nikki mewled and nodded, tilting her head to look down at his fingers.

"But you like it," Jack said, enjoying the narration, taking a page from Tony's book. He was rewarded with a pulse in Nikki's cunt, confirming what he saw in her eyes. He took her to the edge very slowly, not wanting to hurry, feeling like he could stroke the inside of his wife's sodden, used pussy forever.

Nikki eventually began to pant, and her eyes widened, and she arched her back, before howling into the abused pillow next to her face and bursting all over his hand, hot liquid running down to his wrist.

He climbed on to her slowly, while she still writhed in the aftershocks of her orgasm. She didn't even seem to notice as he spread her legs apart, and then sank his cock slowly into her pussy.

It felt like a foreign territory - hotter, wetter than he ever experienced, and sexily misshapen somehow, from use. Nikki mewled, and turned her head to the side. "I'm so sore," she whined.

"I know," Jack said, still fucking her. "That's so hot. I'll go slow. That's so hot, baby."

Nikki was being overtaken by sleep. She was exhausted - the kind of exhaustion that she couldn't fight against. It pulled on her eyelids and made her drift between layers of her consciousness, sometimes nearly asleep.

Jack fucked her as gently as he could, though as she started to get sleepier,

he got greedier and more turned on and began to fuck her faster. He watched her face as she drifted from nearly asleep, dragging herself - almost as if she felt she had to, out of duty - back to open her eyes and smile occasionally. When Jack came, she didn't even open her eyes, just smiled, and lay there, inert.

Jack rolled her over to the side and watched her face. He wanted to ask her about everything: why she was here in his room, how she was here in his room, whether she was going to go see Tony at 730 or not - whether they were really going to book the room for another night, just to repeat this all again?

"Nikki," he whispered, nuzzling her ear.

"Nikki mewled again and lifted her arms up above her head to roll herself - in the most sensual way possible - onto her side, facing Jack. "Mmm...so... sleepy," she whispered. "I have to get my... basket..." Nikki opened her eyes suddenly, sensing this was wrong. "No, wait," she said, but her drowsiness interfered and her eyelids got heavy again. "...alarm."

"Nikki, what are you doing here? How did you get in here?"

She seemed to be asleep for several seconds, and Jack was about to give up, but she purred and opened her eyes out of nowhere and smiled at him. Then her eyes closed. Her fingers played with his chest hair. "I hope you aren't mad.... the girl at the desk gave me..." Nikki's voice drifted away, took on a strange tone, "...somewhere in the back."

Jack knew he wouldn't get a coherent story out of Nikki at this point, but he still wanted to try. He kissed her cheek and tried to rouse her, several times, to explain, but all he got from her were snippets, none of which truly added

up to the whole story. At last, he abandoned all hope when she didn't respond for several moments, and was clearly asleep.

He glanced at the clock - it was almost three-thirty by then, which made his eyes go wide. He got up, turning off the lights, so all that remained was the light in the bathroom, casting a fluorescent glow into the small corridor. He set the alarm on his phone for seven, cringing a little for Nikki, pissed, and then lay down next to her.

He tried one last time to wake her up, moving his fingers down her body, toying with the messy lips of her pussy, but she didn't so much as stir.

He thought he would never get to sleep - his cock was getting hard again, his thoughts were wild, drunk, disjointed, dark and erotic and fun all at once.

But it seemed like he had only just closed his eyes to try to concentrate on sleeping, and the phone was screeching cheerfully in his ear.

CHAPTER 14

Nikki, who was a veteran of getting little sleep between calls, and getting shaken violently from it, sat up straight when the alarm went off. She took a look around, holding the phone up to shed some light on things, and apparently gathered her wits about her very rapidly.

Jack was still emerging from the depth of sleep, rubbing his eyes, trying to figure out where he was, when Nikki snapped on a light after a little bit of hurried banging about with the items on the night table. She knocked a glass to the carpeted floor and it bounced dangerously. "Shit," she hissed.

Jack rolled onto one side and held his arm out to her. "You're not really getting up this early?" he asked, opening and closing his hand to beckon her back into bed. Tony's request was on his mind, but back in the back, where he wasn't taking it very seriously. Surely Tony hadn't actually meant for Nikki to pop down to his room and suck his dick before class... not after all this.

As soon as he allowed this one dark thought through, however, it was as if the damn broke. Every dark, sinister, horrifying detail of the night before - and all of the implications that came with them, as well as the suspicious, jealousy-inducing, mystery of why Nikki was in his room when he returned *at all* - began to crowd into his mind, demanding attention.

But his cock had other plans for his energy and blood, and was unfurling like a windsock, pulsing painfully. Nikki was naked, crawling around on the floor, muttering something about he underwear. "What time is it?" she asked Jack, without looking up. She held a hand to her head. "Oh, my head,

I had too many Cosmos... here." She sat up on the bed, converted into the Enewgizew Wabbit again.

Jack reached for her, sexual advances on his mind, in his fingertips. Nikki slapped at him - playfully, but seriously. "I gotta go, it's seven ten already."

"You aren't...?" Jack said.

Nikki looked over at him, pulling her shirt on and arranging it snugly against her figure. She hadn't found her bra and evidently didn't care. She *shrugged*. "I don't know. Depends on how much time I have."

"Hey," Jack said, reaching for her hand as she started to pop up from the bed. "Wait... I want... to talk about things..."

Nikki seemed annoyed for the briefest second, but then she changed course and let her weight sink back onto the bed. She leaned over to Jack and kissed him. He was seated by then, his legs in front of him, and Nikki gave his hair a ruffle. "I forgot about that," she said, as if Jack would know what "that" was.

He cocked an eyebrow. Nikki laughed and kissed him again. With her lips close to his, smiling, she whispered:

"I went to the front desk to get a new key, because I lost it. And I gave my last name, and then she said *your* name, and I was distracted and just said, yeah, you know... spacing out, right, because APD made the reservations, and *you* usually make all our reservations, and so I just gave them your phone number and she gave me the key, in one of those sleeves, and I saw the room number was different. And that's how I figured out you were here. And so then... I called you, and I left a message, and then... I don't know, I was probably going to come up here to surprise you, I really wasn't sure what to do. But then... I ran into Tony. I don't know why, I just blurted it all

out, and Tony just acted like this was like, I don't know. Totally normal. He told me to come have a drink and talk it through, so, I guess I was like, stunned, I just did. He saw you in the bar, told me to look, and I saw you there. And then he was like: if he can see you, and he isn't stopping you, then that's a definite green light. He's just one of those guys who likes... oh, I don't know what he said... but it made sense. You could have called me any time if you wanted me to stop, he said. So... since we had that agreement, to roll with it... I just kind of... rolled with it?"

She bit her lip and brought her hand to his face. "I was nervous when you didn't show up right away -"

"I had *no idea*..." Jack said, mystified.

" - and then Tony was like, remember that he *saw* you, he's here, take a look at this room. He said you'd like it if we were kissing when you walked in, and the way he said it, he made it kind of sound like... I don't know. Like you planned it together or something..."

"We didn't," Jack said.

Nikki looked suddenly wounded. "I know. I like... get that, now. I got it when you walked in. No one can fake that kind of shock. But... it seemed like... you were okay with it. So I just... went with it." She started to crumple. "Oh, please tell me -"

"Nikki," he said, grabbing her hand before it got to her face. He kissed her. "I love you. Okay? And I asked you to do this. I just... was surprised, okay?"

Nikki sat silently for a moment, moving her lower lip beneath her teeth and letting it slip from the grip of her incisors slowly. "I liked it," she confided. "It was hot."

Jack kissed her. "It was so hot," he said, his hands becoming very grabby.

Nikki smiled and squirmed away, turning around, slipping her feet into the shoes she'd lined up while she was on the floor. "I'm going to go back to my room now," she whispered, and smiled at Jack's pouting face. "And then... should I....? Go wake Tony up...?"

An exquisite sensation, part pain, part delicious arousal, vibrated along the nonexistent cord between his heart and his balls. Nikki seemed pleased with this result. "...and do whatever he orders me to do..." She leaned down to kiss Jack, who tried again to pull her into bed with him, but she was too spry and escaped, giggling. "While you get the room for tonight again?"

Jack nodded enthusiastically.

"And can you do... yeah, whatever else? Let the kids know we won't be back? They can be home alone, right?"

"They can," Jack said.

Nikki smiled. "Okay. So... should I...?"

"Wait," Jack said, leaning forward, stretching his back, reaching for Nikki, who was stepping sexily, playfully backwards and teasing him by touching her bare chest and shoulders. "Wait, wait, you're just going to... do what he told you? And you're... okay with that?"

Nikki paused and looked up, like she actually hadn't thought of that before. She shrugged again, and Jack was pleased to see a flush of shame, or arousal, or both, on her right cheek. "I don't know, I kind of like it," she said quietly, smiling. She dropped her voice to a whisper. "I like... getting used like that. The idea of it turns me on..." She was watching him, enjoying that she was turning *him* on. He could see it moving beneath her features.

"...Tony kind of using his power over me, telling me I have to come by in the morning and service him... kind of holding my job over my head..." She crinkled her nose. "It's sorta fucked up, but I like it."

Jack shuddered. His cock was aching. His mouth fell open a little and he inhaled sharply. Nikki watched him, and then smiled, seizing on something.

"...you, waiting for us all day. Sitting in class..." Nikki moved her hand between her legs, stroking her pussy over her jeans, "... with my pussy all sore, thinking about him fucking and fucking me all night when we get done..."

She smiled, surveying the state she had put Jack into.

She put a hand on her hip and played with a strand of hair with other hand. "So I'm going to go put some lipstick on now," she told him, her eyes alive with mischief. "Unless... you want to... stop me...?"

Jack stared back at her, competing desires shredding him inside.

"No?"

He inhaled again, his mouth falling open for a second time. He felt his head moving slowly side to side.

Nikki smiled. "Good." She turned and went into the small corridor toward the door, then poked her head out to wink at him. "See you later, then?"

She blew him a kiss, turned to leave, and then popped back. "Jack?"

He looked at her, eyebrows raised, lost for words.

"I love you."

"I love you, Nikki."

She lingered a moment, leaning on the wall, smiling. His words were spreading through her, he could see it, and the effect was more arousing than watching her come. She rolled her body along the wall to turn around. "Holy shit, this is crazy," she whispered, giggling, as she left.

END

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